

PATHWAY TO



FREEDOM

TRIMESTER ONE

*How Jesus Impacts
Every Part of Your Life*

RON & KATIE LUCE 

Pathway to Freedom (Trimester One): How Jesus Impacts Every Part of Your Life
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Introduction

We want to welcome you to a journey that will impact the rest of your life! No matter where you've been or what you've gone through, Jesus loves you, and we love you. As you begin to explore this pathway to freedom, know that since you became a follower of Jesus, you have a new family, a new life, a new identity, new friends—you belong! With this new family, you are about to embark on an adventure into the deep things of God that will set you up for success in every area of your life.

The Pathway to Freedom series is meant to be a part of your quiet time with God every day, seven days a week, for the next twelve weeks. Go through this book honestly and prayerfully. Each day begins with a Scripture passage for you to meditate on throughout the day. Don't ever skip reading the Bible passage at the top because it is the foundation for everything else you will learn. At the end of each lesson are action steps designed to help you hear God's voice and apply to your life everything he's teaching you.

At the end of each week, you will find several questions for you to discuss with your connect group. A connect group allows you to join together with other followers of Jesus your age who are as passionate about following Christ as you are. You can encourage each other and hold each other accountable by talking about what the Lord has shown you and praying for each other. Your connect group leader will help guide your weekly discussions as you learn what it means to be a true disciple of Jesus.

A follower is a disciple, a learner who can apply what they learn to reflect to the world more of what Jesus is like.

DEFINITION OF *DISCIPLE*:

The lifelong pursuit of becoming more like Jesus by learning from him and experiencing his reality.

He teaches us how to live...and we are going to learn a lot!

Each week, we will cover some important habits to adopt because we are in hot pursuit of knowing Jesus and becoming more like him. We are

- FOLLOWING,
- SEEKING,
- RENEWING,
- TRANSFORMING,
- CONNECTING, and
- ENGAGING.

We encourage you to spend quiet time with God each day using these steps:

- Start your day with at least fifteen minutes alone with Jesus.
 - ▷ What time will you meet with Jesus? _____
 - ▷ Where will you meet with Jesus? _____
 - ▷ Take a moment to pray and commit your decision to be with Jesus every day.
- Ask Jesus to guide you and speak to you to prepare you for the day.
- Read through the lesson and thoughtfully answer any questions.
- Reflect on what Jesus is speaking to your heart through the lesson and write it down.
- Read the daily Bible reading and ask the Lord what he wants to show you from that passage. Write it down.
- Then end your time in prayer, thanking Jesus for another day to live with him.

Let the adventure begin!

Trimester One

As a follower of Jesus, your quest is to seek him with all your heart and become more like him by learning his teachings and living by them every day. *Pathway to Freedom (Trimester One)* provides the stepping stones to help you get free from all the garbage and hurt the world has tried to contaminate you with. Sure, you are forgiven, and you have given your heart to follow Christ, but you may still have areas where you are hurting, are broken, and feel like chains are weighing you down.

Well, Jesus has an answer and provides the pathway to freedom for every part of your life.

Think about the aging process humans experience after they come into the world: a newborn becomes a toddler, then a child, a preteen, a teen, a young adult, and then an adult. As a person grows, they have more freedom and responsibility. There are things a newborn does that a teen should never do. In each stage of life, there are different expectations.

As a follower of Jesus, you have been born again. In other words, Jesus has put a brand-new heart in you. If you just became a follower of Jesus, you are a newborn in Christ. As you grow in your faith, you will have the opportunity to become a toddler, a child, a preteen, a teen, a young adult, and then an adult in Christ. Please note that there are a lot of people who have known Jesus for a long time, but they are still newborns or toddlers in their faith. Time in Christ does not mean you are mature. You must *choose* to grow.

That is what the Pathway to Freedom series is all about: helping you take steps to become strong in Christ. *Pathway to Freedom (Trimester One)* will help you realize what it really means to live for Jesus as an entirely new person. You will learn the joy of connecting with friends, a connect group, and a local church who will stand by your side as you pursue a life of integrity. When you trust God's Word instead of your emotions, you will have a new confidence and grow in self-control when

you face temptations. As you pursue the things of God with a pure heart, the world's idea of fun will lose its appeal, and you'll discover a whole new way of thinking concerning friendships, music, and dating. As you apply God's Word to your life, you will learn skills to better relate to your parents and walk through difficult family situations with a spirit of forgiveness.

The idea behind this is to help you take small steps every day as you spend some time alone with Jesus and read each day's interactive teaching. It's not just reading but also praying, completing the action steps, answering questions about your personal faith, and being encouraged each day to connect with Jesus fully and bring to him the issue of that day's lesson. Remember, to follow Jesus is, of course, learning his teachings and doing what he said, but it is also connecting with him each day and letting him speak to your heart. Welcome to the Pathway to Freedom series!

Note to Leaders

This first trimester helps young disciples in areas like loving God, finding their identity in Christ, conquering insecurity and inferiority, growing strong in faith, finding accountability friends, belonging, being people of integrity, keeping their word, gathering with a church family, submitting to authority, living by the Word of God rather than their feelings, gaining self-control (over sin, language, alcohol, drugs, sex), listening to godly music, having a pure heart, pursuing relationships with the opposite sex, honoring parents, navigating family struggles and complex family situations, and seeking and giving forgiveness.

We recommend starting each trimester with an exercise to help kids in connect groups to commit to making an appointment with Jesus every day. These are times to pray, read the day's lesson, and grow closer to Jesus. At your first meeting, ask the group members to close their eyes and think of a time they can plan to have their daily quiet times with Jesus. Have

them consider the time they usually get up and what time they could get up (at least fifteen minutes earlier) to meet with Jesus. Ask them to visualize where they will sit the next morning during this quiet time. Where will they put their book and Bible? Will they get coffee, tea, or another beverage to wake them up? Then, in a silent prayer, have them make that commitment to spend time with Jesus the next morning.

When they open their eyes, have them take their book and, using the provided space in the introduction of this book, write their daily appointment time and place where they will meet with Jesus.

Now have each group member share when their daily appointment with Jesus will be.

Week 1

What It Means to Live for Jesus

Day 1

The Greatest Commandment

Jesus replied: “‘Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.’ This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments.”

MATTHEW 22:37–40

What does it mean to love God and choose him above all else? Take a few minutes right now to memorize Matthew 22:37–40.

What had prompted Jesus to give this reply? The backstory is found in verses 34–36:

Hearing that Jesus had silenced the Sadducees, the Pharisees got together. One of them, an expert in the law, tested him with this question: “Teacher, which is the greatest commandment in the Law?”

Jesus replied: “‘Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.’ This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it, ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments.”

If you have made the decision to follow Jesus and make him the center of your life, you no longer live for the world; you live for God. Jesus told us exactly what that means in this passage. He said that the most important commandment in the whole Bible is to love him with all our hearts because he is more important than anyone or anything else. The most important thing you can do with your life is to live for God and to love him with your whole heart.

What does it mean to love him with your whole heart, soul, and mind? List some things in your life that you love with all your heart and that you put a lot of energy into, such as sports, music, theater, or clubs.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Where does your mind go when you daydream? What do you spend most of your time thinking about when you don't have to focus on something specific?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

When you really love something more than anything else—for example, a sport—you put your energy into it. You invest your time by practicing over and over. You put a lot of heart and soul into the game. You may watch and study professional players so that you can learn from them and improve to become the best you can be. When you love something so much, you become pretty consumed with it.

When you become a follower of Christ, you can get confused about what you are supposed to do and think and how you are supposed to act. But the most important thing is loving Jesus with all your guts, all your soul, all your energy and strength, all your passion—basically with your whole life. When you love God more than anything, it affects everything else that you do.

Action Steps

Think about this: Does a boyfriend or girlfriend, money, movies, sports, music, clubs, or activities have more priority in your life than Jesus? Take time to be honest with the Lord. If something else has captured your heart and thoughts more than Jesus, ask him to become the most important thing in your life.

How, then, do you think you can love the Lord more than anything else in your life—with all your heart, your mind, and your strength?

Choose to love Jesus today more than these things that you have loved in the past.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 1

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

He Loved You First

God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life.

JOHN 3:16

If you don't know this verse already, memorize it now.

The Bible says God loves us so much that he gave his only Son. When he saw that the people on earth had a problem with sin, which infected every part of their lives, and that they desperately needed some help, he sent his Son.

He did not send an angel. He did not send an Instagram post from heaven to tell us how to find him. He sent Jesus, his Son. For God so loved the world that he gave his very best.

The Bible says in 1 John 4:19 that we love him because he loved us first. The incredible gift that God gave when he gave Jesus is an awesome expression of his love for us. The best response we can have is to love him back. That is what being a follower of Christ is all about—being in love with God and committing to loving him with everything we have.

How do you know if you love God enough to give him your best? What are some other things that you have given your best to?

Give your very best to God because he gave his very best for you.

Action Steps

To be a follower of Jesus is to be a loyal subject of the King of kings. Think about what it means to give your best to God. Write down some ways you can show him today that you want to give him your best.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Meditate on John 3:16 all day today. *Meditate* means to focus on something as if you were chewing on it and to even imagine it in your mind. You might say the Scripture passage aloud several times or write it down where you can see it often—whatever it takes to get God’s Word inside you. Let it become so real to you that it begins to change your heart and the way you think.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 2

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Love God with Your Whole Being

See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God! And that is what we are!

1 JOHN 3:1

Take a few minutes to say this verse aloud slowly and think about what it means.

The focus of keeping your Christian life alive is to remember to love God with your whole being. We see in 1 John 3:1 that God has lavished his love on us. He even calls us his sons and daughters. The natural response when we receive so much love from one person is to love them back. Think about it for just a second. God has called you *his child*. You belong to him. He has poured out his love for you. He did not have to do it, but he chose to.

The verb *to lavish* means “to give abundantly or extravagantly.” God gave the most costly, extravagant gift he could give—his Son—just so that you could become his child.



Now take a moment to read the story in Luke 7:36–50 about a woman who poured out her love to Jesus in an extravagant way. We can see a great example of God's love in the story of the woman who washed Jesus' feet with her tears. She was so

incredibly grateful because of how much she had been forgiven. She realized that Jesus loved her so much that he did not condemn her or belittle her. Instead, he lifted her up. Jesus' conclusion was that someone who is forgiven much loves much.

Think back for a moment on all the things you have thought or said or done that have broken the heart of God. He has washed those all away. How much more grateful can we be? How much more in love can we be with God, who has forgiven us so much? Our natural response after having God's love blow our minds is to pursue him as fervently as we possibly can, to live for him and know him better than we know anyone else in the world.

Action Steps

Write out 1 John 3:1 in your own words.

Think about the fact that you are now a child of God. He is your Father. Some people have very close relationships with their earthly parents, and some do not. Whatever the case is with you, you now belong to God. He is your heavenly Father, and he has poured out abundant love on you. Take some time to thank him for his love, forgiveness, and kindness toward you and for being such a good Father.

Write out a prayer of thanks to him.

Ask him to help you think of some ways to love him back extravagantly. Write them here.

Never stop loving God and make your life count for eternity—today.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 3

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Do You Love the World?

Do not love the world or anything in the world. If anyone loves the world, love for the Father is not in them. For everything in the world—the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life—comes not from the Father but from the world. The world and its desires pass away, but whoever does the will of God lives forever.

1 JOHN 2:15–17

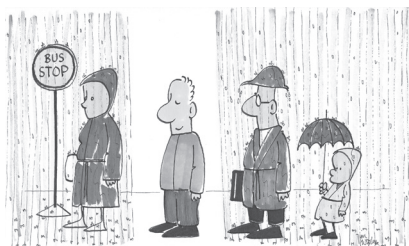
Take a few minutes today to meditate on these verses and write down what they mean to you.

Here the Bible tells us not to love the world or anything in the world. Our lives are so caught up with this craze or that fad. We want this, or we want that. We want to have what others say is fun. We want to be in this group or that sport. But many of the things we crave end up placing us in sinful situations.

The Bible says not to love the world or what the world loves. Do not look with envy at the things the world covets. List some things the world loves that you can see are clearly a ploy or trap from the devil to distract people from God.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

A lot of the music, movies, videos, and other things the world loves are anti-God. They push us away from God. They drown out our love for God. Some people decide to fall in love with God and follow Jesus, but they continue to love the things the world loves. Doing so waters down their love for God.



You can easily identify the person with the rich prayer life.
...GARY

Action Steps

Make a list here of some things you need to get out of your life to keep from drowning out your love for God.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

Pray over this list and decide now to turn away from these things. Be strong and courageous as you walk away from the things the world loves.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 4

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Do You Love Me More than These?

When they had finished eating, Jesus said to Simon Peter,
“Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?”

JOHN 21:15

Jesus was talking to the apostle Peter in this passage. After Jesus had risen from the dead, Peter was out fishing, and Jesus was on the shore. Peter ended up catching a big load of fish and realized it was a miracle. He brought all the fish to share with some of the other disciples and was sorting them when Jesus began to talk to him. He asked, “Peter, do you love me more than these?” What was Jesus really talking about?

Obviously, catching a great number of fish incredibly blessed Peter because it was going to produce a lot of money for him. He may have been thinking about how he could make some improvements to his house or buy a present for his wife or new clothes for himself.

Jesus was asking him a question he asks all of us: *Do you love me more than you love these things I have blessed you with? Do you love me more than your clothes, your phone, and your popularity? Do you love me more than social media, your video games, or your skateboard? Do you love me more than your dreams or the things your parents have given you?*

Do you love Jesus more than these things? In other words, are you willing to give them all up for Jesus if he asked you to? That poses the central question of whether we love Jesus with all that we have. If Jesus were in your bedroom right now asking you this question, what would he be referring to in your life? Do you love Jesus more?

Action Steps

Think about how much you love the things in your room and the activities you are involved in.

How much time do you spend thinking about them?

How many hours do you engage with them?

How excited are you to be involved with them?

Do you think about Jesus as much as these things?

Are you that excited to be involved with him?

What decisions will you make to reprioritize the things you love so that Jesus is number one in your life?

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 5

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

To Love God Is to Obey Him

“If you love me, keep my commands.”

JOHN 14:15

Meditate on this verse all day. What does it mean to love God? We have been talking all week about loving him with everything we have.

Jesus said here that if we are really going to love him, we must obey him and joyfully submit to him. We know that his desires are the best. He's a whole lot smarter than any human on the planet! But many people think Jesus comes to spoil all the fun and take away the zest of life. They think Christianity is about a bunch of rules to be obeyed. But that is wrong. Those are lies.

Jesus said, “The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full” (John 10:10). The thief is Satan, and he's the one who seeks to destroy our lives and tempt us to follow his ways by not obeying Jesus. Listening to Satan is how we get messed up. But Jesus has come to give us a full and blessed life. When we submit to him and the truth in his Word, our lives are filled with joy and peace because we have shown that we trust him so much that we will do what he asks. God created each one of us, and he knows what we were born to do and how we can thrive and be most fulfilled.



12/7/19

The one who invents or creates a thing knows the purpose of that thing and what it is meant to do. Likewise, God is our creator, and he knows more than anyone what is best for us and how we should live in order to thrive and be fulfilled. He hates the things that destroy us—specifically, sin—and when we obey him, he sets us free from those things.

If we are really going to love him, we have to obey and trust that his ways are best, even if we don't understand why. To love God is to obey his commands.

Action Steps

List a few ways that you recently have not obeyed God as you should have.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____

How has the Enemy used these things to mess up your life?

Pray and ask the Lord to give you understanding about how his ways set you free. Make a commitment today to submit to Jesus with all your heart by obeying his ways concerning these things.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 6

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Lay Down Your Life

“Greater love has no one than this:
to lay down one’s life for one’s friends.”

JOHN 15:13

Take a few minutes to memorize this verse and think about it. This is the true definition of *love*. We know Jesus loved us so much that he gave up his life for us. That is love.

I remember when my wife, Katie, and I had our first daughter, Hannah. Hannah was just a small, helpless baby. How incredible was my love for her! If for any reason her life had been in danger, in a second, without even thinking, I would have thrown out my life as a substitute for hers. It was a natural response. I would lay down my life for my daughter.

Jesus wants the same kind of commitment from us. He wants us to love him so much that we give up our lives, our plans, our careers, our pride, and our selfishness to love him.

Just imagine a guy in a war who is in a foxhole with a friend. In the middle of the war, a grenade is thrown at them. They stare at each other eye to eye. Without saying a word, one of the friends jumps on the grenade and is instantly blown to pieces. The friend that is still alive sits there amazed that someone would give his life, his very life, so he could live. He goes over and picks up his friend’s broken body and carries it back to camp. There he cries. He realizes that this guy literally gave his life so that he could live. That is the kind of guy you could love because you know beyond a shadow of a doubt that he loved you first and gave his life for yours. That is the kind of person Jesus is.

We know he loves us because he gave his life for us so that we could live. He is the kind of guy we can give our lives for—and not just our physical lives. We can give up the time we have here in the world so that everything—our goals, our dreams, our desires, our careers—revolves around our love for him.

Action Steps

Can you think of anyone who has sacrificed something for you? Name them.

Have you ever sacrificed for someone else? What made you do that?

What other things do you need to let go of that you haven't mentioned yet this week?

How can you, in a practical way, lay down your life for Jesus today?

Let's remember that the substance of our Christian lives is not what we do or how we look. It's about loving Jesus with everything we are and with the fruit of our lives; what we do will come from the love we have for him.

Take a few minutes to review the verses you memorized this week.

Make sure what you are living for is worth dying for.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 7

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What were the things you felt the Lord speaking to your heart this week? What things have you been loving more than God in your life? How have they been affecting you? What things can you reprioritize so that Jesus becomes number one in your life and your first love? What is the thing that is hardest to give up? Ask your group to pray for you regarding that thing.

Week 2

Becoming Completely New

Day 1

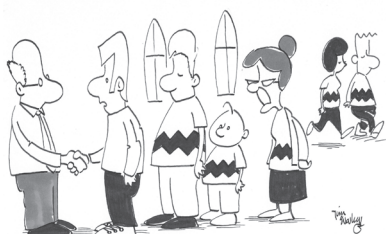
Teenage Bubonic Plague: Inferiority

Humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will lift you up.

JAMES 4:10

Arising from an overpopulation of disease-ridden rats, the bubonic plague caused the death of millions of people throughout Europe in the Middle Ages. It was known as the black death because as death approached, people's skin would turn gray.

There is a different epidemic running rampant throughout this country. It has the potential to infect the heart and home of every middle school and high school student in this nation. From major cities to grassroots towns, this disease of the heart is taking a horrific toll.



This plague, however, doesn't kill your body; it kills your dreams. It stifles your potential. It makes you feel like a loser before you've even had a chance to enter the game. Many teens feel unloved and unwanted because of this disease. It's called inferiority.

I know because I was one of those teens. I grew up in a broken home with a mom who was abused and broken herself. I never wanted to be at home because of the constant tension

and yelling. We didn't have the money for me to be on any sports teams or have a musical instrument or be involved in any kind of outside activity where I could make friends or get good at something. So I felt like a nobody and a nothing. It was many years before I found out the truth of what God saw in me, which changed my life for the rest of my life.

Millions of young teenagers try alcohol, drugs, or other pursuits to help numb the hurt. Some will do anything to temporarily take away the ache, if only for a little while, just to avoid feeling like they're worth nothing. While our world will continue to look for ways to control the drug and alcohol problem, I believe this won't ever be accomplished until we solve the self-esteem problem.

God has a goal for you. God wants to do great things through you in your teen years, not to mention your whole life. It is mind-boggling to imagine the awesome things he has prepared for you. The problem is that too many teenagers end up never pursuing the plans God has for them simply because they don't think they can. Why do they think like this?

For decades, the media has held up idols and heroes whom we're led to believe we should emulate. As the stars from the world of TV, movies, sports, and music parade before us, it's nearly impossible not to compare ourselves with them. Although the world demands that men and women achieve different standards, all people can struggle with inferiority when they feel they have to live up to impossibly high expectations.

Guys are taught to look up to athletic role models on the court and field and to macho movie heroes on the silver screen. We believe the definition of a real man is found next to the word *muscle* in the dictionary. If men were given the choice of having money or being the most attractive (and getting the girls who come with it), looks and brawn would almost always win out.

Guys somehow believe that if they do not have hair on their chest and cannot bench-press 250 pounds by the time

they are fifteen years old, they are not really men. No guy says it, but millions are thinking it: *Something must be wrong with me*. Add this to immoral, pop-culture beliefs and mix with peer pressure, and suddenly you think you're strange if you aren't sleeping with someone early in your teen years. The result is a lot of mixed-up teenage guys.

In my mind, Jesus was the only real man who ever lived. That's why I'm constantly looking at the example he set. His passion was not focused on looks but on being like his heavenly Father in every way. He knew it wasn't outer strength that made the man but the inner strength of imitating the almighty God.

But can Jesus also be the ultimate example for a girl? Absolutely! What we imitate, whether we are male or female, is his character, his inner strength that he received from seeking his Father and knowing who his Father said he was. He didn't care what others' opinions were of him.

Yet so many young women are looking to Hollywood and Madison Avenue (the marketing capital of the world), which say a girl must have looks and curves to be worth anything. Nearly every magazine that targets teenage females leaves a girl believing she must look like those models or she can't possibly survive her teen years. Have you ever wondered how all those models look so perfect? The model they put on the front cover of a magazine went through four to six hours of makeup sessions. A small army of stylists worked on her hair and meticulously prepared her wardrobe. Then she spent hours and hours at a photo shoot where a photographer took literally thousands of pictures only to have one chosen for the cover.

Even after they select the best photo from the bunch, the image is put on a sophisticated computer and enhanced even further to eliminate all the model's flaws. The picture then appears on the front of the magazine, where you see it and say in your heart, *I wish I looked like that*. Truthfully, that model probably wishes she looked like that!

It is a fake representation of reality; no one looks that good without a lot of work. Even your brother could look like that if he had that many people working on his appearance. Meanwhile, most teenage girls are left feeling like they do not measure up, like they will never measure up.

Have you ever heard a girl say, “I’m fat!”? Perhaps you look at her and think, *Girl, you are so skinny you’re going to blow away if I sneeze!* Maybe you have heard a beautiful girl say, “I am so ugly!” Before she finishes, most people are thinking, *Haven’t you ever looked in the mirror?* These types of statements prove the obvious: it does not matter what people look like on the outside. If they feel worthless inside, they’ll think they don’t measure up.

More evidence of this plague of inferiority is when young people constantly ask, “How do I look?” or “Do you think I’m pretty?” Of course, everyone likes to get a compliment, but some people are constantly fishing for them. This happens all the time on social media. Some people think that if they can get enough likes or enough people to say they are okay, then they will actually feel okay. But it’s not true. No matter how many people you have following you or how many compliments you get, it will not cure the problem.

Sometimes it is our friends or family members who make us feel most worthless. The people you love can hurt you the worst by the words they say because you value their opinion so much. Just one comment like, “You’re dumb!” from someone you look up to is enough to make you feel like you may never have any value.

Finally, there is the church. Tragically, many people are taught that God thinks they are insignificant. They are led to believe that a good practice of humility is to think they are nothing but specks of dust to God and that they should grovel in the dirt and beg for mercy. After all, doesn’t the Bible say, “Humble yourselves before the Lord, and he will stomp your head”? Read again. It says, “Humble yourselves before the Lord,

and he will lift you up” (James 4:10). That is the kind of God he is. He lifts you up because he thinks you are more valuable than any of his other creations.

So if you get all these messages from the media, your family, and your friends telling you that you are not worth much and then you hear it from a preacher, the evidence looks conclusive. You think, *Well, if God thinks I'm a loser, too, then I must really be one.*

Have you ever seen a perfect-looking car belching smoke? It may look incredible on the outside, but the engine—the thing that actually makes the car run—is about to fall off its mounts. Unless it's a show car that never has its tires touch a real highway, a car like that is useless. And unless you just want a “show life,” never being truly useful in the hands of the Master, you have to get past the external image and the lies people say and start hearing and believing the truth.

Action Steps

Consider the following questions and write out your honest answers.

How can you let Jesus fix up the inside of your life so you can genuinely feel good about the person God made?

How does inferiority affect you?

What do you say about yourself when no one is looking?

Where do you get your identity from? Friends? Social media? Something else?

Whom do you compare yourself to most often?

Spend some time practicing James 4:10. Pour out your heart to the Lord honestly. Humble yourself before him and ask him to begin showing you who you are to him.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 8

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Are You Supposed to Love Yourself?

Jesus replied: “‘Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind.’ This is the first and greatest commandment. And the second is like it: ‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’ All the Law and the Prophets hang on these two commandments.”

MATTHEW 22:37-40

Jesus is clear about what our priorities should be. He said the most important thing is that we should love God with all we have. The second command is just like it. In other words, it is so important that Jesus could not say the first one without mentioning the second one. He said you should “love your neighbor as yourself.”

Many people think this means you should love everyone else but not love yourself. They make a priority list that looks like this:

1. Love God.
2. Love others.
3. Love yourself.

If you look closer, that’s not really what Jesus said. He said to love others *as* you love yourself. That means that you must love others equally as much as you love yourself. Did you know that if you cannot love yourself, you cannot love others? Oh, you can try, but it never really comes across as love.

It sounds strange to say that we should love ourselves. In fact, it sounds kind of prideful to say, “I love myself.” Some might ask, “Isn’t that conceit and pride?” No, it is not.

If loving ourselves isn't prideful, why do so many people think that it is? Often when we say, "Boy, that guy sure loves himself a lot," what we really mean is "He is arrogant." Sadly, arrogance comes from low self-esteem. He, the arrogant one, feels so low about himself that he tries to make others believe that he is really something marvelous. He tries to push others down and make them feel weaker with his comments so he can elevate himself. Deep inside, he is insecure and does not truly love himself. If he did, he would not feel he had to prove himself to anyone.

Have you ever known anybody who wasn't trying to gain other people's approval all the time? Someone who was so self-assured that their focus was not on themselves but on what they could do to lift other people up? This is a person who really knows that they are loved by God. They have received his love, so they can love themselves. You can only love others as much as you love yourself. Look at what Jesus told Peter in Luke 5. Peter said to Jesus, "Go away from me, Lord; I am a sinful man!" (v. 8). Peter had the same mentality that many people have today: *Go away from me, Lord; I'm ugly, dirty, and worthless*. That's how a lot of us feel when we first discover that Jesus is real. We have a tendency to push God away when we realize he is holy and we are not.

But look at Jesus' response: "Don't be afraid; from now on you will fish for people" (Luke 5:10). He was saying to Peter, "I don't want you to push yourself away from me. Come toward me. Do not be afraid. And I will give you a mission in life that is perfectly suited for you."

It was nearly a rebuke, as if Jesus were saying, "Peter, get up off the ground. Stop that groveling. Quit crying and saying how worthless you are." When Jesus said, "From now on you will fish for people," he was telling Peter, "I see a great future for you. Now stand up like a man. See yourself the way I see you. You are not a worm; you are going to do great things for God."

Similarly, Jesus said to the woman caught in a sinful act, “Woman, where are [your accusers]? Has no one condemned you?...Then neither do I condemn you....Go now and leave your life of sin” (John 8:10–11). He took a woman who had a lot of reasons to feel ashamed and worthless, and he restored her dignity. If Jesus went out of his way to make her feel valuable, what does he think of you? He thinks you can be the greatest.

It is not a sin to love yourself. It is holy. It is right. Jesus said it is the most important thing after loving God. It is more of a sin *not* to love yourself because you are denying the truth of who God made you to be.

Action Steps

If you're convinced it's okay to love yourself, here's how to get started.

How do you talk about yourself?

How do you treat yourself?

Read Matthew 22:37–40 again. Remember, you can only love others with the same capacity that you love yourself.

How well are you doing at loving others?

What do you think Jesus would say about how you love yourself?

Take some time to be honest with the Lord about how you feel about yourself. Let him show you how he feels about you. Ask him to show you what he says about you and write down what he speaks to your heart.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

What Is the Real Truth about You?

You created my inmost being; you knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise you because I am fearfully and wonderfully made; your works are wonderful, I know that full well.

PSALM 139:13–14

What if we each just stopped and asked ourselves, *What is the real truth about me?*

Remember the teenage epidemic we talked about on day 1 of this week? It is the plague of inferiority, and there is only one cure. You have to believe the truth about yourself. God created you in his image. He does not make junk! The Bible says that he “knit [you] together in [your] mother's womb” and that you are “fearfully and wonderfully made” (Psalm 139:13–14). God got really excited the day you were born because he made you unique and special—another awesome example of his creation.

Now you have a choice to make. You can believe Hollywood, or you can believe God. You can believe Instagram influencers and *Cosmopolitan* magazine, or you can believe the Bible. The world wants to run your self-esteem into the ground; God wants to lift you up. If you think about it, if you believe what the world says, you are calling God a liar through your thoughts and actions. You are saying, *I don't care what you say, Lord; I still believe that I'm a loser.*

So what do you do now that you've chosen to believe what God says about you? You start with repenting. That's right, repenting. “But,” you say, “I'm already a Christian.” That's great, but you still need to turn away from your old way of thinking. You need to change your mind, to turn around. That's what

repent means. You need to ask God to forgive you for calling him a liar. You need to commit to believing the truth and speaking the truth about yourself.

Say to yourself, *Self, I don't care how you feel; I don't care what the world says. If God says I am valuable, then I am going to believe what he says about me instead of what I have always thought.*

An object is worth whatever you are willing to pay for it. When I go overseas to different countries, I love to bargain for things. Now if I leave the market after paying five dollars for a souvenir, to me that thing is worth five bucks. If I lost the souvenir, I would think I had lost five dollars' worth of stuff. When God decided to buy you back from the bondage of your sin, he thought about what to pay for you. He could have paid with all the diamonds and oil on the earth. But those were not enough. He could have traded land or a country full of cash. But even this was not enough. When he decided your value, his love knew of only one choice. He brought his own Son on the scene to shed his blood. That's how much you're worth to God: the life and blood of his only Son.

As I said earlier, I grew up feeling pretty low. I felt like a complete failure, like I would never make anything out of my life. Even after I gave my heart to the Lord when I was sixteen, I still felt like a loser. I was the guy everyone picked on in school. Finally, I got hold of one verse that changed my life. I had read it a million times before, but it finally came alive to me: "I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me" (Philippians 4:13 NKJV). And though, in context, the verse is talking about living rich or living poor, this truth has a thousand applications. I read it again and again. I couldn't believe God was telling me that he believed in me. Me—Ron Luce—I could do all things through Christ! I thought, *Lord, in a world that has always told me I can't do anything with my life, here you are telling me I can do all things!*

From that point, I had a choice to make. I could believe what I always thought was true, or I could believe what God said was true. I thought, *God, if you said it about me, then I don't care what anyone else says; I'm going to believe what you say.* My life was completely changed that day. I looked up every verse I could find about who God said I was, and I began to repeat them back to myself. I thought, *If God can say it about me, then I can say it about myself.*

God wants to use you to change your world. Don't you dare let the inferiority the world tries to cram down your throat shut you down. Choose today to believe what God says about you. You will never be the same.

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to memorize Philippians 4:13: "I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me" (NKJV). Now say it a few times out loud about yourself and write down what these words mean to you.

Say the verse again but think about and emphasize the words in boldface: "**I** can do all things through Christ who strengthens me." (We're not talking about someone else; we're talking about you—say, "**I** can!")

Now say it again but this time emphasize "**I can** do all things through Christ who strengthens me." (Not "I can't" anymore.)

Again...but emphasize "I can **do** all things through Christ who strengthens me."

Get the idea now? This time emphasize “I can do **all things** through Christ who strengthens me.” (What things? *All!*)

Now one more time with a different emphasis. “I can do all things **through Christ** who strengthens me.” Do you believe this truth yet?

This is a great way to meditate on Scripture. By saying it aloud and emphasizing different words, the verse comes alive in your heart.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 10

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Changing Yourself by Changing Your Mind

I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me.

PHILIPPIANS 4:13 NKJV

You get strength in your life by rebuilding the inside of your heart and mind with God's words. You gain strength by studying the Bible, God's Word, and meditating on it, letting it flow down in your heart. A verse like this one in Philippians will help you build strength. Say this verse as often as you can.

Now write out Philippians 4:13 in your own words.

These simple words will absolutely transform your life if you say them so many times that they explode and come alive inside your heart. This is because it is truth; it is reality as God sees it. This world is trying to tell you that it is foolish to live for God. The devil is trying to tell you that you can't resist peer pressure. Many other voices are trying to tell you that you are going to be a failure and you are never going to make it. Amid all that, God is saying, *I believe in you. I can see that you are strong. You are strong and can do all things, not just some things.*

It's not that you can sort of do a bunch of things. You can do *everything* through Christ, who strengthens you. You can be strong because you have the strength of Christ. He strengthens you.

That strength becomes stronger and stronger as you meditate and chew on his Word. It's like an infusion of power from on high as you chew and chew and chew on a verse, and suddenly it explodes, and you feel the fire and the courage and the strength of God well up in your heart. So you know you can—you really can—do all things through Christ, who strengthens you.

Action Steps

List here your biggest obstacles and the areas where you feel powerless.

Say this to the Lord and to yourself: *I can do* [say an obstacle] *through Christ, who strengthens me*. Say that about each of your areas of weakness and leave your quiet time today with confidence, knowing that you can conquer every weakness as Christ gives you strength.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 11

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

What God Says about You

In all these things we are more than conquerors
through him who loved us.

ROMANS 8:37

The Bible is referring to the fact that in the middle of every kind of persecution and circumstance, we are more than conquerors. That means we have the strength of God. This week we are talking about who you are, who God says you are, and how to become strong by finding your true identity. We are talking about being men and women who are not blown over by any little circumstance.

Find the strength that God put in you when he put his Holy Spirit inside you the moment you gave your heart to him. Think about the concept of being more than a conqueror. What do you think it means to be a conqueror?

It definitely means that you are not just barely going to make it. It surely doesn't mean that you are struggling to get by as a Christian. A conqueror is somebody who is strong. A conqueror is somebody who is a champion. A conqueror is someone who knows they have a strength that will not quit. God is looking to make you into a man or woman of God who has the strength that will not quit. Your strength will endure because you have the strength of the Holy One of Israel.

In Christ, you can say, “In spite of everything that the devil has tried to do to keep me from being a successful follower of Jesus, I know that my God lives inside me. He is on my side, and he says I’m more than a conqueror. If he says I’m more than a conqueror, then I know that I can be more than a conqueror.” The key is this: we can’t convince you that you are more than a conqueror. You have to be convinced because *God* says that you are more than a conqueror. God says that you can do all things through Christ.

Action Steps

Write Romans 8:37 on an index card or make it your wallpaper on your phone and carry it around with you all day. Say it so many times that it is blasting through your brain. Say it so many times that God ignites your heart and you’re convinced because God has convinced you that you are more than a conqueror. Recite Romans 8:37 so many times that you can explode from your quiet time with God into your school or job today, knowing that you can conquer anything that comes your way.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 12

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Growing in Strength

The child grew and became strong in spirit; and he lived in the wilderness until he appeared publicly to Israel.

LUKE 1:80

The child grew and became strong; he was filled with wisdom, and the grace of God was on him.

LUKE 2:40

Get out your Bible and read around these verses. Whom is each verse talking about?

Both John and Jesus had to grow in strength. Strength isn't something that you just pray for and get right away. You have to *grow* in strength. And you grow by getting the Bible (God's thoughts written down) planted deep in your heart. Even Jesus, the Son of God, grew in strength.

Growing in strength is a process. Make a commitment this week that strength is a character trait you're going to work on for the rest of your life. You don't get stronger just by wanting to be strong. You get stronger by continuing daily to plant the Word of God in your heart so that you know who he says you are when you feel like you're not enough. Then when people look at you, they'll see a person of strength. Your inner person is growing day by day. The same things they said about John

and the same things they said about Jesus are the things they'll say about you. They'll say, "I know this person, and every time I see them, they get stronger and stronger and stronger. Every time I see them face a temptation, they have a story about how they defeated it because they are growing in strength."

Action Steps

List some areas in which you'd like to grow in strength.

Now pray over these areas. Ask God for some specific verses on how you can get strong in each of these areas.

Memorize Luke 1:80 and 2:40. Make a commitment today to grow in strength throughout your life as you pray this prayer: *Lord, no matter what happens, I am going to grow in my strength. I want to be like John. I want to be like Jesus. I want the strength I have today not to be the ultimate strength that I will ever have. Let it be just a building block for more strength that I will get tomorrow and the next day because I'm choosing to plant your Word in my life. In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 13

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

God Makes You Strong in Your Weakness

That is why, for Christ's sake, I delight in weaknesses, in insults, in hardships, in persecutions, in difficulties. For when I am weak, then I am strong.

2 CORINTHIANS 12:10

This verse shows what happens in the life of believers when they get hold of the Word of God. In 2 Corinthians, Paul was basically saying, "I glory in my weaknesses because these are the areas that God has now made strong in me." Some people feel that an area they've been weak in for a long time is an area they will be weak in for the rest of their lives. That's a lie from the pit of hell. God wants to face the devil in a big way in your life by making you strong in areas of weakness. Paul loved to brag about his weak areas because these were the very areas in his life that became strong in Christ.

Some of us walk through our Christian lives feeling like we're barely going to make it. We often feel weak and never very strong. Too many people have a woe-is-me attitude. They don't realize that the very reason Jesus died was to destroy the works of the devil (1 John 3:8) so that we could be overcomers. The prophet Joel said, "Beat your plowshares into swords and your pruning hooks into spears. Let the weakling say, 'I am strong'" (3:10). Even the weak among us will start saying that they're strong in Jesus' name.

It's time to say, "Enough is enough!" and stop letting the devil run around unchecked inside our heads. We need to determine that we will get in the Word and that we will get

strong. We know the power of God is in his Word, and when we drive the Word into our hearts and lives, we get strong in Jesus' name.

As you take on this challenge of a follower of Christ to study the Word of God, you'll develop strength, and as you develop strength, you'll have more passion to get back into the Word of God. The stronger you get, the more you will want the Word. And the more you get into the Word, the stronger you'll get.

Action Steps

List some areas in which you have felt weak.

Write out 2 Corinthians 12:10 on an index card or make it your phone's wallpaper. Confess it over all these areas you have written down and quote it every time you feel weak today. Start saying, "I am strong!"

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 14

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss what you learned about identity this week. What is identity, and where do you get it? What makes you feel inferior? What does God say you're worth, and how can his opinion of you change your perspective? How can you change your own opinions about yourself in light of God's opinion, which you can find in his Word? What habits can you put in your life to grow in strength? Discuss what this phrase means to you: "If God says it about me, I can say it about myself."

Week 3

Friendships That Matter

Day 1

A New Level of Friendship

A friend loves at all times,
and a brother is born for adversity.

PROVERBS 17:17

What is an accountability friend? This is someone who is willing to hold you responsible to account for your actions. Having an accountability friend means letting someone else have a say in what you do with your life. They are there to hold you accountable to do what you've said you want to do.

An accountability partner or friend is someone you trust to love you at all times—in the good times as well as the bad times. They love you when you are on rocky ground and when you are sailing victoriously.

One of the problems a person encounters when they commit their life to Christ is that many times, they continue to surround themselves with people who do not love the Lord. They feel like they can't be themselves around other people and can't let others know everything that is going on in their life. If they do something to really mess up in their walk with God, they keep it to themselves and develop a list of secrets.

An accountability friend stands by you whether you do right or wrong, but they also love you too much to let you suffer in your secrets. Instead, they will tell you the truth and help you get your act together.

As a follower of Christ, you cannot afford to be a lone-wolf Christian. Christianity is not about coming forward to the altar, crying and praying, hoping you can change your life by yourself. It's about getting connected with other people who have the same fire and passion to change the world through

Christ. Christianity is about locking hearts with people and saying, “We love each other too much to let each other backslide. We love each other too much to let each other get into sin and not say something about it.” It’s about getting in each other’s faces and helping each other go live for God.

If you isolate yourself from others, you become much more vulnerable to an attack from the Enemy. Satan is a predatory creature, and it’s much easier to take down prey when they’re alone. You must lock arms and lock hearts with several other people who are committed and accountable to each other and say to them, “If you see anything in my life that doesn’t look like Jesus, I want you to tell me about it. I want to look like Jesus so much that I don’t want anything to get in my life that I don’t deal with.” This is the purpose of an accountability friendship: to help you fight your battles.

A real friend will love you at all times (Proverbs 17:17) even though they might see something that is not going very well in your life. They’ll love you enough to tell you about what’s going on. It’s not about judging each other; it’s about being committed in good times and bad.

Action Steps

Meditate on Proverbs 17:17 today. Pray and ask God for an accountability friend or two who can really push you to be more like Jesus.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 15

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

The Value of an Accountability Friend

When Peter came to Antioch, I told him face to face that he was wrong. He used to eat with Gentile followers of the Lord, until James sent some Jewish followers. Peter was afraid of the Jews and soon stopped eating with Gentiles. He and the others hid their true feelings so well that even Barnabas was fooled. But when I saw they were not really obeying the truth that is in the good news, I corrected Peter in front of everyone and said: Peter, you are a Jew, but you live like a Gentile. So how can you force Gentiles to live like Jews?

GALATIANS 2:11–14 CEV

An accountability partner keeps you from getting off track and doing things that will be harmful to you in the long run. Some things might seem right in your eyes, but according to Scripture, they are not right (Proverbs 21:2). It's not about judging each other and getting mad at each other. It's about helping each other go toward the Lord hand in hand.

Here in Galatians, you can see a very specific example of this kind of accountability. Basically, Paul got in Peter's face and said, "You're being a hypocrite. You're saying that you're not better than these guys, but then you eat only with the Jews and not with everyone else." Paul faced him right in front of everybody.

That doesn't mean that if you are an accountability partner, you need to face your friend or embarrass them in front of everyone. You certainly can—and perhaps should—talk with them one-on-one. But you need to be honest enough to speak the truth to them. As an accountability friend, you can't force

someone to change, but you can help them recognize when they are doing something wrong.

Paul essentially said, “Peter, this is not right. And if you think it is, I need you to give me an accounting. Explain to me why you are doing this if you think it is so right.” If your friend can’t give an accounting for their actions or attitude, they should be prepared to admit that they are wrong and are open to change.

Action Steps

Having an accountability friendship is very scriptural and godly. In fact, it helps you become more like God. It’s about loving each other enough to speak the truth to each other’s face. Describe a time you have had someone in your life get honest with you about something and helped you make a better decision or be a better person.

Spend some more time praying throughout the day about someone you would like to invite into your life to keep you accountable.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 16

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Your Closest Friends: On Fire for God

Do not be unequally yoked together with unbelievers. For what fellowship has righteousness with lawlessness? And what communion has light with darkness? And what accord has Christ with Belial? Or what part has a believer with an unbeliever?

2 CORINTHIANS 6:14–15 NKJV

As you get serious about really following Jesus, you're going to have to limit the amount of time you spend with people who are of the world. Some people say we need to witness to these people and share the Lord with them. That's absolutely true. The most important reason for you to spend time with people who aren't followers of Christ is to show them what Jesus is like. But you can't be out on a limb all by yourself trying to get them to know the Lord, hoping they'll become followers of Christ so you'll have friends who also follow Jesus.

The Bible says in 2 Corinthians that we are not to be yoked together with unbelievers (6:14). In other words, don't hang out with them too much by yourself, don't become best friends with them, don't let their ideas infiltrate your mind, and don't let them influence you. If you've been hanging around people who don't know Jesus, who don't love God with all their hearts, or who are lukewarm, you may have to reevaluate your friendships and how much time you spend with them. It's not like you need to get rid of all your old friends, but you must have a new posse of friends around you who are following Jesus like you are.

For the most part, hang out with people who love God. You can strike up accountability friendships only with people who love God with all their hearts and who are going to hold you to do the same thing. They should be your closest friends. Join a friend group of on-fire, blazing followers of Christ who will push you closer to God and will help you be the best person you can be. You have to get locked in with people to whom you can be accountable about your faith. Then together you can reach out to those who don't yet know the Lord.

The Bible is very clear about the relationships Christians should have with unbelievers. It's not merely an issue of whether you should or shouldn't hang out with them. The Bible is asking you to examine what you really have in common with them. How could they be your best friends when what's deepest in your heart is completely different from what's in their hearts?

Action Steps

Think about 2 Corinthians 6:14–15 today. Chew on it all day. Memorize the first sentence, meditate on it, and think about any friendships you may need to reevaluate. Have you gotten so close to some unbelievers that they've almost (or already) influenced you? If so, how have they influenced you?

You may need to cut off these unhealthy friendships or just decide to spend less time with those people.

The saying “You become like the top five people you spend most time with” is true. Choose whom you would like those top five people to be in your life.

Keep praying for the accountability friends God is going to bring your way. He’s going to use your accountability friendships to change your life.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 17

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Paul's Friends

Paul and Barnabas spent considerable time there, speaking boldly for the Lord, who confirmed the message of his grace by enabling them to perform signs and wonders.

ACTS 14:3

This accountability friendship idea is not just a casual suggestion. It is essential for growing in your walk with God. The devil has long used the lack of accountability friendships to destroy peoples' lives. Most people have a hard time being honest with others. They want to cover everything up and pretend it's all right. They want to do everything alone. Then they wonder why they are falling away from their faith and feel so far from God.

Basic Christian survival mode requires finding an accountability friend, but it takes some effort on your part. You have to do it if you're going to keep your passion for God. Let's look at the scriptural examples of Paul and Barnabas or Paul and Silas. You can read about them in Acts 13, 14, and 15.

Paul went all over, traveling from village to village and town to town, starting churches and ministering like crazy. He was an awesome, fiery man of God, but he never went by himself. He always had someone around him like Barnabas, Silas, or Timothy. Each man was relentless about pushing each other to go for God. If anyone could have stayed strong in the Lord on his own, it was Paul. However, Paul didn't trust himself to go alone. He knew an evil world was out there with way too many temptations to think that anyone could go at it alone.

Yes, you have the power of God and the Word of God living inside you, but we all need outward motivation to keep our

hearts and our minds focused. Paul took other people with him to help keep his heart and his mind focused on Jesus. It's funny how many fewer temptations you're drawn into when other people are around. You would never even think about certain sins with other committed Christians around you.

Action Steps

Take some time today to meditate on the friendships in the verses we've been talking about for the past few days. Then list two or three people, no more than that, whom you think could really be accountability friends like Paul had with Barnabas or Silas.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Pray that God will put the same thing on their hearts and see if God makes a divine connection just like he did with Paul and Barnabas.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 18

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

In-Your-Face Friendships

You can trust a friend who corrects you.

PROVERBS 27:6 CEV

Accountability friendship is about being willing to get into each other's business. This is not simply saying, "Well, I'll pray for you, my friend." Some of your Christian friends may be living the Christian cliché where they act like everything is all right, but inside, they're not right at all. They spend so much time involved in sports, playing video games, or doing other activities that they don't feel very close to anybody else anyway. There are people they say they're close to, but it's just because they go to the same church or youth group. But they don't really know each other.

Accountability friendships are different. They are deeper friendships. Accountability friends say, “I’m going to get in your face, and I’m going to let you get in my face. If you see anything in my life that doesn’t line up with the Word of God, I expect you to call me out about it and then encourage me to step up.” Another term for this is *in-your-face friendships*.



In these friendships, you give someone permission to hold you accountable and to ask you how your quiet time was, what God spoke to you, and what's going on in your life. It could be

as simple as asking, “What’s going on with you and the Lord?” If you say, “Well, nothing really,” then your accountability friend says, “Wait just a minute. Aren’t you growing in the Lord? Don’t you want to make a difference with your life?” Your accountability partner gets in your face and says, “Listen, I will not stand for this. I love you too much to let you half-heartedly go through your quiet times and coast through your life.” They also ask more deeply, “What’s wrong? Where are you off track? How can I help you? How can I pray for you?”

Think back to the times when somebody has gotten in your face and kept you from making a really big mistake. That is what accountability friendships are about. These are people you allow to get real with you not because they have to but because you want them to. They help keep you from making big mistakes.

Action Steps

Write down a few areas in which you know that you need some accountability.

Keep praying over those people you listed yesterday whom God might want to use in your life to be an accountability friend to you.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 19

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

What to Talk About with an Accountability Friend

“No longer do I call you servants, for a servant does not know what his master is doing; but I have called you friends, for all things that I heard from My Father I have made known to you.”

JOHN 15:15 NKJV

This is Jesus’ definition of *friendship*: Things that he heard his Father speak in private, he made known to his disciples. He told his followers about them. He told them the deepest things in his heart that he wouldn’t tell anyone else about. Then they were qualified to be his friends.

These accountability friendships you’re developing should be with people with whom you are committed to sharing your heart, the very deepest part of yourself. Two or three people should really know everything about you—your deepest fears, desires, and longings. These are not people with whom you should ever allow yourself to be fake.

In order for his apostles to qualify to be Jesus’ friends, he shared with them the deepest things in his life. If you want people to really pray for you, you have to tell them the most important prayer matters you are experiencing. Don’t just ask them to pray for you about the surface issues. Start sharing your very gut with them and let them seriously pray for you about things that really matter. In other words, it’s not just, “Pray for me because I have a test in school this week.” Rather, you pray for each other about a friendship at school, a struggle with your parents, any insecurities about yourself, certain

temptations, or whatever you are going through that is really affecting who you are and your walk with Christ.

When you do that, you allow somebody the privilege of coming into your life. Then they can really be a true friend to you because they know what is going on, and they can really care about you.

Accountability friendships allow you to develop the kinds of friendships that can end up changing the world, the kind of friendships where you connect heart-to-heart and soul-to-soul. It's not some surface "Christian" friendship, but you are people who really care about each other. You share your hearts on an ongoing basis and hold each other accountable to keep pressing toward the Lord.

Action Steps

Take some time to list some things here that you've wanted to share with other people but you've never found someone who cared enough to really listen or someone whom you trusted.

There is going to be a time when God will give you some friends with whom you can really share deep things from your heart. Keep asking. He has promised to hear you and answer.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 20

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

How to Make Friends

A man who has friends must himself be friendly,
but there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother.

PROVERBS 18:24 NKJV

If you're going to have friends, you have to be friendly. How do you find an accountability friendship? You don't find it by staying in isolation somewhere and hoping that God will bring someone to you. God will bring someone into your life, but you have to get out there and reach out to people.

You must show that you want to be this kind of friend to somebody else. You're not just looking for somebody to reach out and wait on you or listen to you. You should also be willing to reach out and wait on them, listen to them, and serve them.

If you want somebody else to be interested in your life and help push you toward the Lord, you start by showing that you're interested in somebody else's life. You need to be like a heat-seeking missile going after the right kind of friend. Don't settle for casual associates whom you just happen to meet at school. *Be intentional with whom you get to know.*

Think about the kind of person you want as an accountability partner. They should be somebody you look up to. You see stuff in their life that looks like Jesus, and you want it in your life.

Look for somebody you want to be around because you know that their character will rub off on you. Find someone with wisdom to speak into your life. It doesn't have to be an older person, just someone you admire because you see God in their life. Since your friendship will be incredibly deep and you

will share some very personal secrets, this person should be the same gender as you.

Continue to pray for your new friend now and ask God to begin to mold their heart and draw them toward you as an accountability friend. Be friendly now and show yourself as friendly to them. Don't dump this heavy accountability idea on a person right away. Get to know them first. Talk to them about what is going on in their heart and see what you can pray with them about. Later, you can talk to them about being accountable to one another. Say something like, "Listen, I want you to get in my face about stuff. Maybe we could get in each other's faces and really push each other toward the Lord."

Now is your chance to go for it. Don't just sit there thinking about it anymore. Don't wait for someone to come up to you and ask you to be their accountability partner. You're going to have to go after it. It's not an option. It's not just a good idea. It's something you're going to have to relentlessly pray for and pursue.

Whatever your age, you're not too young to have an accountability partner who stays in your face. Somebody who is going to change the world must be hooked in with other people. Your closest friends should be people who are blazing maniacs for Jesus and who want to change the world just like you do.

Action Steps

Now commit to going out and talking to the people you've been praying about. Talk to them and pursue accountability friendships in a very specific way. Decide right now what you plan to do in this accountability friendship. God bless you. You can change the world!

I commit to being a follower of Christ and to surrounding myself with at least one or two accountability friends who will help push me toward the Lord. I will stay connected with

accountability friends all through my teen years. They can stay in my face, and I will stay in their faces so that by the time I am twenty, I will have developed solid friendships that have pushed me to become all that I can be as a follower of Christ.

Sign your name

Date

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 21

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss what accountability means to you. What kind of people make great accountability friends? What does the phrase “Get in your face” mean, and what’s the best way to do that and keep a friend? What kind of relationships should you have with unbelievers according to Scripture? Do you think that maybe some of the people in this group could be some of your accountability friends?

Week 4

The First Step toward Becoming Like Jesus: Integrity

Day 1

What Is Integrity?

A good name is more desirable than great riches;
to be esteemed is better than silver or gold.

PROVERBS 22:1

Take a few minutes right now to memorize this verse and really chew on it. Write out what you think it means.

This week we are talking about integrity. Proverbs 22:1 is essentially about integrity. When you have integrity, you have a good name. You have a strong reputation. You have a name that people associate with something positive because everything you do and say communicates that you keep your word. According to Proverbs 22:1, a good name is more important than silver or gold. Having a good reputation, having integrity, and being someone whom everybody can count on are more important than having silver, gold, or any other material riches you could possibly want in life.

Living a life of integrity starts in our heart. It's not about trying to impress other people with how godly we can be but rather about knowing that we live for an audience of one. All the time. In everything we do, whether we're with people or alone where no one can see us, God is there, and we choose to do the right thing because we want to please him.

Most of the time our society looks up to people who are good at lying and cheating. If you can get away with bad things, the world honors you, but the kingdom of God is different. God wants you to walk in truth in everything you say, everything you do, and everything you're a part of. In God's eyes, the purer, the more truthful, and the more faithful you are, the more honorable you are.

Action Steps

It's time to adopt God's value system. It's time to start valuing a good name and a life full of integrity. Take a moment to list some things here that you think you could do that would help you to be more like Jesus and give you a good name.

Your accountability partner can help you establish integrity. They will get in your face anytime you look like you're not keeping your word or if your name is getting tarnished because you're not representing Christ. Make these words the prayer of your heart today and all week: *Lord Jesus, please make me a person with a good name. I want to represent you in a way that will honor you. In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 22

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Keeping Your Word

“All you need to say is simply ‘Yes’ or ‘No’; anything beyond this comes from the evil one.”

MATTHEW 5:37

Being a person of integrity is being someone who means what they say and who says what they mean. It's being somebody who follows through on what they say they are going to do. It used to be that a handshake was as good as a contract. You didn't need a written contract; you just gave your word and shook on it, and people could count on you. But today, lawyers draw up all kinds of contracts. You have to read the fine print, sign on the dotted line, and have the paper notarized. This process has become necessary because people can't trust each other to keep their word.

Problems with integrity started way back before Jesus' time. People started swearing by things instead of promising something in their own name: “I swear I'll do this” or “I swear I'll do that” or “I'll swear by heaven this and that.” Their name wasn't good enough to put on the line, so they swore by heaven or by hell. Jesus said that's not the kind of people we're supposed to be. Don't swear by heaven or by hell. Be a person who is so full of integrity that people can trust you when you simply say, “Yes, I'll do it” or “No, I won't.”

For some people, doing what they say is simply a matter of remembering. They may give an excuse: “Well, I am sorry. I just forgot to do it” or “I didn't remember that I promised to quit doing that thing.” But that's not good enough. People of integrity find a way to remind themselves that they committed

to something. When their word and their name are on the line, they won't do anything to tarnish it.

For other people, not keeping their word is a matter of deliberately lying or committing to doing something that they either have no intention of completing or have no way to complete. They may say yes to a thing, but then when no one is looking, they won't do it.

People of integrity are the same in private as in public. What others see is what they get. It's not an act that people put on so others will approve. Sadly, many people aren't authentic about their Christian lives. Sure, they do things to look spiritual in front of others. You can see them shouting and screaming, "Jesus!" and wearing Christian T-shirts. They outwardly say, "Yes, I am a Christian. I love God." But they don't spend any time with the Lord. In their heart of hearts, they think about garbage. They're involved in sin. They are not really crying out for God. They are hypocrites. When people break their integrity, it's hypocritical. But for people who truly follow God with all their hearts, there is no difference between who they say they are and who they act like when no one is watching, between what they say they will do and what they actually do.

We have all broken our word at some time in our life. As followers of Christ, we are to be different. We admit our sins, ask forgiveness, and seek to make things right.

Action Steps

Describe a time that you kept your word, even when it was uncomfortable or difficult.

List some situations in which you have broken your word.

What are some actions you can take this week to make things right where you have broken your word?

You may have heard the story of Zacchaeus (Luke 19:1–10) and how he repented before Jesus. He said, “If I have cheated anybody out of anything, I will pay back four times the amount” (v. 8). So as a young person pursuing integrity, ask the Lord to forgive you for the ways you’ve broken your word and seek ways to make up for commitments that you’ve broken in the past. Follow through on these actions today and watch God’s blessing start to come on your life.

Also, share these things with your accountability partner and pray for each other to keep your word.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 23

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

God Is Our Example

“By myself I have sworn, my mouth has uttered in all integrity a word that will not be revoked: before me every knee will bow; by me every tongue will swear.”

ISAIAH 45:23

In this verse, God is helping us understand what integrity is all about by defining it for us and by describing his own integrity. He is giving us his word on something. He is saying, *Listen, let me tell you the way it is. When I give my word, I never take it back.* Isn't it good to know that God never lies? When he says something, you can count on it. You can take it to the bank. He always does what he says he's going to do. In this case, he was saying that one day every knee is going to bow and every tongue is going to confess that Jesus is Lord. God was giving his word on something, and his word will never be revoked. When he says something, it's as good as done.

As followers of Christ, we need to pursue the same kind of integrity in our lives. When we say something, it should be as good as done. No one should ever have to wonder whether we're going to keep our word or not. When we give our word, we lay our lives, our reputation, and our credibility on the line. Let's not be people who say one thing and then do another.

Don't make commitments that you can't keep. When you give your word, be clear that you are going to keep it. This goes for the smallest things to the biggest things. For example, when you tell somebody you will pray for them, do you really pray for them? Or is it something that you say but don't really mean? One of the things I do is when someone asks me to pray for them, I say, "Let's pray right now." Then I actually pray for them at that

moment. I do not commit to continuing to pray for a person unless I will really do it because I don't want a long list in the back of my mind of all the people I have committed to praying for but have forgotten. That's why I usually do it right at that moment. It helps me to be a person that does not break his word.

When you tell a friend that you're going to be at a meeting, do you actually make it to the meeting on time? When you tell your friend that you're going to meet them at a restaurant at a certain time, do you actually make it there on time? It's a matter of keeping your word and deciding what kind of a person you're going to be.

Action Steps

Describe a person you know who always lives with integrity. What impresses you about them?

Start practicing integrity by making small commitments and being faithful to every single commitment that you make. Every time you tell somebody you are going to do something, go above and beyond to do it. If you don't do anything else, make sure that you fulfill the commitment. Watch the confidence you start gaining in your life today.

By the way, what can you do to make up for the times in the past when you haven't kept your word? Keep working on that!

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 24

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Integrity of Heart

“As for you, if you walk before me faithfully with integrity of heart and uprightness, as David your father did, and do all I command and observe my decrees and laws, I will establish your royal throne over Israel forever, as I promised David your father when I said, ‘You shall never fail to have a successor on the throne of Israel.’”

1 KINGS 9:4–5

We’re talking about integrity this week. We’re talking about being a person of your word. We encourage you to get with your accountability partner and say, “I want you to help me keep my heart pure. Will you help me keep my word? Anytime you see me not living up to what I say I am going to do, whether in my heart for the Lord or in my relationships with other people, bring it to my attention. I want to always keep my word.”

In today’s passage of Scripture from 1 Kings, God made a promise. Rewrite the promise as it applies to you today.

He said, “If you,” then “I will.” He was describing the benefits of having integrity and defining *integrity* a little bit more clearly. God told Solomon how he would bless him if Solomon would have integrity of heart like his father, David, had.

Isn’t it interesting that integrity is always linked to the heart? If you have a pure heart, a heart after God, then your life

will show it by the way you live with integrity. If you don't live with integrity—if you're not the same on the inside as you are on the outside or if you're different in private from what you are in public—then it shows that your heart is not really pure. Over and over again, the Bible links integrity to the heart, and God calls us to be pure in heart: “Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God” (Matthew 5:8).

Action Steps

Heart and soul, through and through, you need to be consistent. If you find areas in your life where you haven't shown integrity, take a moment to read Psalm 51 and cry out to God right now for a clean heart just like David did. Write down your prayer here.

Change starts with us getting honest with God. Don't be discouraged. It takes practice to get to where you won't slip up anymore. But the next day you can go back and keep your word more regularly in that specific area. With prayer and practice, you'll get better and better, and you'll establish the habit of always keeping your word whenever you give it.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 25

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

God Judges Our Hearts

The LORD shall judge the peoples; judge me, O LORD,
according to my righteousness,
and according to my integrity within me.

PSALM 7:8 NKJV

Take a few minutes to meditate on Psalm 7:8. Write out what it means to you.

God judges us by our integrity and by how true we are to our word. When we make a commitment to him, he wants to know if we will really keep our word. When we give our word and make a commitment to somebody else, do we keep that word? God wants people who don't have corrupt hearts, scamming this thing and trying to get away with that. He is looking for a generation he can truly be proud of. He is looking for people who keep their word just as he keeps his word.

In Psalm 7, David asked God to judge him according to David's integrity. He essentially said, "Look at my life, Lord. I have been keeping my word just like I said I would." In 1 Chronicles 29:17, David said, "I know, my God, that you test the heart and are pleased with integrity. All these things I have given willingly."

When you keep your word, God gets really happy. He is so excited and pleased because you've become more like him. And nothing gets God more excited than watching you become more like him. That's why he commands blessing toward you.

Action Steps

Integrity pleases God. One of the biggest goals in my life is to make God smile. We believe all of us should desire that above everything else. Just one smile from the awesome, living God who created the whole earth is worth a lifetime of passion and labor striving to please him. Do everything you can today to be a man or woman of integrity and to please God as he looks through you and judges your heart. Then you can say to God, as David said, *You have judged my heart and are pleased with my integrity.*

Think of one thing you can do today to be more like Jesus and to make God smile.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 26

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Integrity Is Our Standard

The integrity of the upright guides them,
but the unfaithful are destroyed by their duplicity.

PROVERBS 11:3

What's the main point that comes through to you in this verse?

When you say something, people should be able to rely on it. We have such a huge problem with situational ethics these days that some people don't even know what integrity means. According to situational ethics, whatever feels good at the time is okay to do. It means that someone will judge what's right or wrong whenever they're in a particular situation.

The Bible, however, talks about letting our integrity guide us. In other words, we decide in our hearts that we want to follow God, and we find out what's right in his Word. Then we let that standard guide our decisions and don't just do what seems right in the moment. We base our judgments not on how we feel in a situation but on what we know is right based on Scripture. We don't have to flip back and forth: *Well, what decision should I make this time? Should I try to sneak out or not? Should I try to cheat or not? Should I keep the extra change that somebody gave me or not?*

When you have integrity, people will be so blown away by your purity and honesty that they'll want to know what you

have on the inside. Every day you have to make a thousand decisions—what you’re going to wear, what you’re going to do, whom you’re going to hang with. You face peer pressure all the time. God is looking for you to be the kind of person who is guided by integrity. In other words, God himself, your friends, and even you don’t have to wonder what you are going to do in any given situation. You have this confidence because you let the integrity of your heart guide your decisions and not just whatever happens to be popular at that moment.

Action Steps

Do you have a decision to make right now? What would situational ethics tell you to do?

What would integrity tell you to do?

Right now, you can make the decision based on your integrity. Think about the commitments you’ve made to the Lord in the past. Think about your commitment to live with a pure heart, your commitment to be free of sin, and your commitment to follow God with all your heart. Keep the commitments fresh

and alive in your heart and mind all day and let the commitments guide all the decisions you make today.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 27

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Integrity Brings Security

Whoever walks in integrity walks securely,
but whoever takes crooked paths will be found out.

PROVERBS 10:9

This verse describes one of the most incredible advantages of walking with integrity. Please write out what this verse means for you today.

The Bible promises that if you have integrity, you will walk securely. What does that mean? You won't have to worry about the devil picking you off. You won't have to worry about getting stabbed in the back. You won't have to wonder, *Did I tell this lie to one guy and that lie to another person?* Some people have made so many different commitments interwoven with lies to so many people that they don't know to whom they've given their word or about what. As a result, they never know what's going to come up and bite them.

But the Bible promises that if you walk with integrity, you'll walk securely. People won't be pushing you over. You won't be wobbling around in every decision you make, unsure of yourself and fearful of getting caught. You'll be at peace and feel confident, taking sure steps because you know that you're

walking with God and that his ways are right and true and honest. Your conscience will be clean, and you will feel secure.

The devil can't knock you down either because you're doing what's right. You have a fortress around you that is guarding you, protecting you, and strengthening you. Others can say what they want about you. They can try to hurt you. They can try to tear you down, but you will remain steady when you have integrity.

Some young people live in fear, wondering what's going to happen to them next, who is going to come after them, or what they're going to be tempted with. The Bible promises that you can blow all that fear out of your mind if you walk with integrity. You'll walk securely. You'll never have to second-guess yourself. And you'll never have to wonder about what the future looks like for you. It's going to be secure. It's going to be strong. It's going to be stable because you've decided to walk with integrity.

Action Steps

Right now, make integrity a priority in your life. Now that you have read all the Scripture passages for the week, make a commitment to meditate on them. Choose your favorite one to memorize and write it out here.

You have been thinking all week about intentionally making integrity the central part of your life. It's time to decide what kind of person you're going to be.

Describe what kind of Christian you want to be.

Let your accountability partner know what kind of a person you want to be and hold each other accountable. Write down some things you want your accountability friend to hold you to when it comes to integrity.

By communicating these goals with an accountability partner, you keep your integrity at a strong level. Having an accountability friend offers security; it's like insurance for maintaining a life of integrity.

Daily Bible reading: Matthew 28

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss all the qualities and benefits of integrity that you can think of. How does God bless a person of integrity? What are the qualities you want to develop in your life, and how are you going to make that happen? What are some little ways this past week that you have given your word and then kept it? Talk about areas in which you each need to keep your word this week and pray for each other now to do it.

Week 5

Whom Do You Belong To?

Day 1

Meet Together Regularly

Some people have given up the habit of meeting for worship, but we must not do that. We should keep on encouraging each other, especially since you know that the day of the Lord's coming is getting closer.

HEBREWS 10:25 CEV

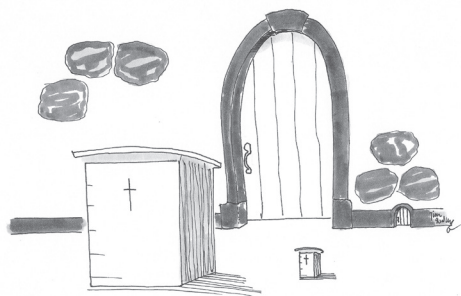
In this verse, Paul was specifically talking about the importance of getting together with other Christians so that you can learn and grow and continue pursuing a relationship with God with all your being. A lot of people think that if they make their commitment to the Lord, they can do whatever they want as long as they don't fall into major sin.

However, the point of this verse is that you are not designed to be a lone-wolf Christian. You are designed to do incredible things for God and to change the world, but you have to be connected with other people who want to do the same thing. In this passage, the Bible is giving specific instructions, basically saying, "Don't you dare quit going to church! Don't you dare stop getting together with people who have like minds and like faith."

This is an important command for young people today. A lot of people say, "I can't really make it to church. My job or my sport interferes with church and connect group." But we have to have people around us. The Bible calls it fellowship. We have to surround ourselves with people who love God and are going after God in the same direction.

I have talked to so many church leaders who get really discouraged. It seems they work their hearts out for their young people, yet the young people don't seem very committed. For

example, the church leaders will plan and plan and plan some kind of retreat or activity. They announce it for two months and mention it during meetings. And when it's time for the activity, no one comes. It turns out that the youth are more committed to a school activity or sport than they are to this group of people with whom they are going to spend eternity in heaven.



10/26/19

As followers of Christ, we need to be of a different mindset. This doesn't mean that you should neglect your schoolwork or your extracurricular activities. It does mean that you should prioritize church and your connect group more than you ever have. It means you must decide whom you belong to and of what group you will choose to say, "These are the people I really connect with heart-to-heart."

Does that mean you have to be at church every time the doors are open? No. But at the very least, be committed to attending the regular services so that you can be continually encouraged to grow deeper in your faith and your relationships with people who are pursuing God like you are.

Don't be so foolish by saying, "I have my Bible and my study manual, and I'll do my own thing." You have to be plugged in to a local group of people. If you are committed to the Lord, other people around you should know about your commitment to the Lord so they can help you grow.

The most important way that you can publicly tell others that you love Jesus, that you have decided to follow him, and that you belong to the church is to be baptized. Baptism was the most remarkable and visual celebration that early followers of Jesus would use to tell the world that they belonged to Jesus. To learn more about baptism, see the section called “What Is Baptism?” after week 12 of this book. Pray about getting baptized if you haven’t already taken this step of faith.

Action Steps

Maybe you’ve not been as committed to your church or connect group as you’d like to be. If you’ve shown a disinterested attitude or not shown up, you might need to make some apologies: first to God and then to the people it may have hurt. Write out anyone you need to talk to and ask forgiveness here.

Think of some things that you can do that will show your commitment to the Lord and the local church. How can you show that you have determined that you will not allow yourself to get out of the habit of meeting for worship? Write down your ideas.

How can you show your commitment to your connect group?

Don't just be a thoughtless, haphazard Christian who floats in now and then. Write down four ways that you can show your commitment.

1.

2.

3.

4.

Read Hebrews 10:25 and meditate on it today so that it becomes a part of your life and your heart.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 1

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Spur One Another On

Let us consider how we may spur one another on toward love and good deeds.

HEBREWS 10:24

If you'll notice, this verse appears in the Bible right before the verse you meditated on yesterday. Take a few minutes to write out in your own words what it means to "spur one another on toward love and good deeds."

One reason it's so important to regularly meet together and commit to your church and your connect group is to continue to push each other on to be more like Jesus. It's another area of accountability. We talked in week 3 about having accountability friendships. You need to have two or three people you are very close with, but that's not enough. It's also very important for you to be connected to a local body of believers. These people know your life, and you know their lives. Together you create a place where each member is being fed, growing, and submitting to the leadership that God has put over the group. As you get into a connect group in a church, you can do exactly what Scripture says. You can reignite your passion for God, really love each other, and help each other do good deeds.

God wants every connect group to be full of passionate followers. He wants every church to be full of people who will

change the world. As you participate in these communities of believers, you are saying, “I want to push you toward love and good deeds. I want to help you get other new ideas for how we, as a team, can really change this world.” You can’t be a part of an athletic team if you show up only now and then. No one could count on you. Whether you realize it or not, other people in the church depend on you just as you depend on them.

As a follower of Christ, decide to get plugged in and stay plugged in. It’s important that you stay involved in whatever ways you can. Have this mindset: *I’m part of the team. I’m a part of the family. This is MY church. I’m going to be a part of what God is doing here. We’re going to push each other toward love and good deeds. I’m not just going to try to push myself and spur myself on alone, but I’m going to let other people speak into my life and spur me on. We are going to do everything we can to put our heads together to find out how we can really overtake this world with the love of Jesus.*

Action Steps

Think of two or three ways you can serve your connect group or church and spur them on toward love and good deeds.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 2

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Where Do You Belong?

You were bought at a price. Therefore honor God
with your bodies.

1 CORINTHIANS 6:20

The Bible says we have all been bought at a price, but what does that mean? Jesus paid for you with his blood. If you have given your heart to him, then you don't belong to yourself anymore because he bought you. He owns you because you have freely given your life to him. You don't give your life to him and then live for yourself; you give your life to him, and then you belong to him. This reality is important to think about.

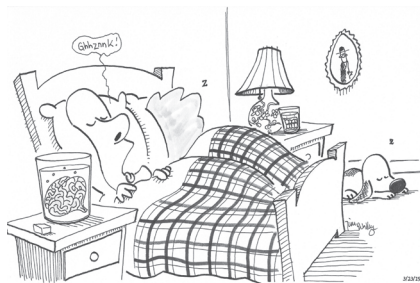
Some people don't really consider that they belong to their connect group. They belong to their sports teams, choirs, bands, friend group, or some other clubs. But they feel as if they don't really belong to their connect group. They just go because Mom and Dad go to that church. Their identity is wrapped up in other things, such as their social media account or the people they hang around.

As a follower of Christ, it's time to change your sense of belonging. We assume if you're this far in this book, you are truly committed to growing in the things of the Lord. If this is true, then you are in the same group as other people who also belong to the Lord. They have given him their lives, so they belong to him. You have given your life, so you belong to him. You belong with each other, and with them, you should find the most sense of belonging.

What does that mean? Other followers, other people who are radically committed to God, are the ones you're talking about when you talk about your best friends. They are the

people whom you live life with, pray with, and share your struggles with. They walk through life with you.

When you are thinking this way, you don't look at something the church has planned and think, *I can't really do that because I have plans with my sport or my school.* You change the whole thing around: *I really belong to these wild Christ followers who want to shake up my community and the world. If I have plans with my connect group, I really want to participate. They are the ones I really belong to because I'm going to be living with them forever. If they have plans, then I'll cancel anything that interferes because I find my real identity not in the activities I participate in but in what we are doing for God to change this world. That's what I'm made of. That's what I'm about. I belong with people who belong to Christ.*



To say that you will cancel anything that interferes is not to say that you will not be a person of your word. As a Christ follower, you have to be a man or woman of integrity. However, you may want to avoid getting involved with groups whose activities regularly conflict with your church or connect group schedule. Or you could talk with your coach or another leader and tell them that you have a commitment to your church but want to participate when there's not a conflict. That would be a good way to make a strong statement about your beliefs. You definitely want to make connect group activities a higher priority than anything like parties, dances, or sporting events when you're just a spectator.

Now this is a pretty different way of thinking. A lot of young people go to church, but they belong somewhere else. Right now is the time for you to rethink why you are in a connect group. If you really love God as much as you say, then you will start pouring your energy into the things that your connect group and church are trying to accomplish.

Action Steps

Make a list of groups or organizations that you feel you belong to or that you are committed to right now.

How can you change your thinking and sense of belonging so that you're more committed to your connect group and to your church than these other things?

Decide today to get more committed to the vision of your connect group and the vision of your church and to feel more at home there than you do anywhere else. You belong with people whom Jesus also bought with a price.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 3

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Take Up the Vision

Whatever you do, do it heartily, as to the Lord and not to men.

COLOSSIANS 3:23 NKJV

God knows that all people long to find something they can do heartily. We want to find something we can throw our hearts and minds into. I think one of the biggest challenges for young people today is that they are trying to find something meaningful to pour their lives and their hearts into. They are looking for something they can give their all for, something that demands everything. Some people pour their lives into academics or a career. Some get involved in sports or other worthwhile activities, but some get caught up in drugs or gangs.

Although these activities don't seem to have anything in common, they serve as examples of the wide variety of distractions available for teens that, many times, keep them from being involved with God and his kingdom. They distract us from the main thing we were designed for. That doesn't mean that we can't be involved in sports or extracurricular activities and do those things for the Lord, but we should get our sense of purpose from pouring our all into the things of God and the things he has called us to do.

We humans are created with the tendency and drive to pour our lives into something. The Bible says, "Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength" (Deuteronomy 6:5). When we love the Lord with all our strength, using our energy for God to promote his kingdom, that's when we'll be truly fulfilled.

Let me get more specific. God has given you a connect group and a church for a reason. He has given your church

leaders and pastor a vision for how to change your city, your town, your area, and your region to improve lives and build the kingdom. It is absolutely imperative for you, as a follower of Christ, to become involved with the vision that your church leaders and pastor have for your connect group and your church to shake up the world. You get to be a part of something much bigger than you! But it's hard to get involved if your heart and soul aren't in it. You have to love the Lord with all you have. Then he will use you to show the world that he is doing something amazing through your church.

You need to believe, *The coolest thing God is doing in town, next to my quiet time, is what God is doing in my connect group. We are there for each other when we are hurting. We pray for each other and help each other through difficult times. We're shaking up the city. We're invading places where people go to hang out. We're making a difference in the middle school and the high school. We're doing stuff that really makes a difference. It's not just that I'm sort of involved or that I come when the pastor begs me. I'm there before my leaders want me there, and I'm praying for and planning for the ways God will move. I'm taking notes, and I'm volunteering my time because I'm committed with all my heart to this vision that God has given my pastor and my church leaders. In fact, I have taken it on as my own. It's not just their vision, but it's mine, too, because I'm a part of this church's vision. I'm going to pour my soul into doing everything I can to make this happen.*

Get involved with God's kingdom. Whether you're into sports, music, art, academics, or some other activity, consider how you can use these pastimes to help further God's kingdom and the vision of your church. Take some time to meet with your church leader (and maybe your pastor, depending on how busy they are) and ask about their vision and where you and your interests fit into the vision. Tell them you have some free time and that you want to really pour your life into furthering that vision. Tell them you want to be more than just an

attendee. You want to be someone whose heart and soul are totally committed to the vision.



Action Steps

Memorize Colossians 3:23 today. Write it out in your own words.

Meditate on it all day.

List some things here that you can do to further the vision of your church or connect group.

Schedule an appointment with your church leader today and let them know about your commitment to the vision. Get clear directions from them about what you can do to further that vision. Write the vision in your Bible so you can pray over

it often. Do it with all your heart, and you will have so much fulfillment that you won't know what to do with yourself.

One more thing for you to think about: if you are genuinely committed to the vision, you can tithe (10 percent of your income) to your church each week. If you are really pouring your heart into the church, your money will naturally follow. And if you give and tithe to your local fellowship, God will bless you for it: “‘Bring the whole tithe into the storehouse, that there may be food in my house. Test me in this,’ says the LORD Almighty, ‘and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven and pour out so much blessing that there will not be room enough to store it’” (Malachi 3:10).

Daily Bible reading: Mark 4

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Submit to Your Church Leader

Give respect and honor to those who are in authority.

ROMANS 13:7 NLT

Our culture today does not show much honor to its leaders. Too often, the world simply teaches us to do whatever we want, insisting it is our right, and to completely ignore any sense of honor or obedience toward leaders in our life.

As a follower of Christ, it's important for you to be committed to the vision of your connect group and your church and to be specifically committed to your church leader and loyal to him or her. Being loyal to your church leader means having the attitude of humility that shows you believe God has placed you in that group and God has placed that leader over you to help you grow. A follower doesn't have to be forced to honor or obey their leader. They know that in the same way Jesus obeyed his Father, he showed us how to act and what attitude to have toward authorities in our life.



Being respectful to your church leader means you obey them. It means you'll listen to and take notes on their preaching as a sign of respect. If a leader asks you to stop talking, you don't start texting people instead. In fact, you probably

shouldn't have been talking in the first place. You also don't want to talk behind your leader's back or whisper malicious rumors about them or your dislike of certain things they do. This is the attitude the world has toward leaders, not the attitude of followers of Christ.

If there is something you dislike about what your leader has said, then be honest enough to go to them face-to-face and discuss the issue. If they change their mind, fine. If they don't, say, "I'm committed to this vision. I'm committed to you. I'm going to shut my mouth and go along with this." It takes a courageous man or woman to honor their leaders when they disagree.

A Christ follower has an even greater responsibility to respect leaders than those who don't know Christ. A Christ follower attends church because they know fellowship is part of God's plan. You can also know that God put you in a particular group within the church and that God put that particular leader there in charge of you. By honoring that leader, you are honoring God. God will bless your life, and you will be amazed at how much leadership you will develop by learning to really follow and submit.

You can find many examples of this in Scripture. For example, in Acts 16:3, when Paul decided to take Timothy along on a journey to share what Jesus had done with others, Paul circumcised him because the Jews who lived in that area knew Timothy's father was Greek. Timothy submitted to Paul even to the point of being circumcised, even though it was clear that no one was becoming a follower of Christ through circumcision. Timothy trusted Paul because Paul was a faithful and honorable man of integrity who could be trusted.

If, however, a leader ever asks you to do something unbiblical, something ungodly, or something that makes you feel uncomfortable because your conscience says it's wrong, you should know that God would not want you to obey that person. Your first allegiance is to the Lord and his Word. In that case,

you should walk away and immediately bring it to the attention of another responsible adult.

Now it's time to wholeheartedly respect and honor the leaders God put into your life.

Action Steps

List some things that you may have done that have dishonored or been disrespectful to your church leader.

List some things that you will do this week to show them in an incredible way that you are going to honor, listen, and obey them from this point forward.

Take a few minutes now to memorize Romans 13:7. Make an appointment with your church leader this week to ask them to forgive you for any areas where you have dishonored them. Ask them how you can get plugged into the vision. Tell them of your commitment to the vision.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 5

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Submit to Your Senior Pastor

Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which God has established.

The authorities that exist have been established by God.

ROMANS 13:1

A follower of Christ respects the senior pastor and the leadership of the church (the elders and other church leaders). Christian fellowship doesn't just revolve around your connect group. You are also a member of your church at large. If you're really going to be a Christ follower, you need to know how to display the right kind of attitude toward your pastor.

Sometimes young people come in with a cocky attitude that's very disrespectful to the leaders of the church and to the pastor. They think, *My connect group leaders can relate to me, but the pastor of my church is old and can't really relate.* They mock the pastor during services or text their friends from the back row. The attitude of a follower should be completely different from that. God will not permit you to be that way. If you want God to bless your life, you must honor every level of leadership he gives you. Your pastor is one of the leaders.

You can do some specific things to show your pastor that you respect them. Sit in the front few rows instead of somewhere near the back. Join in the worship service. Look your pastor right in the eye when they look at you. On the way out, shake hands and say, "Pastor, I appreciate your message—you gave me a lot to think about. Thank you for all you do." Take notes through the sermon and really try to get a lot out of the message. If you open your heart and pray, *God, please help me to really listen to what you are speaking to me today*, you'll be

amazed at what God will speak through your pastor, even though they are older and from a different generation. After all, the Word of God is thousands of years old, and it still relates to you. So what if your pastor is a little bit older than you? They have been your age before and can relate to your struggles in some way.

You can also show your pastor that you respect them by the way you dress. A lot of young people come to church dressed like they're going out with their friends. While God doesn't care what you look like on the outside, your appearance can show an attitude of respect or disrespect. Think about it this way: If you were going to meet with the president or a leader of your nation, how would you dress? Would you wear torn or dirty clothes and have messy hair? As we travel to churches around the world, we see many young people dressed like that.

Does that mean you have to wear a suit or a dress every time? No. But it's a decent gesture to care about how you carry yourself and put yourself together. You communicate to the pastor and the church whether they're important to you by how you dress. If you would dress up to meet a government official like a president or a governor, wouldn't it be more important to dress up to meet with somebody who is in leadership in the household of God, with someone who has spiritual authority in your life? As you honor your pastor and other authorities in your life, you are honoring God by how you carry yourself and how you treat them.

Action Steps

List some things you will do this week to show your pastor and church leaders that you want to honor them and respect them.

Jesus is the ultimate head of the church. Ask him if there's anything you can start doing this week that will show more honor to him and write it down.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 6

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

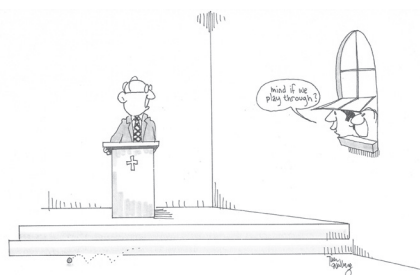
Day 7

Young and Radical Examples

Don't let anyone make fun of you, just because you are young. Set an example for other followers by what you say and do, as well as by your love, faith, and purity.

1 TIMOTHY 4:12 CEV

The Bible encourages us not to let anyone mock or look down on us just because we're young. Some people mock teenage Christians and don't take them seriously. They think teens have a reputation for being inconsistent about their beliefs, always being up and down and back and forth. They're on fire, falling away, on fire, falling away.



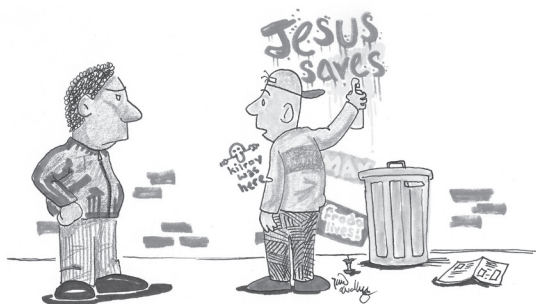
The hazards of having your church near a golf course.

As a young follower of Christ, you can change that image. You can show people that you are part of a force to be reckoned with. You are serious about God, your Christian life, and your commitment to your connect group and church. Your identity is rooted in Christ and in the church.

Paul told Timothy to be an example of love, faith, and purity. In other words, young people should be blowing the minds of the adults around them. The adults should look at the lives of the teens in the church and think, *Wow! Why am I not*

loving people like that? Why don't I have that much respect for my pastor? Why am I not that committed to my church? Young people should be an example to everyone else. Timothy was. Others should be imitating, not mocking, the young people of the church.

As a follower, you need to get a new picture of what your commitment to your church and connect group, to your pastor and church leader, is really all about. This is not a haphazard, only-when-it's-convenient thing. Come rain or shine, bad times or good, you're going to church. If the mail carrier can get out in the rain, shine, snow, or sleet, why can't you go to church? You say, *Oh yes. Lord, I'll die for you. I'll do anything for you.* But then it gets a little rainy outside, and you don't go to church because it's inconvenient. You need to have the commitment that says, *I'm going to show myself as an example. I'm going to be there because my heart is there, my commitment is there, and my life is there. God has called me to this thing, and I'm pouring my life into it.*



"Evangelism? I thought you said, 'vandalism'!"

7/22/19

Commit today that even though you're young, you'll live the kind of life and have the kind of commitment to your connect group and church that will glorify God and cause people to say, "Wow! What an incredible example!"

Action Steps

List some things that you can do or maybe that you've already started doing that will be an example for people to follow.

Ask the Lord to make you an example to other believers, young and old, of a true disciple of Christ.

Throughout all my youth years, I commit to my connect group, to my church, to my church leaders, and to my pastor because I know that it is no accident that I am here. I know that God has given me these leaders and these groups to be involved with to help me grow and to help me change the world.

Lord, I want to honor you with my commitment to fellowship with the believers in my church, which will also deepen my relationship with you. I commit to finding my part in the vision of my connect group and church and to doing everything I can with all my heart to be a part of it.

Sign your name

Date

Daily Bible reading: Mark 7

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Discuss how this week's lessons and Romans 13:7 have changed your perspective on leadership. How did you use to view and treat leaders, and how do you see them now? What are some of the commitments you've made this week to honor your church leaders and pastor and to join with the vision of the church?

Week 6

Faith When You
Don't Feel Anything

Day 1

Warm Fuzzies Come and Go

“Everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock.”

MATTHEW 7:24

When they give their lives to the Lord, some people have a dramatic experience. Some weep, laugh, get excited, or are amazed at what God has done for them. Some people do not feel much change at all.

This week we are going to talk about how to build your house (your life) on Jesus, not on feelings.

Matthew 7:24 talks about the wise man who builds his house on the rock. Take a few minutes to memorize this verse. This parable helps you understand how to build your life on Jesus. When you become a Christian, you do not leave Jesus at the door of your life and continue with your daily activities as before. Jesus says that to live for him, you need to build your life on him, the Rock, and establish on him every part of your life in a solid way. You may have felt incredible warm fuzzies when you first gave your life to Jesus. Or you may have felt nothing at all. You may have been wondering why some people feel something and others do not.

The answer is that nobody knows why. God communicates to different people in different ways. A good example of this is the story of the sinful woman who wept when she was forgiven for so much (Luke 7:36–50). The incredible mercy of Jesus and how much she had been forgiven emotionally stirred her. Over the next few weeks, however, she may not have felt as emotional, but still she had been forgiven.

Maybe you felt excited and had a lot of gushy feelings when you first gave your life to Jesus, but now you do not feel anything at all. This doesn't mean that you are no longer saved. Feelings about anything never last forever. That is the nature of feelings. Becoming a follower of Christ was not an emotional decision; it was a smart decision! Warm fuzzies may come and go, but we must develop a steadfast life in Jesus.

Action Steps

What do you think it means to build your life on the Rock of Jesus (according to Matthew 7:24)?

List some things you can do to help you build your life on Jesus.

Start building your life on Jesus today. It is not important what you feel. Just keep building on Jesus no matter what.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 8

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Guided by the Word or Emotions?

If you declare with your mouth, “Jesus is Lord,” and believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead, you will be saved. For it is with your heart that you believe and are justified, and it is with your mouth that you profess your faith and are saved.

ROMANS 10:9–10

Take a few minutes today to get these verses into your heart and think about what they mean.

We need to guide our lives by what God’s Word says, not by our feelings. Sometimes when we feel really excited about doing a thing, we are, of course, more prone to do it. If we do not have those feelings, we probably won’t want to do that thing.



So many Christians are living an emotional roller coaster because they guide their lives by their feelings and not by the Word of God. When some people go forward at an altar call, they feel very enthusiastic and excited. But when they leave and

have their own quiet times, reading the Bible and talking to God, they don't feel any warm fuzzies, so they don't keep up with their quiet times. We have to build our lives on the stability of God's Word.

The Bible says in Romans 10:9–10 that if you confess Jesus as your Lord and believe in your heart that he was raised from the dead, **you are saved**. You are saved not just because you feel saved. Some days you wake up and don't feel saved at all. But you have to go back to the Word. Ask yourself, *Have I confessed Jesus as my Lord and Savior?* What does that mean to you?

It means he is your boss, your chief. You have submitted to him to lead you. Have you said with your whole heart, *Lord Jesus, you are my Lord, and I believe in my heart that you have been raised from the dead?* If so, then you are saved! It does not matter whether you feel like it or not. If the Word of God says it is true, it is true. It doesn't matter what feelings or doubts the devil may bring your way. You have to build your life and faith on God's Word.

You can believe, *God said that if I confess Jesus as Lord and believe he was raised from the dead, then I am saved*. Boom! You are saved! No question about it. You can have incredible confidence about what God says. What he says is true no matter what you feel. This is the fundamental building block of your life in Christ. You build it on his Word. You believe it because God said it, and it reflects what is real no matter what you feel.

Circumstances and people will come into your life and make your feelings change. But that does not mean that what God has done in your life has changed. Don't worry about having the feelings. Just concentrate on having a pure heart, living for God, and letting him clean up your life.

Action Steps

Spend some time right now thanking God for saving you and for all the things he has done in your life lately. If you recall his blessings aloud, you will be amazed at how that action encourages your heart and lifts your faith. Write out ten blessings that the Lord has given to you—big and small.

Keep memorizing and meditating on the Word of God.

Also, have you checked in with your accountability partner lately? Spend some time sharing your biggest challenges, encouraging, and praying for one another.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Draw Near to God

Come near to God and he will come near to you.

JAMES 4:8

Take a few minutes to memorize and meditate on this verse.

So what if you do not feel anything? What should you do? You need to live a life of obedience because you love Jesus even if you do not feel anything. It is just like when two people are married. Sometimes they feel in love, and sometimes they do not feel in love. The fact is that if they have decided to love, then they do love the person. You need to do things that will draw your hearts closer and closer together.

James 4:8 says that if we come near to God, he will come near to us. What does that really mean? If you do things to focus on God and draw close to him, then he will draw close to you. The closer you get to him, the more you feel him near. But you do not have to feel him to know he is near. God said that he will never leave you or forsake you (Hebrews 13:5). He will not leave you, whether you feel as if he is there or not.

Action Steps

List some things you can do to draw closer to God today.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Once you do these things, what will you do if you do not feel anything?

If you keep quoting the Word and are committed to what you know is true, it does not matter what you feel. The Word says it is true, no matter how you feel. What Scripture says is what is real. Your feelings will eventually follow. Do not give up. Keep pressing into Christ, and you will sense him coming near.

Meditate on James 4:8 all day and really believe it. Disappointment is not defeat unless you stop trying.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 10

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

What Happens When You Worship?

He was filled with joy because he had come to believe in
God—he and his whole household.

ACTS 16:34

Read Acts 16:16–40. We can learn a lot from the story of Paul and Silas in jail. Paul and Silas worshiped God while they were in prison, even though they were in chains. As they worshiped, the awesome presence of the living God came in. The place was shaken, the doors flew open, and the chains fell off.

As you get into the awesome presence of the incredible, sovereign, living, holy God, he can stir up your emotions (the way you feel and what you sense physically). You may wonder how you can feel the same awesome presence of an incredible God early in the morning when you are barely awake. What does it take to get into the presence of God?

When you find yourself in tough situations and do not feel God's presence, concentrate on loving him more and worshiping him as Paul and Silas did. Then you'll realize God is there all the time, whether you feel him or not. When you really worship him, you will feel his presence. Your fears will subside, your worries will disappear, and your "chains" will fall off! When the presence of the living God comes and you are completely focused on worshiping him, you cannot help but experience his peace and closeness.

Action Steps

Are you in a tough situation? Are you having a hard time feeling the presence of God? If your answer is yes to either of these questions, then worship him today. Do not wait until tomorrow. First Thessalonians 5:16–18 says, “Rejoice always, pray continually, give thanks in all circumstances; for this is God’s will for you in Christ Jesus.”

Take a moment today to thank God for being stronger and more powerful than your toughest situation. Focus on the things he is doing for you instead of the seemingly unanswered prayers. He is working in ways that you may not see yet. Rejoice that you belong to him and that he’s going to see you through. It takes faith to worship him in a hard situation, but like Paul and Silas, when we praise him anyway, his presence always shows up.

Write out a prayer, thanking him for all the good things in your life that come because of him.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 11

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Set Your Mind on Truth

Brothers and sisters, whatever is true, whatever is noble, whatever is right, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is admirable—if anything is excellent or praiseworthy—think about such things.

PHILIPPIANS 4:8

Take a few minutes today to memorize this verse. The Bible says we should build our lives on the Word of God, not on what we feel. Building our lives on his Word means memorizing it, chewing on it, listening to it, and meditating on it some more. Think about it and how it applies to your life. If you are going to build your life on the Word of God, then you have to meditate on things like this:

- God has removed your sins from you as far as the east is from the west (Psalm 103:12).
- Your life is hidden with God in Christ (Colossians 3:3).
- You are seated with Christ in heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6).
- You have been redeemed (bought back from the Enemy) by the blood of Jesus (1 Corinthians 6:20).

Action Steps

Take a moment right now to practice meditating on each of these Scripture passages. One by one, say each aloud, picture its meaning, and thank God for it. Meditate on it and realize it is truer than any circumstance you find yourself in. No matter whether you feel it or not, it is true because God's Word says it is. You build your life on a firm foundation by meditating on the truth because the truth sets you free (John 8:32).

Daily Bible reading: Mark 12

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Faith That's Bigger Than Sight

We live by faith, not by sight.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:7

Spend a few minutes meditating on this verse. What does it mean to you?

When I first committed my life to the Lord, I felt extremely excited. But there have definitely been times since then when I have not felt much at all. I still continued to read Scripture, got up every morning to seek God, kept serving him, and kept loving him even when I did not feel very excited. I'm so glad I did, no matter how I felt, because it has brought me a lifetime of joy and knowing God's love ever more deeply.

According to 2 Corinthians 5:7, we cannot live by what we see. We live by our faith and have confidence that God's Word is right no matter what we think or feel. Walk by faith, not by what you see.

When it looks as if God has abandoned you or everyone has turned against you, it does not matter because you have faith that is bigger than sight. Faith is more important than sight, and you are believing God.

Action Steps

List some situations or circumstances you have experienced when it seemed as if God was not with you.

Think about the faith you have in the living God and how his Word will carry you through tough circumstances. Think about some verses that apply to the circumstances you just listed. For example, “I can do all things through Christ who strengthens me” (Philippians 4:13 NKJV).

All day today, think about 2 Corinthians 5:7, that you live by faith, not by the things you see around you. Chew on it all day: *I live by faith, not by sight. I live by faith in the awesome, holy, living, incredible God, not by sight or feelings.*

Set some goals today about basing your life on the Word of God. For example, *I will have faith for my brother's salvation even though he refuses to go to church with me.*

Write down a few faith goals.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 13

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Build Your Life on the Word

“Do not let your heart be troubled; believe in God,
believe also in Me.”

JOHN 14:1 NASB

Being committed to Christ means loving God and living for him even when you do not feel anything. In fact, it would be a good thing for you to decide to remain a follower of Christ even if you never have another “fuzzy” feeling for the rest of your life.

Live by faith with your confidence in God and his Word. You must love him and serve him even if all others turn their backs on him and you never get excited about another thing in your whole life. Build your life on the Rock of Jesus Christ and on the confidence that his Word is true no matter how you feel.

The truth is, the more you build your life on his Word by trusting him instead of your feelings, the more you will be filled with a joy and peace that surpasses your understanding and is deeper than your feelings. Once you get a taste of his peace, you won't want to settle for anything less! Happiness and excitement are great, but they come and go according to our circumstances. When things are going great, we feel happy. When things are bad, we feel down. But even when things aren't going so well, God brings us peace *if our eyes are fixed on him* and we're trusting him for the outcome.

Jesus told us not to LET our hearts be troubled. That means we can choose to believe in God and believe in Jesus instead of allowing ourselves to be stressed and troubled. Building your life on his Word is simply trusting him no matter what. God is for you. He will never let you down. He is faithful and trustworthy.

Action Steps

Have you ever known of someone who loves the Lord and has a deep peace, even when they're going through something really hard? Describe them.

Write out some of your biggest concerns that may be getting you down right now.

Now lay them all down at the feet of Jesus. Pray over each one and let God handle them. Don't allow your heart to be troubled. Don't live by your emotions. TRUST IN GOD.

You are building your life on his Word.

Would you take a moment now to make a commitment to God? Tell him, *Lord, no matter how I feel, whether I am excited or not, I am going to commit to building my life step by step, day by day, on your Word.*

Now that you have said it, do it!

What are you doing with your life to glorify Jesus? Make a list of some ways you can bring glory to him in your own unique way or through your own personal life circumstances.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Remind yourself this: *I believe God's Word because it is true and because it is right—no matter how I feel or what anyone says about me.*

Daily Bible reading: Mark 14

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

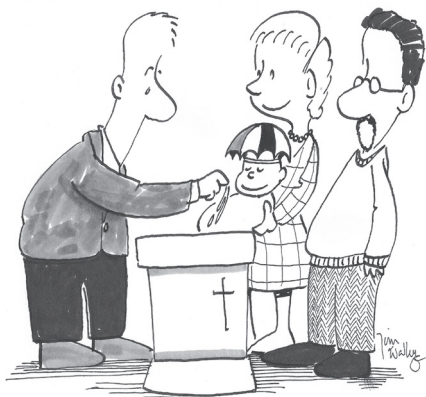
What do you do when you don't have feelings for God? Discuss times when you felt God was not there. What does it mean to "live by faith, not by sight" (2 Corinthians 5:7)? How do you build your life on God's Word? What are some ways you can strengthen your resolve to love God and live for him even when you don't feel like it? What is something you really need God to help you with this week? Ask your group to pray for you regarding this.

Week 7

Taking Control of Your Life

Day 1

Baby Christian



4/13/19

It's interesting how the family responds when a newborn baby has their first bowel movement. They all stand around in wonder. The mother and the father are so proud. They point at it, they look at it, and they cheer, "Look! They had their first stinkies!" They make all kinds of jokes about it. Then, as the months go by, the parents begin to bicker over who has to change the baby's diaper. It is no longer a laughing matter. They make every excuse for why they should not have to change it. Even the babysitters make up reasons why they should not have to change diapers.

But the fact is that somebody has to change them.

At some point, the child is expected to learn how to control themselves. If a healthy person were thirteen years old and still filling up their diaper, it would be cause for concern. Yet that is how so many Christians are.

When somebody first gives their heart to the Lord, they are sure to make mistakes. They may think, *Oh well, it was just an*

accident. And then they make another mistake. *Oh, I just had another accident...just another accident.* Well, if Christians are still having the same kind of “accidents” four or five years after being saved, it’s as if they keep “filling their pants.” In other words, they keep the same attitudes or the same habits or the same sins as they had before, and they never grow up. They walk around just like a baby, acting like nothing is ever wrong.

Perhaps they’re still rebellious, they have bad attitudes, they’re cutting people down, or they’re lying, cheating, stealing, or involved in immorality. They come to church and act like everything is just fine, but everybody can tell because there is an aroma that they give off that they often cannot even smell themselves. They say, “I can’t help it. It’s just a problem I have.” But it’s not just a problem; it’s sin. God wants us to learn to control ourselves in the same way a child must learn to control their bodily functions.

Proverbs 25:28 says, “Like a city whose walls are broken through is a person who lacks self-control.” When we lack self-control, we become just like a city with no protection. Every enemy can move in and take over. What the Bible is saying here is that if you lack self-control, it’s like you do not have any protection around your life. We continually use the excuse of “I just can’t help it. I can’t control myself. It’s just a problem I have.” You have no protection against sin because you have not built a resistance against it. That resistance is like a bulletproof wall to the devil. But if you don’t have that wall of resistance, any little temptation that comes your way gets through your shield.

It’s not good enough for us to say, “Well, I just can’t control myself. It’s not really my fault.” If this sounds familiar, you would be wise to start praying about it and learn how to control different parts of your life so that you don’t walk around like a Christian with dirty pants.

Action Steps

Write out what you think Proverbs 25:28 means for your life.

Take a few minutes now to meditate on Proverbs 25:28. Ask the Lord to show you how you can start to build up that wall of protection in your life and write down your thoughts here.

Daily Bible reading: Mark 15

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

How to Have Self-Control

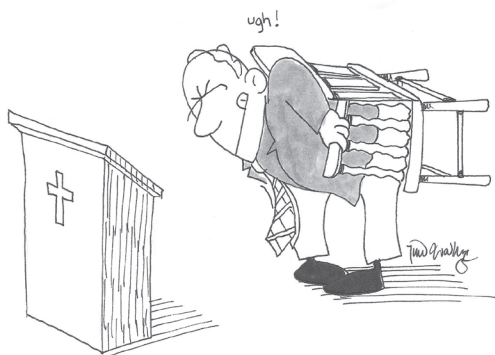
For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith goodness; and to goodness, knowledge; and to knowledge, self-control; and to self-control, perseverance; and to perseverance, godliness.

2 PETER 1:5–6

Peter gave us a perfect progression of growing up spiritually. Let's concentrate specifically on adding self-control to your knowledge and adding perseverance to your self-control.

As you learn how to live as a follower of Christ, you're going to gain knowledge through what you learn from church, Bible verses, and even fellowship with other believers. As you get knowledge about how you should live, you will need to add self-control. In other words, start putting into practice the things that you know are right. Doing the right things in all circumstances causes you to have self-control. Then add perseverance to your self-control. *Perseverance* means a "continued effort to do or achieve something despite difficulties, failure, or opposition."¹ *Perseverance* means you don't give up even when it's hard and even when you fail. You keep practicing godliness.

The Bible wouldn't tell us to have self-control unless God knew that we could. He has given us the power to have control in our life. As we learn the Bible and practice how God says to live, the Holy Spirit gives us the power to live that way. Saying you have no self-control is just as ridiculous as saying, "I can't control my screaming." With a baby that is true, but as that baby grows, they learn to control themselves even though they didn't know they could.



Time for that diet resolution.

3/30/19

The same is true about you. As God teaches you things from a sermon or from your own Bible study about how you should live, he expects you to take the power of the Holy Spirit that he has put in you and practice every day controlling that area of your life.

Action Steps

Make this commitment now:

In Jesus' name, I am going to add to what I know, and I'm going to start doing it now. I am going to start forcing my body, my mind, my lips, and my life to do what I know is right because I know that I have the power of the Holy Spirit to do it. Then I'm going to add perseverance to my self-control. I'm going to continue to have self-control and do what I know is right. I'm not going to do whatever my body wants to do. I'm not going to do what my sin nature wants to do anymore. Just because it's natural doesn't mean that it is what I should do. I have the power to do the right thing. I'm learning to have self-control so that I don't constantly live in sin for the rest of my life as a Christian.

Take a moment to write down some of the areas of your life where you need to have self-control.

Now pray over these areas: *Lord, in Jesus' name, I commit these areas to you. I no longer want to get myself dirty from sin in all these areas of my life. I am going to do what I know is right. Thank you for giving me the power to persevere in self-control and never give up. I am an overcomer! In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Daily Bible reading: Mark 16

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

The Fruit of Self-Control

The fruit of the spirit is love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control. Against such things there is no law.

GALATIANS 5:22–23

We're talking about growing in the Lord and not being a baby in the things of Christ anymore. Today's verses begin with "the fruit of the Spirit." Note that fruit does not simply appear on trees. You don't walk out to an apple tree and see buds one day and see apples the next day. The apples have to grow. First the bud turns into a flower, which develops into a small apple, which grows into a large apple, which finally ripens.

This is the same thing that God wants to do in our life. We pray, *Mature me so I grow fruit*. But it's not enough just to pray for the fruit of the Spirit: *God make me patient, God make me kind, God make me loving, and God give me self-control. Give it to me now!* To mature and grow up as a follower of Christ, you must pursue making the fruit grow.

If fruit is going to grow, the seed must be planted, watered, and fertilized. **The seed is the Word of God. You plant it in your heart.** You learn it and meditate on it. You water it by expressing praise and worship, cultivating a humble heart, and adding to your knowledge. You keep learning more and more about the Lord so you can continue to exercise self-control in the areas you learn about.

Self-control is a fruit of the Spirit—a fruit of your surrender to the Spirit of God and the renewing of your mind in the Word of God. To cultivate this fruit, demand of yourself that you do what you learn about. Picture yourself as a fruit tree,

growing the fruit of the Spirit and constantly pursuing maturity and growth. You are not somebody with just a bunch of blossoms, as some Christians are. You don't just have a lot of little baby fruit. Work to grow mature, healthy, plump, juicy fruit on your tree by *spending time in God's presence* and getting his Word in your heart.

Those who see you from one month to the next or from one year to the next will then see a lot of growth in your life. In areas where you used to be impatient, you'll become really patient. In areas where you used to be rebellious, you'll become submissive to authority. When people are around you, they should say, "Wow, you have really grown."

Action Steps

Take a moment to list some areas in your life that, over the next two months, you want people to look at you and say, "Wow, I see growth in this area."

Find out what God says about these areas you've listed. Take the one where you need the most work and find a verse about it. Write it out here and on an index card or in your phone so you can take it with you to meditate on throughout the day. As you plant those seeds in your heart, you will begin to see the fruit of self-control develop in your life!

Pray over these areas right now: *Lord, in Jesus' name, these are the areas I want to grow in. I don't want to just stay the same. I don't want to make up excuses for why I still have immature fruit or no growth in my life in these areas. As I learn what your Word says about these areas, I promise to apply self-control over my sinful nature so that you can be glorified in the way I live. In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Now take a few minutes to memorize Galatians 5:22–23. Meditate on these verses as you begin to work on getting mature fruit in your life.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 1

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

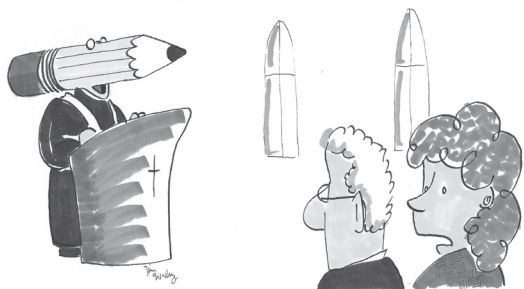
Take Control of Your Mouth: Filthy Language

You must also rid yourselves of all such things as these: anger, rage, malice, slander, and filthy language from your lips.

COLOSSIANS 3:8

The way people talk to other people in this world is so corrupt and corroded. I'm not just talking about cussing or swearing but also gossiping, verbally slamming people, and using words to stab them in the back.

Colossians 3:8 says to rid yourselves of filthy language. Think about filthy language. Whether it's garbage jokes, cutting other people down, talking about people behind their backs, or referring to leaders in a garbage way, it's just filthy language that's not honoring God. You might say, "Well, I just can't help it," but the good news is that you *can* help it. Now that you know that filthy language shouldn't be coming out of your mouth, add self-control to your knowledge. Say, *In Jesus' name, I am going to take control over my tongue.*



"He's sharp and to the point, but on the other end of it, he's always correcting himself."

3/12/19

Another form of filthy language is lying. Lying is saying things that are untrue, whether it's what we call white lies or it's blatant lies to our mom or dad or teachers. It's time for us to become people of truth. You don't have to lie. You might have a particular propensity to lie because you have learned that's the way you can get away with things. But as a new creation, as a man or woman of God, new words should be on your lips. Say, *In Jesus' name, I'm going to be a person of truth and do what is right, controlling my tongue.*

Action Steps

List a couple of ways you want to correct the way you talk, whether it relates to lying, telling inappropriate jokes, cutting people down, gossiping, or talking about your leaders in a way that doesn't honor them or God.

When you find a certain area in your life that doesn't honor God, the way you get clean and take control is to repent. You say, *Lord, I am not going to talk like that anymore. I repent of talking like this. I repent of using the tongue that you have given me to let this garbage come out of my mouth. I choose to use self-control and submit this area of my life to you. In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Now remember Colossians 3:8 throughout the day. First, take the next few minutes and meditate on it. Then, write it down and refer to it all day to renew your mind and the way you think. It will give you power as you chew on it. Then, if you are tempted today to use your tongue for garbage, let this verse come out of your mouth instead.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 2

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Flee from Sexual Immorality

Among you there must not be even a hint of sexual immorality, or of any kind of impurity, or of greed, because these are improper for God's holy people.

EPHESIANS 5:3

Let's talk about immorality.

Immorality is like garbage. It has a stench that everyone can smell. But people who live on a garbage dump don't really notice the smell. They live in it every day. It's all around them, and it has become normal.

If you're hanging around a bunch of worldly people who are fooling around with sex a lot, but you're only doing it a little, then you might feel pretty righteous about it. You don't seem to smell too bad. But if you are hanging out with people who are followers of Christ and you mess up just a little bit, you're going to realize it smells pretty bad to them and to God because it's messing up your life.

The Bible has a lot to say about fleeing immorality:

- "Flee from sexual immorality. All other sins a person commits are outside the body" (1 Corinthians 6:18).
- "Among you there must not be even a hint of sexual immorality" (Ephesians 5:3). A hint could be a look, an attitude, looking at a girl up and down, or checking out a guy's body.
- "Put to death, therefore, whatever belongs to your earthly nature: sexual immorality, impurity, lust, evil desires and greed, which is idolatry" (Colossians 3:5).

Note here that it says to put it to death. That means kill it: don't think like that, don't act like that, and don't do that thing anymore.

First Thessalonians 4:3 says, "It is God's will that you should be sanctified: that you should avoid sexual immorality." It says to "avoid sexual immorality." You have the power to steer around it. You don't have to keep messing up your life with sin. You might think, *But I just can't help it.* Yes, you can help it. Keep the lights on, stay out of the dark, and stay away from being alone with the opposite sex. The good news is that God has given you the power to have self-control.

Action Steps

Think of any sexual immorality you may have in your life, now or in the past. Include impure thoughts, pornography, or anything that can be interpreted as a hint of sexual immorality.

Take a moment now to pray and repent. *God, I'm sorry. I want to be totally clean, and I choose to use self-control in this area of my life.* Take a few minutes to meditate on 1 Corinthians 6:18 and Ephesians 5:3. Write them both here in your own words.

Say these two verses over and over and over again until they start getting down in your heart. Write them out to take them with you and memorize them today. Chew on them and make them a part of you so that anytime you get tempted with any immoral thought or action, you're ready. Instead of following through with that action (or even just continuing to think about it), pull these verses out as an act of self-control. You don't do this because you feel like it, but you force yourself

to remember the right way, the godly way, the honorable way to respond. Keep practicing this, and you will be free.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 3

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Freedom from Drugs and Alcohol

Do not get drunk on wine, which leads to debauchery.
Instead, be filled with the Spirit.

EPHESIANS 5:18

Write this verse out in your own words.

Debauchery includes behavior involving sex, drugs, alcohol, and such things that are often considered immoral. When people get drunk or high, they are far more likely to do things they'd never do if they were sober. Drinking can lead to some really stupid decisions. If drinking or doing drugs is one of those things you have continually messed up on, it's time for you to get a handle on it. It doesn't matter if your family drinks or not. You don't have to be enslaved to drinking anymore.

Some people feel that because their families have problems with drinking or doing drugs, they are just doomed to give in to it. You need to understand that the Bible says you have the power and the authority to live free from these vices. Besides, the joy that God gives you is way better than the high that any beer, whiskey, or weed could give you. Don't get full of the world. Get filled with the Holy Spirit; get full of God. Let God invade every part of your life.

If getting drunk or high has been a temptation for you or if this has been a problem in the past, grab hold of today's verse and cram it down inside you. Decide, *I am not going to put up with this anymore. I am not going to act like this is just some*

little problem I have. This is a sin. It's messing me up, and I'm going to stop once and for all. No more will I allow this area to rule over me. Next time I feel like I want to grab a beer or go to a party, I am going to reach for the Word of God instead. I am going to reach for Ephesians 5:18, and I am going to let it come out of my mouth. Instead of filling myself with something to numb my brain, I'm going to let God fill me with his Holy Spirit!

The Bible says in Hebrews 4:12 that the Word of God is sharp. It is living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword. It will make you sharp. It will make you strong because it will fill you with the power of God as you continue to meditate on it.

Action Steps

Write Ephesians 5:18 on an index card or make it your phone's wallpaper and take it with you all day, especially if this is an area in life you need to repent of. It is time to mature in faith. Quit making excuses in your life and instead say, *In Jesus' name, I am going to be free of this once and for all. I am too strong, and I've been around God too long to keep walking around filling my life with this garbage and acting like it's just another problem. It's time for me to grow up.*

If drinking or getting high is not a problem area for you, then make a commitment now that you'll never even start. Promise yourself now that you'll stay pure and free for the rest of your life. Either way, allow God to fill you up every single day.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 4

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Deal With Your Own Sin

The word of God is alive and active.

HEBREWS 4:12

There are so many other areas we could talk about—other things that may have dirtied your life or areas you need to clean up. For every sin that you have had a problem with, that has messed up your life with garbage, there is a verse to deal with it. Instead of thinking, *Okay, I can conquer this with my own mental willpower and try to get over it*, you can say, *I'm going to find a Scripture passage that has to do with this sin I'm dealing with and use the power of God to flush these out of my life. I am going to quit walking around like a baby with a dirty diaper.*

Maybe stealing is something you struggle with. For you, there is Ephesians 4:28: “Anyone who has been stealing must steal no longer, but must work, doing something useful with their own hands, that they may have something to share with those in need.”

Maybe pornography has had a grip on your life. Your thoughts are filled with images that control you. God will set you free as you wash those thoughts with the Word of God day and night. Psalm 101:3 says, “I will not look with approval on anything that is vile. I hate what faithless people do; I will have no part in it.”

Maybe the thing that controls you is your temper. You've let anger dictate your life. When you're angry, you just spew garbage on everyone around you. Here are some verses you can use:

- “‘In your anger do not sin’: Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold” (Ephesians 4:26–27).

- “Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry” (James 1:19).

Hebrews 4:12 says that “the word of God is alive and active.” Take the verses that apply to your situation and let God’s Word come ALIVE in you to help you take control of your life again.

Action Steps

Whatever you are dealing with, the Bible has the answer. We encourage you to look back at all the different verses we have discussed over the past few days and at those verses you have meditated on this week. The Holy Spirit will highlight the areas of your life he wants to specifically deal with. Write the references here for the verses you are especially going to concentrate on in the coming weeks.

Decide right now that you are going to learn how to deal with your own sins and that nobody has to convince you that you really do have a sin problem. No one is exempt from this heart work. We all have to deal with something. Most of the time, that’s what revival and camps are all about: trying to convince you that you have sin in your life so you will repent. But as a mature believer, you don’t have to be convinced. You know you have dirt in your life that only Jesus can cleanse.

Decide that you are not going to walk around with a hard heart, waiting until your sin gets so bad that it’s obvious to the

whole world before you repent. At the first little sign of stench, you're going to get that smell out of your life. Then you are going to learn how to control your own life so that you don't keep sinning and messing up in the same area again and again for the rest of your life.

Remember, it's not cute if you are still filling your diapers as a teenager. It's not cute if you're walking around with a bunch of sin in your life that you should have grown out of by now. You grow out of it by finding verses that deal with the specific sin and then memorizing them, meditating on them, and cramming them into your heart until God begins to transform you so that your natural reaction is not to do that sin but to grab your Bible and fight all temptation the same way Jesus did.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 5

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Why does the Bible use the term *fruit of the Spirit* when it talks about self-control? How do you grow self-control in your life, and why is that important? Discuss the idea of a teenager in dirty diapers and how that affects people around them. How do you really grow up and overcome sin in your life? What specific verses are you using to blast sin out of your life?

Week 8

Why Music Matters

Day 1

What's behind the Music?

“I will make music to the LORD.”

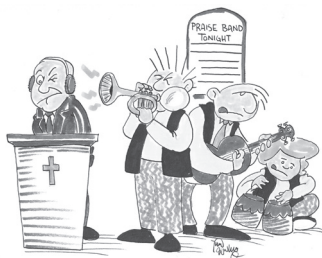
JUDGES 5:3 NLT

If Jesus has changed your heart, then his ways, his thoughts, and his ideas should affect every area of your life, including the music you listen to.

Why was music created?

The Bible talks about angels making music to the Lord in heaven, blowing their trumpets and playing their harps. Music was first created to glorify God. It was created as a way of expressing his awesomeness.

Today, every type of culture and religion has its own style of music. There is nothing wrong with music. It was created to glorify God. The problem is with the way people express themselves in the music. Some people say a certain style of music is wrong, such as rock and roll or heavy metal. But style is not the issue. The content and spirit behind the music and the spirit of the person who is writing and performing the music are the issues.



Musicians write songs based on their experiences, good and bad. Some write about alcohol, drugs, immorality, or other

influences. They may be trying to prove a point or simply expressing their thoughts or feelings. Some musicians take the gifts that God has given them and choose to use them for themselves or for the world. Some are using their gifts to promote anti-God ideas. If these musicians are not Christians, they are probably using ideas that are not from the Lord. If their ideas are not from the Lord, there is only one other source for them.

Why does it matter what music we listen to? As music enters your ears, you think about the words, often continuously. Then these words influence your mind. The Holy Spirit may warn you that certain music is not good for you. It is scary when a person ignores the warnings and thinks, *I am going to listen to this music, period*. What if the person behind the music is held captive by sin, rebellious against God, and totally controlled by their old nature? By listening, you're letting that person's rebellion against God influence you.

Remember, you have been transformed by the renewing of your mind. If Scripture has renewed your mind and you keep listening to unbiblical music, it tears down the Word of God that was planted in your mind. You may want to think God's thoughts, not what anybody else is thinking. But if you listen to the music of the ungodly, then their thoughts, ideas, and priorities will affect you, even though you may not want them to.

Action Steps

As an experiment today, pay careful attention to any music that you hear. Then ask yourself these questions:

Who wrote that?

What was in that person's heart?

What was in that person's mind?

What kind of experience did it come from?

What is that person trying to communicate?

Begin thinking differently about music.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 6

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Are You Being Tricked?

“Do not follow the crowd in doing wrong.”

EXODUS 23:2

This week we are considering the music we listen to. Music all over the world has become a subculture—a sort of connect group within a group. Teenagers in any middle school or high school in America listen to certain kinds of music, whether it is pop, heavy metal, rap, or some other style. Such teenagers may know all the groups playing that style and all the things they sing about. They may have all the latest CDs or downloads and recognize the music videos by those groups. They may even begin to dress and act like the musicians.

When a group within a culture acts and speaks in a distinct way, that group becomes a subculture. You may not even realize that you wear the same style as they do or that you wear your hair a certain way. You may not notice that you have a certain type of attitude and say the same words used by the musicians you listen to. **A subculture sucks you in, and you may not even realize it.**

You are being trained to think the way they think, to sing the way they sing, to look the way they look, and to act the way they act with the same attitude. The Bible speaks very clearly about this in Exodus 23:2, essentially saying, “Do not give in to peer pressure.” Do not do what the world wants you to do just because the world wants you to do it. Just because these people are famous rappers, pop divas, or rock stars does not mean that what they say or do is right. It doesn’t mean that the way they dress is right.

Are you letting these groups or your peers tell you what to think? Do you let them tell you what's cool and what's not cool? You have to be strong and realize that their philosophies and their lifestyles are affecting the way you think and the way you live. And if they are not living a Christian life, they're tricking you, and you may not even realize it.

Action Steps

Take a good look at the music you listen to and the artists you like. Compare the words of their music with the Word of God. Do their words agree with God's Word?

What does God's Word have to say about the things they're singing about?

In what ways have you been influenced by their style, words, or attitudes?

If their words agree with God's Word, then listen to their music. If not, don't listen to it because you may get tricked, and as a result, your foundation in Christ will not be stable. If you live on the edge of sin, it is easier to fall.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 7

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

What's a Spiritual Song?

Speak to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs.

EPHESIANS 5:19 AMP

Take a few minutes to memorize this verse. What exactly does this mean to you?

When we talk about the music we should listen to, does this mean we should only listen to church songs or hymns? Or should we sing very spiritual songs instead of listening to rock and roll? No, that is not what it means.

Music is an expression of your heart, an expression of an idea. It's an expression of something you are thinking about or something going on inside you. These are the things that inspire people when they write songs. When it comes to music, you have to start asking yourself, *Is the music I am listening to glorifying God? Is it lifting him up?* You might think it's just mediocre music, not really of the devil, just mediocre. But is mediocre good enough?

Do you want to be a mediocre Christian? Do you want to have a mediocre walk with God? What do you want to have playing in your mind all day? There's no easier way to keep thoughts and praise of God in your mind than the music you listen to. The Bible says that if you are going to sing a song, then

let it be a spiritual song. Let the song talk about how awesome God is, how cool he is, how great he is.

Instead of wasting your energy glorifying your ideas, your experiences, or your way of life, sing songs that lift up the King of kings and the Lord of lords.

Action Steps

Write Ephesians 5:19 in your own words.

How can you practically apply this truth to your life today?

Daily Bible reading: Luke 8

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Does Your Music Lift Jesus Up?

Hate what is evil; cling to what is good.

ROMANS 12:9

It is interesting to me that a person can meditate on the Word of God—they read it, learn it, and memorize it—and then they put on their headphones and listen to secular music that robs them of their peace and joy. Afterward, that person may lose confidence in God and even believe they are falling away from God.

In this verse from Romans, Paul admonished us to remove what is evil from our lives and focus instead on everything that is good. With our minds set on these things, our mouths will lift up and glorify God.

When I was a teenager, I was a rock and roller. After I started following the Lord, I still liked my rock and roll. I listened to a little bit of Christian music, but I liked the other stuff. I didn't think the words really affected me. One day as I was driving in my car with the music on, I found myself singing the words to the song. Though I was a young follower of Christ, I wondered why I was letting those words come out of my mouth. I thought, *These words are not lifting God up. These are stupid words.* I decided then that I was going to shut off the secular music and turn on the godly music.

As you continue to seek after Jesus and renew your mind in his Word, you will notice the way evil is affecting you. You may not have noticed before. As you grow, you will get to the place where you actually start craving the good things of God.

Action Steps

Challenge yourself today to shut off anything that is not lifting Jesus up. Do not let it go into your mind or come out of your mouth if it is not lifting up Jesus. I had to ask myself, *If this music is not affecting me, then why do I find myself singing the words?*

Music wraps up someone's values in a palatable package so that other people will like them. Music makes you want to listen to what they're singing about. It's like a wolf in sheep's clothing. It seems friendly, but it's still a wolf, planting ideas in your mind. You have to be smart enough to see through the lies. You have the responsibility to put godly things into your mind—no one else can do that for you.

What values does the music you listen to stand for? Sex outside of marriage? Drugs? Rebellion toward authority? Disrespect toward the opposite sex?

If you are honest, does the music you listen to bring you closer to or further away from God?

Make a choice to shut off ungodly music today.

YOU WILL NEVER ATTAIN SOMETHING YOU'VE
NEVER HAD UNTIL YOU DO SOMETHING YOU'VE
NEVER DONE.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Finding Jesus Bands

“A good tree cannot bear bad fruit, and a bad tree cannot bear good fruit. Every tree that does not bear good fruit is cut down and thrown into the fire. Thus, by their fruit you will recognize them.”

MATTHEW 7:18–20

How do you tell if a band that professes to be Christian is really Christian? There are a lot of groups today that claim to be Christian bands, but when they cross over into secular music, they often stop talking about Jesus at their concerts. How can you tell if it's a group that you want to influence you? Let me give you a couple of hints.

First, look at the lifestyles of the group members. Read articles about them and their interviews. Find out what they're talking about and what they're thinking about. Think about what's going on inside them. Ask yourself if their goal is really to lift up Jesus or just to be expressive and creative with music. It is really important to do this.

Some people are barely saved before they start banging out music that they call Christian. They don't have a solid foundation, and they aren't mature in their faith yet, but they have a lot of people following them, listening to their lyrics as if they were gospel. Be careful—people are just human. We cannot idolize them the way people of the world idolize rock or pop stars. Pop stars come and go, but Jesus doesn't. He stays the same forever.

Another way you can tell if a band is really Christian is to read their lyrics. Ask yourself these questions:

- *What do the lyrics talk about?*

- *How is the band trying to influence me?*
- *What ideas are they trying to communicate to me?*
- *Is that something I really want in my head?*

Even if the message isn't negative—even if it's neutral—it's occupying your brain space, and if it's not helping you grow closer to God, is that what you want?

Action Steps

If you haven't done it by now, have a party. Go into your room and check all your playlists and anything else that isn't 100 percent glorifying to God. Then start deleting music files. Take those songs, posters, and any other musical paraphernalia you have and destroy them. Update your playlists and snap those CDs. Jump on them! Stomp on them!

Give thanks to God for setting you free from this garbage in your mind and in your life. Thank him for putting godly things there. Yes, it is radical and wild, but that is what being a Christian is all about. No one can stand in the winner's circle unless they are willing to pay the price.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 10

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

The Soundtrack of Your Life: Make Some Decisions

Whether you eat or drink or whatever you do,
do it all for the glory of God.

1 CORINTHIANS 10:31

Our verse today says that no matter what you're doing, do it for God. That includes your music. As a result of the music you listen to, different things will come into your life. Music has a big effect on what you do. Think about how music makes you act.

What about Your Headphones?

When people listen to music in a public place, they often use headphones or earbuds. Maybe you use headphones when you're listening to your music at school while you're sitting next to people you should be talking to. Maybe your music is distracting you from opportunities to develop meaningful relationships with people at school or at home, people who can help you grow stronger in the Lord. Think about it: you're listening to music because that subculture has sucked you in.

For some people, their headphones have become like an appendage—part of their head. Maybe you need to decide to put down your phone for a week or to listen to music for only an hour a day. Some people are so addicted to music that they don't know what to do when they're not listening to something. Shut off the music, think about God, and get into the Word. Have some quiet time with God.

What about Your Room?

Music can also affect how we decorate the spaces we spend time in. Does the music you listen to influence the decor of your bedroom? Maybe you need to decide whether that poster is glorifying God or not. Is it just a heathen rock group or a picture of girls or guys? If Jesus walked into your bedroom, what would he think? We don't have to wonder because he is truly in there. Rearrange your room so it's clean and godly. Make it cool but "godly" cool, not "worldly" cool.

What about Dancing?

Music and dancing are also inherently linked. There are lots of kinds of dances that are amazing and an artistic or cultural expression or even a sign of worship to the Lord. However, not all dances glorify God, such as the dances many young people go to. I went to dances all the time when I was a teen. After I became a Christian, I began to ask myself why. Here I was at a dance, moving my body and expressing myself to music that didn't glorify God. The whole experience did not glorify God at all. I was just trying to pick up some girl. I decided that I would quit going to those types of dances.

You may think I'm taking this too far. But we need to think about our motives for what we do and ask ourselves, *Can I do this with a clear conscience and a pure heart?* Being a radical follower of Christ means going "too far" in the right direction so that you no longer get caught up in the wrong direction.

Action Steps

List some things involving music that you need to give up or change in order to glorify God.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Now list what you can do to replace those things with activities that better glorify God.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Get with your accountability partner and decide together to live sanctified lives.

God is not trying to steal your fun. He is trying to make you into a world changer.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 11

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

God's Idea of Fun

Since, then, you have been raised with Christ, set your hearts on things above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God. Set your minds on things above, not on earthly things.

COLOSSIANS 3:1–2

We have been talking all week about how a relationship with Jesus should affect every part of your life, including the music you listen to. You can also apply these principles to the type and amount of media you consume—like movies, TV shows, and social media content. Today we'll give you some alternatives.

You know, some people think Christianity is the religion that says not to do this and not to do that. They think that God doesn't want you to have any fun, that he cheats you out of a good life, and that anything fun is a sin. Well, that just isn't true. The problem is that the world's idea of fun is mostly sin. God's idea of fun is righteous, radical, life-giving, and world changing.

There are a number of incredible Christian groups that play just about any type of music: pop, rock, dance music, hip-hop, rap, folk, and blues—you name it. You can glorify God in the style of music you really like to listen to without compromising your values and conscience.

But remember, the world does not revolve around music; it revolves around Jesus. People often continually blast their music because they're afraid to deal with some of the issues in their lives: their hurts, troubles, or frustrations. They play their music loudly so they can drown out their tormenting thoughts. All day, they keep their minds occupied with music, music, music. When I realized I was doing that, I pulled out the sound system

from my car. I didn't want to be tempted to listen to music all the time. I wanted to have more time to think and pray.

When we keep our minds set on Jesus (Colossians 3:1–2), he fills us with REAL LIFE so that we no longer feel the need to numb our emotions and drown out our sorrows and restlessness with crazy, loud music or hours of social media. We can find true joy and peace in the little things: playing with a puppy, participating in sports competitions, hiking in the mountains, playing games with friends or family. We can experience what life was meant to be because our hearts are set on Jesus; even in silence, we are at ease because we have peace with God.

Action Steps

This ends our week of talking about music. Decide now to put righteous, godly music in your heart, in your mind, and in your life so you can be transformed. If you don't know of any good Christian music, ask your Christian friends, go to a Christian bookstore, or look it up. Write down what you discover, including bands, albums, or music genres to explore.

You will love how your heart leans into Jesus when you listen to music that glorifies him. You will have a peace that you didn't have before because you will "set your mind on things above, not on earthly things" (Colossians 3:2). You will grow even faster in the Lord because you will no longer be pulling yourself down with the influence of the world.

Do you still remember the verses the Holy Spirit was highlighting for you this week? If not, take a few minutes to learn them again today.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 12

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What are some of the messages from secular music that you have liked the most in the past? How many hours a week do you think you listen to music? What percentage of that music is about Jesus? What did the Lord speak to you this week in your quiet times? Did you get rid of any music this week? What is some great music you can share with each other to listen to this week?

Week 9

How to Have a Pure Heart

Day 1

What Is a Pure Heart?

“Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.”

MATTHEW 5:8

Jesus made this promise during his Sermon on the Mount. He was making this commitment to all who would dare to have a pure and undefiled heart after God. As followers of Christ, we have to be people with pure motives and pure hearts. *Purity* simply means “without corruption.” Some people give God lip service, meaning that they say all the right things, but a bunch of garbage is corroding their hearts. They go to church and Christian events, yet on the inside, sin corrupts so much of their lives.

All ungodly behavior starts with an impure heart. It is so much easier to remain pure before the Lord when your heart is pure, when you are genuinely seeking him and genuinely wanting to keep every part of your life absolutely clean.

Jesus made a promise: if you keep your heart pure, you are going to be blessed—so blessed, in fact, that you get to see God. You’re going to see him at work in your own heart. You’re going to see him at work in other people’s lives. You’re going to see him at work in this world. You can see the evidence of his work and his blessing all around you.

It’s amazing how much God can be doing all around you, but if your heart is not pure, you will not see it. It’s not enough just to have a pure body. You have to have a pure heart. The commitment to purity doesn’t start with the commitment not to have sex until you’re married. It starts with the commitment to have a pure heart and to keep your thoughts pure.

Action Steps

Take some time right now to think about things you may have in your heart that have been corrupting your thoughts or walk with God in any way. Maybe they corrupt the way you look at people or your perspective of life. List these things here.

Ask God to forgive you and cleanse you of any kind of corruption right now. Meditate on Matthew 5:8 all day today and claim the promise. Pray with freedom, *Lord, thank you for forgiving me and making my heart pure. I've given everything to you, so now I want to see you today in my heart and in my life. In Jesus' name. Amen.*

Daily Bible reading: Luke 13

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

A Clean Heart

Who may ascend the mountain of the LORD? Who may stand in his holy place? The one who has clean hands and a pure heart, who does not trust in an idol or swear by a false god.

PSALM 24:3-4

Take a few minutes to meditate on this Scripture passage. Write out what you think this says in your own words.

The psalmist David was asking whom God would accept to be in his holy presence. In other words, whom will God allow to be close to him? To whom will he reveal the secrets of his heart?

David answered these questions: those who have clean hands and a pure heart. If what you do with your hands is clean and pure and if what's going on inside your heart is clean and pure, you can be close with God. God is looking for a new generation of young people with clean hands and pure hearts. He is looking for young people who will choose to hang out with him and draw near to him. He is looking for people who are constantly thinking not just about what they do but about what's going on in their hearts. Is your heart clean? Is it acceptable before God? Is it pure?

Jesus washed your heart with forgiveness when you first gave your life to him. He cleansed your heart of all impurities; now it's important to make sure that you receive his cleansing

and forgiveness every day and that you do everything with a pure motive and a pure perspective. Make sure a heart that longs for God motivates everything you do.

God allows only one kind of person to get close to him, only one kind of person to hang out with him. Only one kind of person could, as Moses did, go up and be on the top of the mountain to hang out with God. Only those with pure lives and pure hearts get to really connect with God. It's not about being perfect or even trying to be perfect. It's about staying so close to Jesus that you know his heart. The moment you start drifting, you ask for his help because you don't want anything to come between the two of you—you want to stay connected to him. You are honest with him, you keep nothing from him, and he helps you in every situation all day. That's having a pure heart before him.

Today aim to have a pure heart all day. Think only of things that would glorify him.

Action Steps

You may think it's only necessary to get forgiveness if you do something really bad. But we humans pretty much need forgiveness daily for wrong thoughts and attitudes.

Spend some time right now and ask the Lord to shine a spotlight on any corruption in your heart that's not pleasing to him or on any "idols" in your life and write these things down. Idols are things you have trusted in instead of trusting in God.

Ask him to forgive you, cleanse your mind and heart, and give you a clean heart today. Now take some time and thank

God for loving you enough to correct you, to get the junk out of your heart, and to allow you to be close to his heart.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 14

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Hearing from God

Those who live in accordance with the Spirit have their minds set on what the Spirit desires.

ROMANS 8:5

This week we are talking about having a pure heart. We are talking about being someone who always has pure motives and a pure heart. It doesn't mean you're perfect, but it means that you continually draw near to God and want to please him with your thoughts and everything you are and do. We've discussed several advantages of having a pure heart. Can you list some of them here?

When you have a pure heart, the Bible says even your thoughts please God because you're not absorbed with yourself anymore, but you're focusing on what the Holy Spirit is saying to you and what he desires (Romans 8:5). Here is a glimpse of what happens when you have a pure heart. When you keep your mind, your heart, and your motives totally clean and bathed in the blood of Jesus, asking for forgiveness and focusing your energies on doing only what is pure and right, you will notice that the Holy Spirit anoints your thought life. Your mind will be cleared up enough so that you can hear things from God that you never heard before. When you have a pure heart and think pure thoughts, God is so pleased that his Spirit finds it easy to be at home in your thought life. Then you can start hearing

things from God's Spirit because you have "cleaned out the pipes" enough to allow his Word to flow into you.

What an incredible advantage it is to have a pure heart! You'll be led by the Spirit and hear things from God that many people never get to hear. You will be way different from the average young person who just goes to church on Sundays but then tries to get away with everything they can throughout the rest of the week. With a pure heart, you can tap into the Holy God, who created this whole universe.

Action Steps

Read Romans 8:5, memorize it, and meditate on it. Write it on an index card or make it your phone's wallpaper and carry it with you all day. Practice paying attention to what God is speaking to you in the moment. When thoughts come to your mind that you think are from God but you are not really sure, write them down.

You'll be amazed when you notice how many things God is speaking to you—wanting you to do things and giving you wisdom for making decisions and teaching you how to act in relationships at school, how to witness, how to do better at your job, or how to get better grades. Perhaps he'll give you supernatural remembrance of things that you've heard and studied for your tests. He'll tell you how much he loves you and how you belong to him. But it all starts with a pure heart. Try it today and see how it goes!

Daily Bible reading: Luke 15

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Purity in Your Relationships

Flee the evil desires of youth and pursue righteousness, faith, love and peace, along with those who call on the Lord out of a pure heart.

2 TIMOTHY 2:22

Read 2 Timothy 2:22. What does this verse personally mean to you today?

Take a few minutes to memorize this verse right now. In this letter, Paul was dealing with probably one of the biggest struggles young people have. As you begin to develop physically, it is only normal for you to notice people of the opposite sex. But the Bible is clear on this subject. Impure thoughts are called lust. In a depraved world, it is normal to have lustful thoughts. But you, as a man or woman of God, need to get smart and guard yourself. Run from these things and keep your heart pure.

One of the biggest challenges young people face in their quest to stay pure is that pornography is all over the internet. People on video doing what only married people should do in private causes the erosion of purity from a person's mind and a perversion of what God meant sex to be all about.

Whether you are a guy or a girl, here are some reasons to never look at porn:

1. It encourages human sex trafficking. Many of those videos are shot with men, women, and even children who have been kidnapped or trafficked. Watching the videos makes more money for the people who produce the movies, rewards them for stealing people from their families, and encourages them to keep producing the videos.
2. It objectifies humans by teaching the viewer that the person on the video only has physical value. Porn does not recognize their dignity as a human being.
3. It distorts your idea of what great sex should be and perverts it into something dirty. God, not Hollywood, invented sex. He knows how we humans can have the best, most fulfilling sex only in marriage.
4. After watching porn, you may put unrealistic expectations on the person you will marry one day, expecting them to do what the porn actors do, which you or your spouse will never be able to live up to and which is not based on love.
5. It causes an empty void in your own soul, taunting you to crave even more perverted videos. This oppression in your mind and habits will destroy every romance you ever have. Lust is never satisfied. It only gets more and more perverted as you feed it.

Our pursuit of a pure heart can't just be contained in a lot of nice, flowery words. It has to come down to gut-level honesty. Many guys look at girls and have lustful thoughts. Many young ladies think sensually about guys they might like. Wash your mind of this garbage. Look people in the eyes rather than up and down their bodies to see what they look like. Care about them as people. Look at the opposite sex as brothers or sisters, not for your own pleasure.

First Timothy 5:2 says to treat older women as you would your mother and younger women as sisters. This can apply to young women as well—treat older guys like a father and younger guys like brothers. When you think of them as family, it's easier to have pure thoughts toward them. The point is to look at others as valuable human beings who have a lot to offer this world. They may be really hurting, betrayed, and broken. They may have been treated in an impure way their whole lives. If you look at them in an impure way, you add to the problem rather than protecting them from it.

The Bible says, “To the pure, all things are pure” (Titus 1:15). In other words, if your heart is pure—genuinely pure, genuinely forgiven, and thinking on the things of God—then when you look at people of the opposite sex, the first thing that will pop into your mind will be something positive, holy, and pure. It's time for a new generation of young people to commit to having pure hearts in the way they look at people of the opposite sex.

Action Steps

Today, practice this: As you go to school or work, practice looking people in their eyes. As you look them in the eyes, just imagine how you would be looking at them if you were Jesus. What would you be thinking about them while you're talking to them?

If you have struggled with looking at porn, ask Jesus now to forgive you and cleanse your heart and mind. Talk to your accountability friend or your group leader so they can help you in your journey to live completely pure.

Write today's verse from 2 Timothy on an index card or make it a wallpaper on your phone and carry them with you. Meditate on it all day. As you interact with people today, practice having a pure heart in the way you see them.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 16

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Forgiven

Create in me a pure heart, O God,
and renew a steadfast spirit within me.

PSALM 51:10

Rewrite this verse in your own words.

Take a few minutes right now to meditate on this verse.

David prayed this prayer after he had really blown it with Bathsheba. You can read about this situation in 2 Samuel 11–12. David committed adultery with Bathsheba, another man's wife, and got her pregnant. Then he sent her husband to his death so he could marry her. Later, when David realized he had sinned, he came running back to God and cried out for God to create a pure heart within him.

Maybe you have been impure in the past in a relationship with someone. It's time for you to pray the same prayer that David prayed. Say, *God, create in me a clean heart. Lord, I don't want to be harassed for the rest of my life by the impure things I've done in my past. In Jesus' name I pray. Amen.*

You don't need to be tormented all your life with a guilty conscience. Many times, people who previously have been sexually involved replay like a videotape in their minds the things that happened. They watch it over and over and over

again. They fight the battle in their minds because of what they are thinking about all the time.

If you have been sexually involved or into any kind of impurity, do these things anytime you think of the memories: (1) ask God to forgive you and to cleanse your heart and your thoughts, (2) forgive yourself and forgive the other person for taking advantage of the moment (sometimes the hardest thing to do is to forgive yourself for violating your own conscience), and (3) take some time to pray for that person. Instead of just thinking about the things you did together, look at that person the way Jesus would. Pray that God will change their life and draw them closer to the Lord. Also pray that they will come to find who Jesus really is and allow him to radically change their life.

Maybe you haven't messed up physically, but you have messed up a lot mentally. Some people pride themselves on the fact that they are virgins physically, but in their minds, they are not virgins at all. If this describes you, you need to repent just as much as those who have actually committed the physical act of sex (Matthew 5:28).

David cried out for a pure heart. We have been talking about purity all week long. God wants you to be pure in your heart and in your mind as well as in your body. You cannot pridefully look down at somebody who has messed up physically if, in your heart, you lust or you think about other people in an impure way. God wants you to be a person with a pure heart as well as a pure body.

Action Steps

Look up Psalm 51 and make David's prayer your own: *God, create in me a clean heart regarding the way I look at people. Create in me a clean heart in the way I have been involved with people in the past.*

Take some time right now to pray over the people you have been involved with in the past or whom you have thought

about in an impure way. When you leave your quiet time, your heart and mind can be pure toward these people, and you will have forgiven yourself once and for all.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 17

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

The Motives of Your Heart

“You, my son Solomon, acknowledge the God of your father, and serve Him with wholehearted devotion and with a willing mind, for the LORD searches every heart and understands every desire and every thought.”

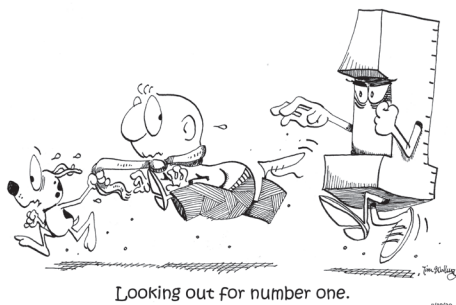
1 CHRONICLES 28:9

Having a pure heart starts with motives. It doesn't only have to do with having pure relationships with people when it comes to sex. It begins with being pure in the way you look at life and relationships; the way you treat your parents, your teachers, and your boss and other leaders; and even the way you do your homework. It has to do with being honest, others oriented, and servant hearted. Having a pure heart means treating people the way Jesus would treat them. God weighs motives. He doesn't just care about what you do; he also cares about why you're doing it—the motives of your heart. He wants your motives to be pure. He measures the motives, and he knows what they are. That's God's agenda.

Your goal to please the Lord in life is not just about doing pleasing things but also about doing pleasing things with the right motive, a motive that's generated out of a pure love for God and the desire to do what's right. You may do “right things” sometimes because you think you will get noticed or because someone is looking at you. But you can tell if your motives are pure when you are still committed and determined to do what is right even though no one will notice.

Somebody might want to be the captain of the basketball team because it fills something in her ego. A person might want to be a boss because he likes to tell people what to do. Neither

person has a pure heart or considers that it might be better for the team if someone else is the captain or that the company will have more success if someone else is in charge. People with selfish motives always want their own way. In any kind of friendship or relationship, they don't think about God's best in the situation. Their thoughts are centered on themselves.



Action Steps

List some things that you've done or thought in your relationships with your friends or family that have come out of impure motives.

How can you correct these things?

Now ask God to forgive you and ask him for his mind and his heart so that you launch into every area of life with a pure heart that follows God with pure motives in everything you set your hand to do.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 18

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

A Heart Refined by God

The goal of this command is love, which comes from a pure heart and a good conscience and a sincere faith.

1 TIMOTHY 1:5

Take a few minutes right now to think about what this verse really means. Write down what you think the main point is.

This week we have been talking about having a pure heart in everything. Today's verse from 1 Timothy says that love coming from a pure heart is what this whole Christian life is about. We must love our neighbors, our enemies, people at school and work, and people of the opposite sex. God wants us to have a love that comes from a pure heart.

But how do we keep our minds and hearts pure as we love those around us? Philippians 4:8 gives us a clear picture of how to keep the mind and the heart pure: by dwelling in your mind on things that are awesome, excellent, and praiseworthy—things that will give glory to God. We know that you, as a young person, might think, *How in the world can I keep these great things in my mind when I am bombarded with so many bad things all day?* Well, it's not easy. It takes practice. You have to set your mind "on things above" (Colossians 3:2). You have to choose to set your mind on pure things. God has given you

the power to choose. Having a pure heart means your heart has been refined by him.

When gold or silver is refined, it is heated to extremely high temperatures, which causes the impurities to rise to the top. The refiners can then scoop off the impurities. God wants to do the same thing in your heart today and every day. He wants to heat up your heart. So fuse it with his Word as you keep your mind on whatever is pure. As the impurities come to the top, you repent. Then God scrapes the impurities off, and your whole life becomes a little purer. Then tomorrow he heats up your heart a little more, and more impurities come to the top. When you repent, he scrapes off these impurities too. Each day you get purer and purer. God will constantly refine your motives, relationships, and attitudes and make them purer.

Having a pure heart is a character trait that we should value above anything because, as Jesus promised in Matthew 5, those who have a pure heart will see God. Psalm 24 tells us that people with pure hearts will hang out on God's holy mountain and hear his voice as he speaks to them in their thoughts. When you seek a pure heart with everything in you, you can avoid becoming someone who is content to look like a Christian on the outside while inside they have a corrupt heart.

You must have a pure heart to keep your relationship with God right. You have to have a pure heart to pursue a relationship with the opposite sex that is holy and to keep a godly romance pure. A pure romance doesn't begin after you get in a relationship. It comes by practicing having a pure heart right now in everything you say and do.

Action Steps

Review your memory verses from this week. Chew on them all day. Practice fleeing youthful lust today. Today practice keeping your mind set on whatever is pure. Practice looking at people, right into their eyes, with a pure heart and with pure motives

and watch how God will begin to revolutionize your life. You'll walk closer and closer to the top of that holy mountain and hang out at the top with God, just like Moses did.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 19

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

What does it mean to have a pure or clean heart? Describe God's daily refining process and share how he did that with you this week. How can you set your mind "on things above" when you're bombarded with so many bad things? How can you think about the opposite sex in a way that honors God? How do you get a clean heart? What verses spoke to you the most this week, and why? How can you specifically pray for each person in your group?

Week 10

Relationships with the Opposite Sex

Day 1

Submit Your Passion to God

This is the will of God, your sanctification: that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each one of you know how to control his own body in holiness and honor, not in the passion of lust like the Gentiles who do not know God.

1 THESSALONIANS 4:3–5 ESV

Sanctification is a big word that simply means something is “set apart and made holy for God’s purposes.” Write out the meaning of this Scripture passage in your own words.

Over the past weeks, we’ve been talking about having a pure heart and a passion for God, for his Word, and for his lordship. Without that foundation, the words in the next few lessons will most likely ring hollow. This week calls for incredible trust that God knows this subject better than we do and that **his ways always work**.

You and I were created to be passionate people. We have the built-in ability to focus all our emotions and energy in one direction for good or for not so good. The passion God wants us to have for him often gets redirected, and I don’t have to tell you where.

Let’s admit the obvious: the opposite sex is mysterious and exciting. For many young people during the middle school and high school years, the excitement is as high as it will ever be. Believe it or not, God did that. He gave you the gift of passion for the opposite sex. But like any gift, we can misuse it. And

that's what has happened to countless young Christians who genuinely want to live passionately for God. The result is that their hearts are burned, their emotions are crushed, and, too many times, their futures are ruined.

One of the biggest struggles for young people in their walk with God is learning how to respond appropriately to their inner passions for the opposite sex. If you've ever been in a relationship with a girl or guy, you know that it's tough to think about much of anything else. And if you're not in a relationship, well, it's still tough to think about much of anything else. The dilemma is that few know how to be a great Christian friend to someone of the opposite sex.

It's time to get serious about your walk with God and what he says about the boyfriend-girlfriend thing. God wants you to have a lifetime of success with the opposite sex, so naturally, he wants you to do things his way.

We hope you didn't cringe while reading those last four words. You are heading toward adulthood, and for most young people, that means they want to do things *their* way. This is especially true in the whole arena of the opposite sex. As a young adult, you don't have too many things you can control, so understandably, you would at least like to control this. But the opposite sex is one area in which you need to be "out" of control. That is, God needs to have his control, not because he wants to ruin your life but because he wants this important area to be the best it can possibly be.

We have talked to hundreds of young people who were doing great with God until they got into a dating relationship and became distracted. One of these people is a guy named John. He passionately committed to the Lord when he was sixteen. He had enthusiastically plugged into his church group, but then he began to date girls who were not Christians. His motives were good; he was "trying to reach them for Christ." But he got trapped and tricked by the current dating system. He thought he needed a girlfriend. He ended up weeping bitterly

after compromising his virtue by having sex with a girl—a precious gift he had at one time pledged to save for his future wife. But he'd given it away in a moment of passion.

The same mistakes are made even when teens date others in their church. Fortunately, John came back to the Lord and got his life right. Not everyone makes it back because they think they are too far gone or have done too many things for God to forgive, and that is the real tragedy because there is always a way back. God will restore the life of every single person who comes to him with a heart that wants to change.

You should know that the following lessons in this book are not just filled with a few nice ideas for you to think about. How you respond to the ideas could determine your ability to live successfully for God during some of the most important years of your life.

Another thing you should know is that you won't find the answer to the most asked question from Christian teens: "How far is okay to go?" Why is that answer missing from this book? We've discovered that trying to answer that question encourages the wrong mentality—that we can stay as close as we can to the gates of hell as long as we don't fall in. We don't play that game in our lives, and we would never encourage another Christian to do it.

We cannot take a Christian version of what the world is doing and think that it is God's best. God has different ideas, and his ideas relating to the opposite sex will save your heart from getting crushed, keep your body pure until marriage, and keep you fired up spiritually.

Action Steps

Today we talked about the current dating system. Describe that system and how it has affected you or people you know.

How has dating affected others' commitment to God or yours if you've been involved in dating?

Ask the Lord to open your eyes this week to his ways of thinking about the opposite sex.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 20

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Put It to Death, or It Can Be Deadly

Put to death therefore what is earthly in you: sexual immorality, impurity, passion, evil desire, and covetousness, which is idolatry.

COLOSSIANS 3:5 ESV

Our world is plagued with the notion that everybody is fooling around with sex before marriage. One area of the world that has faced the devastating results of such immorality is Africa. Millions in Africa currently live with HIV, and hundreds of thousands have died from AIDS-related illnesses. The reason? Many have believed the lie that abstinence until marriage is impossible. And it's not a safe-sex issue. Hundreds of thousands thought they would be protected by this practice, yet the safe-sex line has failed to keep its promise.

God's way of safe sex is keeping it sacred within marriage. In regions of Africa (like Uganda), where they do adopt biblical principles and God's way of safe sex, the number of HIV/AIDS illnesses and deaths has gone down dramatically.

In America, because of the way movies and TV programs depict sex outside of marriage, you might feel like you're not normal if you wait. Hollywood glamorizes immorality, making it seem like anyone who wants to have any kind of real life has to fool around before he or she gets married. The entertainment industry only shows the exciting or passionate side of sex without showing the truth of what happens inside someone's heart when he or she gets involved sexually before marriage. We could tell you a thousand heartache stories, but you've probably already heard them.

God is looking for young people who love him and want to live passionately for him by standing up with pure lives

dedicated to him. No longer should you have to look down in shame, as if you are embarrassed about being a virgin or no longer sexually active. There are a lot of great reasons to stay pure. But if you're still not convinced that waiting for sex until marriage is the way to go, let me share a few reasons this week why waiting is your best possible decision.

Action Steps

Why do you think God wants you to stay pure and wait for marriage? List some good reasons to save sex for marriage that you know of so far.

If you've already been sexually active or have been struggling with impure thoughts, how has it affected your relationship with the Lord?

Our verse today was written to Christians and assumes that some of them had been involved in sexual immorality and all kinds of impurity, so you're not the only one who has struggled in this area. It's part of being on this earth. But now that you belong to Jesus and have the power of the Holy Spirit, God says you can put it to death.

Take some time to pray—confess everything to the Lord and ask him to forgive you. Ask him to give you some ideas on how to put those sins to death in your life and write them

down. Ask the Lord to give you a pure heart toward the opposite sex.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 21

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Avoid the Date-'Em- Then-Hate-'Em Cycle

Treat younger men as brothers, older women as mothers, and younger women as sisters, with absolute purity.

1 TIMOTHY 5:1–2

The first reason to wait until marriage to have sex is that you could be dating the future spouse of someone you know or even your future pastor!

When young people begin to date, few seem to take it seriously. They don't stop to consider whom the person they are dating might someday marry. We know a pastor who has his wife's high school boyfriend in his congregation. He has said from the pulpit, "Someone here has kissed my wife!" That might sound kind of wild, but it's true. The person you date will be someone's wife or husband someday. Treat them like you would want someone to treat your future spouse.

The Bible says in 1 Timothy 5:1–2 that we should treat the younger men and women in the church as brothers and sisters, with absolute purity. Wouldn't you want to treat the young women or men in your church the same way you'd want a person to treat your brother or sister—with purity?

Consider this fact: you and any sister or brother in Christ in your church have the same Father, a Father who can see everything you do. How would you feel if you had a daughter and you found out that someone was fooling around with her? What would you like to do to him? How do you think your heavenly Father feels when someone is fooling around with his daughter or son?

The second reason to wait until marriage to have sex is to avoid the date-'em-then-hate-'em cycle.

Most young people I've known over the years—from back in high school until today—do not know how to have a real friendship with someone of the opposite sex. When you do have a close friend, you usually say, "I know them too well to date them." Like anyone else, you'd like a few good friends who care about you. You may want to date them, though, because you think that dating will make a friendship stronger. When it doesn't work, you're fooled into believing, *The further physically I go with that person, the better friends we will be.*

Just the opposite is true. After a few dates, kissing tends to be the substitute of choice for real communication. Before long, kissing isn't quite as exciting, so more sexual involvement follows with the hope that it will make you closer. So the all-too-common scenario on most weekends goes something like this: You go on a date looking forward to real companionship because you're lonely or bored or because you just really need to talk to someone. But soon, communication gets tough, so you start kissing or going even further. Instead of finding the companionship you were seeking, you end up substituting a racing pulse for true communication. While a racing pulse and its consequences in the context of marriage are wonderful, when they're outside of marriage, they will leave you emptier than when you began. The very thing you want out of the relationship (a real friendship) is the very thing that physical involvement makes impossible.

As you make the commitment to avoid immorality before marriage, you will have a much greater possibility of having a real friendship with the person you date. Plus, you won't have any regrets if you break up (and fewer than 2 percent of marriages are from a high school relationship,² making breakups highly likely). The closeness you really want is impossible to find if you get involved sexually. So many dating relationships are completely severed after the couple has

intercourse. Respect is lost, and guilty consciences set in. It is not the way God intends the beautiful intimacy that is meant for marriage. Sex serves to enhance the closeness a couple has for each other only after they are married and committed to each other for life. It makes the relationship better because they chose to keep the order of things as God has planned it: friendship, love, marriage—then sex.

If you do not have a heart-to-heart friendship with a person, having sex will not give it to you. Getting physical before marriage only gives the relationship a false sense of closeness that isn't based on unconditional love. Sex before marriage truly is the destroyer of relationships. While this fact seems illogical to the world, it is the truth.

Action Steps

Describe how you would want someone of the opposite sex to treat your brother or sister.

What do you think Paul meant in 1 Timothy when he talked about treating young men and women as brothers or sisters, with absolute purity?

What is God's order of things in relationships, and how will understanding that affect your relationships and friendships with the opposite sex?

Daily Bible reading: Luke 22

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Wrong Place, Wrong Time

The man and his wife were both naked, but they felt no shame.

GENESIS 2:25 NLT

The third reason to wait until marriage to have sex is that you could be looking for love in all the wrong places.

Many young people think that if they could finally experience sexual intimacy, they would find real love. Countless young ladies have heard guys say the words, “If you love me, you’ll let me...” In a desperate hope for someone who really cares, young women have compromised their virtue. As a result, emptiness and depression begin to hound a love-starved teen.

The love and acceptance you need and desire cannot be found in a passionate moment of immorality. True love respects a person’s purity. A guy once asked me, “If it’s really love, isn’t it okay?” If it were real love, he would not even ask to have from a girl what only belongs to the one who commits to her for the rest of her life: her husband.

If sex equaled love, then prostitutes would be the happiest people in the world. As it turns out, they are some of the most miserable. Many times, teenagers, looking for the love and acceptance they wish their parents would give them, make desperate attempts to get love from relationships. They come up feeling emptier every time.

The fourth reason to wait until marriage to have sex is to be able to look your sexual partner in the eye.

The predictable question young people ask themselves after they lose their purity is, *Will they respect me tomorrow?* The answer is always *no*! And worse still, you won’t respect yourself either.

Sex in the context of marriage is pure and holy and is nothing to be ashamed of—when you're married. Genesis 2:25 says that both the man and his wife were naked, but they felt no shame. But shame came when Adam and Eve disobeyed God by eating the forbidden fruit. The Bible says that they realized they were naked and sewed fig leaves together for clothes. Then they hid from God because they were ashamed (Genesis 3:7).

After giving away the precious gift of your purity in an immoral situation, there is only one way you can feel: ashamed. Many people feel ugly or dirty or like a dark cloud follows them around wherever they go. It is nothing to be proud of for a girl or a guy. Yes, it's true that you have hormones and that sex obviously feels good, or people wouldn't keep going back for more. It wouldn't be a temptation if it wasn't alluring and fun. But just because you have a sex drive doesn't make you unique—so does the entire animal kingdom. God has made us qualitatively different from other mammals. We have the ability to say yes or no to our natural desires and instincts; animals don't.

I don't say this in a tough-guy way; I believe it with all my heart: A real, godly man controls himself and treats young ladies with respect. And a real, godly woman treats herself with respect by letting her boyfriend know her limits before the situation goes too far.

Many young Christians see their entire walk with God erode because they become ashamed of how far they've gone sexually. It is amazing to think that a few moments of passion could make someone turn his or her back on God and miss the promised abundant life here on earth—or even the promised eternal life in heaven. But teenagers are taking that chance every day.

When I was a church leader, there was an eighteen-year-old girl in my church whom I'll call Jennifer. She knew the Lord, but she was very insecure. To compensate for her feelings of inferiority, she acted like the cutest thing God ever made.

While she attempted to live and act like a Christian, she also had a seductive side to her. She had perfected a magazine-cover look to attract guys. While she thought it was all totally innocent, the guys around her were falling all over themselves to get her attention. Then Jennifer got pregnant by a guy she had been dating—an older guy (because dating older guys is cool, right?) who did not even go to church, much less love the Lord. After she found out she was going to have a baby, everything changed, and she struggled with her walk with Christ even after she apologized to her Christian community.

We as the body of Christ can gather around people like Jennifer, reaching out to them when they feel like they've failed God and their community. Instead of standing in judgment when people are at their lowest, we can make a difference in their lives by loving them and encouraging them that God can restore them back to himself.

Action Steps

Write out what you learned today. What is the difference between real love and sexual intimacy?

What does the phrase “Real love respects a person’s purity” mean to you?

What is the best way to respect yourself and feel good about yourself when it comes to decisions about purity?

Daily Bible reading: Luke 23

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

A Matter of Life and Death

Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect.

ROMANS 12:2 ESV

Take a few minutes to meditate and think about this verse.
Write out what it means to you.

To conform to something is to behave the way a group or society expects you to. If you allow your thinking to conform to youth culture, you may think that sexual promiscuity (having casual sex with different partners) is normal and safe. But is it?

The fifth reason to wait until marriage to have sex is that it's a matter of life and death.

We all know about sexually transmitted diseases (STDs), but nearly every teenager I've met thinks an STD could never happen to them. There are so many different STDs, including gonorrhea, syphilis, herpes, and HPV. Many of these are excruciatingly painful, and some have no cure. Some STDs can cause you to be infertile, meaning you can never have children, while others cause the deaths of thousands each year.

Through public school education, magazine articles, and so-called scientific studies, the world will consistently try to convince you that as long as you practice "safe sex," you are

“safe.” The idea, of course, is to use condoms. The problem is that many are defective. People get pregnant using condoms, and people get STDs. If you use a condom and think you’ll be safe, you’re fooling yourself. You’re taking a big risk for you and your partner. We think young Christians are smarter than that.

This all sounds pretty scary and maybe even a little hopeless, but the good news is that no sexually transmitted disease can infect you if you follow God’s plan and wait until marriage for all sexual contact (not just intercourse). You can avoid a lifetime of regret with one commitment of character.

Action Steps

Today we looked at an epidemic problem for teens who engage in sex before marriage. Romans 12:2 says not to conform or behave according to this world’s standards. God has a different set of standards for sex that will protect you from being another teen victim of a sexually transmitted disease. Consider which verse on purity most spoke to your heart and write it out here.

What is the Lord saying to you through this verse?

Memorize it, meditate on it, and renew your mind so that you won’t be tempted to go along with this world’s foolishness.

Daily Bible reading: Luke 24

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Worth the Wait

“At the beginning of creation God ‘made them male and female.’ ‘For this reason a man will leave his father and mother and be united to his wife, and the two will become one flesh.’ So they are no longer two, but one flesh.”

MARK 10:6–8

The sixth reason to wait until marriage to have sex is that it’s worth the wait.

God designed for us to experience sex only in the context of marriage. He knows that unconditional love within a lifelong commitment is the best way to get the most fulfillment and satisfaction out of this wonderful gift.

Remember, sex was God’s idea! He invented it. He must know how it will be the best. Ultimate devotion to one person through marriage is a picture of how God wants our relationship with him to be. God knows that to benefit fully from our relationship with him, we can’t have other gods clouding the picture. We must be wholly devoted to him. The marriage relationship of husband and wife is a picture of our undivided relationship with God. He wants us to have an awesome sex life, and he says the best way that can happen is when we’re faithful to only one person our whole life. That’s it. No regrets, no shame. Only pure sexual intimacy the way it was designed to be experienced: in marriage!

There’s an obvious truth that we hope you’ve picked up on. A high percentage of people—especially those who are famous and in the media spotlight—have already blown it. Their wealth and fame have convinced them that they are entitled to experience all things pleasurable whenever they want and with

whomever they want. It's natural to assume that they would then approve of you doing the same. Your immorality justifies their lifestyle. Most have no idea how great it would be if they married as a virgin. Have you ever wondered why anyone listens to what celebrities say about sex anyway? If they're experts on sex, why do so many split up and go from relationship to relationship, never seemingly satisfied? Only God has the final word on sex.

Action Steps

The world thinks it's an authority on the subject of sex, but actually, God is the only true authority because he invented it. Write out the difference between Hollywood's way and what Scripture says (God's way).

What are the potential dangers and consequences of sex outside marriage and of doing things the world's way?

What are the benefits of waiting for marriage and of doing things God's way?

Daily Bible reading: John 1

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Because God Said So

Do you not know that your bodies are temples of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, whom you have received from God?

1 CORINTHIANS 6:19

You have just read six common-sense reasons not to be sexually active before marriage. But just in case common sense does not make sense to you, here is the best reason:

The seventh reason to wait until marriage to have sex is because God says to.

As Paul wrote in today's verse, if you have given your life to Jesus, you have God living in you. You cannot take God's holy vessel (you) and put it in circumstances that consistently lead to sin. Just a verse before that, in 6:18, Paul said to "flee from sexual immorality," and 1 Peter 2:11 says "to abstain from sinful desires."

Romans 13:14 tells us to "clothe [ourselves] with the Lord Jesus Christ, and do not think about how to gratify the desires of the flesh." This means we should do all in our power not to give sin a chance to happen. While it's tempting and seemingly innocent, driving to a lonely place with your date only sets you up to fail. It sounds pretty simple, but if you and your date just stay around a lot of other friends or family and keep the lights on, you will stay pure.

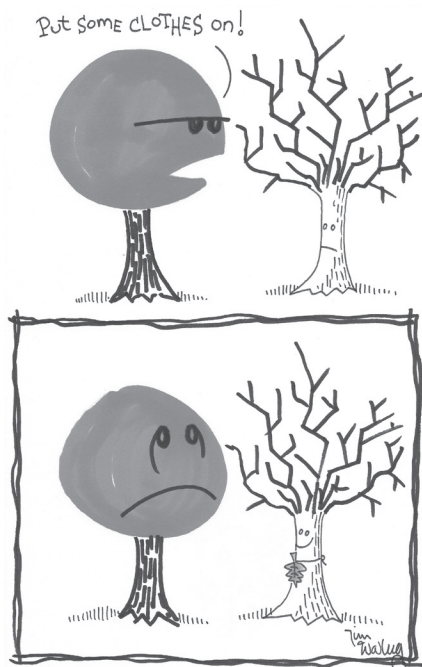
If none of these other reasons have convinced you, stay pure because God says to. Trust him. Even if you don't understand why, just obey. One day you will be walking down the aisle of a church to get married. When you stand there looking your bride or bridegroom in the eyes with no shame, you will be glad you did things God's way, and God will bless

your married sex life because you chose him over what the world says to do.

I remember just after I became a Christian, I went on a date with a girl who went to a religious school. I was so excited to find a girl whom I thought loved the Lord like I did. However, I soon found out that she had other things in mind. When I took her home, she began to try to kiss me very passionately in the car. I was afraid for my purity! I stopped her and pushed her away, but she kept making advances.

I thought, *This is just great. All my life as a heathen I wanted this, and it never happened! Now that I'm saved, it happens!* So I stopped her again.

Finally, she opened up the car door and got out. She slammed the door and stomped to her front porch. Believe it or not, I drove away excited! *I had said no! I had said no!* It felt so good to say no. You can say no too.



What if you have already lost your virginity? You might be thinking, *All this sounds great, but what if I've already messed up?* There is good news for you. Jesus will always forgive. His love will wash away your past as if it had never happened. He will forget it, and he will help you to forget it too. You must ask him to forgive you, and then you must repent. Put your foot down and say, "No more!"

Some people think, *Well, since I have already blown it, it doesn't matter if I keep messing up.* Wrong! The more you keep sinning, the more it will mess up your head, your heart, and your future marriage. It is time to stop now. It is time to start over again. It is time to begin your second virginity. Now that you know about living pure, you can stay pure from this time forward. You need to put some time between the present and the last time you messed up. The longer you stay clean, the purer and holier you will feel.

The most important thing about being pure is your heart. God wants you to have what I call "the spirit of a virgin." Some people have never blown it physically, but they think about it all the time. They look at pornography or lust after other people. Their body might be pure, but their heart is not. Those who get married with an impure heart are miserable. They do not have the spirit of a virgin.

On the other hand, there are others who have wrecked it big-time. But they've repented, gotten their heart right, and kept their life pure from that point on. They've walked down the aisle without any shame because they knew they had repented, were forgiven, and were washed clean by the blood of Jesus. They had the spirit of a virgin, and now these people have great marriages.

Action Steps

If you've been involved in sexual immorality, either physically or just in your heart and thoughts, and you've not yet asked God to forgive you, confess right now to the Lord all you've done.

First John 1:9 says, "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness." God promises that when we're honest with him about our sin, he'll not only forgive us, but he'll cleanse us too. When we're made clean by his blood and renew our minds with his Word, we'll have the power to repent of our sin.

Pray about it and then sign the following sexual purity commitment: *Because my body is the temple of the Holy Spirit, I commit to staying free from all sexual activity until the day I get married. I commit to keeping my mind pure by not allowing my eyes to look at any person in an impure way or at any images that tempt me sexually. Thank you, Jesus, for the power to stay pure and holy every day.*

Sign your name

Date

Daily Bible reading: John 2

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Describe the dating system of the culture. What do you see happening to the hearts and spiritual lives of your friends (or yourselves) who date the world's way? What does the Bible say about how to treat the opposite sex? What are the benefits of staying pure until marriage? How can you stay pure in the face of all the peer pressure to do the opposite? What are some practical ways to keep your purity until marriage? Spend some time praying for each other's resolve to keep your purity.

Week 11

Family Survival

Day 1

What's Your Family Like?

Fathers, do not exasperate your children; instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord.

EPHESIANS 6:4

If you come from a stable, loving, two-parents-who-love-each-other-and-love-God family, you're absolutely in the minority. The divorce rate for Christian marriages is almost as high as the divorce rate of non-Christian families if those Christians do not build their relationships with Christ at the center.³ While no two families look the same, this lesson will share two types of situations young Christians may experience and will encourage you to remain firm in your faith no matter your family dynamics.

Jackie wanted to serve God with all her heart after she became a Christian in high school. The church group she was invited to had leaders who walked their talk, especially in their homes. She was amazed at the love and commitment and the lack of tension she saw when they invited her over. Not only did she want that for herself, but she also wanted God to use her to reach others who were just like her: lost in the world with only one hope of finding their way out.

There was only one minor problem. She didn't have a car, and her parents wouldn't take her to church. Sometimes this wasn't a problem. People from church would pick her up. But since she lived fifteen miles away, it wasn't always convenient to get a lift, especially if she wanted to go to services on Wednesday night or Sunday night.

Did Jackie's parents congratulate or encourage her in her new faith? Not a bit. In fact, her dad would constantly put Christians down. He laughed at her new beliefs and never once

showed interest in her relationship with God. Her mom was a bit softer, but she had abandoned God years before she married her husband. Her guilt kept her from offering Jackie much encouragement beyond asking, “How was church today?”

Randy’s parents were Christians but only attended church on Sundays. Church was a habit, as was praying before meals, but they rarely shared meaningful conversations about the Bible, Jesus, or how to live the Christian faith. Randy knew from his own experiences at camp and at church that God was much more real and dynamic than his parents were portraying, but he couldn’t put church and mediocrity together. It didn’t compute. He asked me, “If God is really real, why doesn’t everyone who’s been going to church for twenty years have more excitement about the Lord?”

There are pockets of revival breaking out all over the world among today’s youth. It’s one of the most exciting God things I’ve seen in the last few years. Yet when many young people tell me how they want to live only for God, they also say that their moms and dads are neither saved nor do they live what they preach. Disillusionment about the Christian life based on what teens are seeing and hearing at home has the power to quench the fires of revival and turn down the volume of God that teens like you are trying to turn up.

And what if both Mom and Dad are Christians yet they are pursuing a divorce? Some young people have told me of intense circumstances in their homes involving a dysfunctional parent or a new stepparent. “How do I deal with my mom, who is an alcoholic?” they ask. Or “What should I do about my dad, who is my elder but who sexually abuses me?”

These next few days are designed to help you gain godly perspective and genuine help for some of the most intense predicaments that can occur in the family. No matter what your circumstances, please do not judge the goodness of God based only on any negativity you see from your parents. He is bigger than that.

Adults are human like everyone else. Sometimes they've learned to confess their sins and push ahead to become more like Christ; other times they're just better at hiding their sins. Whatever situation you are facing right now, I am confident that God will help you as he helped me get through some rough years with my folks.

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to talk to God about your family situation. If it's been particularly rough lately, pour out your heart to him.

Psalm 62:8 says, "Trust in him at all times, you people; pour out your hearts to him, for God is our refuge." A refuge is a place to hide for shelter and protection. No matter how intense things may be with your family, God will be a place for you to always go and pour out your heart. He is a safe place.

If your family knows the Lord and you are close, thank him for that blessing. Either way, he already knows every detail of your life, but he wants you to be honest with him and tell him how you feel in the deepest parts of your heart. Hard times or good times, you can trust him, for he is your shelter and protection.

Daily Bible reading: John 3

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

Honor Equals Freedom

“Honor your father and mother”—which is the first commandment with a promise—“so that it may go well with you and that you may enjoy long life on the earth.”

EPHESIANS 6:2–3

Are you the type of youth who is constantly wishing for more freedom at home? Sure you are. The desire for more freedom is a good thing. But you’ve probably noticed that sometimes this desire turns into rebellion when you don’t think you’re getting your freedom quickly enough. When your parents see rebellion in you, they do the exact opposite of what you want them to do: they clamp down.

Do you want your parents to let you do what you want? I’m going to give you a key that will unlock the freedom door of your life. You must honor them. To honor someone is to highly respect them.

Why honor them?

It’s been God’s plan from the beginning.

Ephesians 6:2 tells children to honor their father and mother. This command originally came from the Ten Commandments, which God gave to Moses for the children of Israel. God established the parents, not the kids, to be in charge of the family.

You may not like hearing this, but in most homes—even Christian homes—disharmony and problems can usually be traced back to the fact that the kids are running the house. They boss their parents around or try to manipulate them, and to avoid conflict, the parents cave in. When this happens, it

reverses the order of how things should be run. The results are confusion and tension.

Let's say, for example, that Susie asks her mom if she can go to the football game on Friday night. Mom says, "No, you got an F on your history test this week. You need to stay home and study."

So Susie goes and asks Dad, and he says, "You are my little girl. Of course you can go."

Mom walks by Susie's room on Friday night as Susie is getting ready to go to the game and says, "I thought I told you that you couldn't go." Susie responds, "Dad said I could." Mom goes to talk to Dad about it, and a fight explodes as Susie is walking out the door.

What are other ways you and your friends try to manipulate Mom and Dad? Whining, crying, threatening, being openly rebellious, isolating yourself from them, and rolling your eyes are just a few common tactics of teens. Of course, teenagers don't create all the tension in a home. But many blowups can probably be avoided if teens treat their parents with honor and respect.

Romans 13:1–2 says, "Let everyone be subject to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which God has established. The authorities that exist have been established by God. Consequently, whoever rebels against the authority is rebelling against what God has instituted, and those who do so will bring judgment on themselves." God has established the authorities that exist, including your parents. If you've ever wondered why things don't seem to be going right in your life, check to see if you are bringing judgment on yourself by not honoring them.

God gives your parents the responsibility to raise you to

- be responsible,
- be smart,
- know how to think,
- be sober minded,

- be obedient to God,
- make wise decisions,
- be able to govern and lead others, and
- have a broad perspective on life.

Wise parents will respond to the mandate: to raise you ready to govern and lead skillfully when you are of age. God gave them this responsibility. That is why it is so important to honor them.

Action Steps

Take a few minutes to write Romans 13:1–2 in your own words.

God gave you your parents to protect you, teach you wisdom, and help you grow up. They love you and want the best for you.

Ask yourself, *Have I been honoring my parents' authority in my life? In the way I treat them? In how I talk to them? Do I really listen to them? Do I obey them?* How have you honestly been doing regarding these things?

If you have not been obeying and honoring your parents, ask the Lord right now to forgive you and cleanse your heart of any negative feelings toward them. Ask him to give you a heart of love and gratefulness for your parents.

Daily Bible reading: John 4

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Advantages of Honoring Your Parents

“Honor your father and mother”—which is the first commandment with a promise—“so that it may go well with you and that you may enjoy long life on the earth.”

EPHESIANS 6:2–3

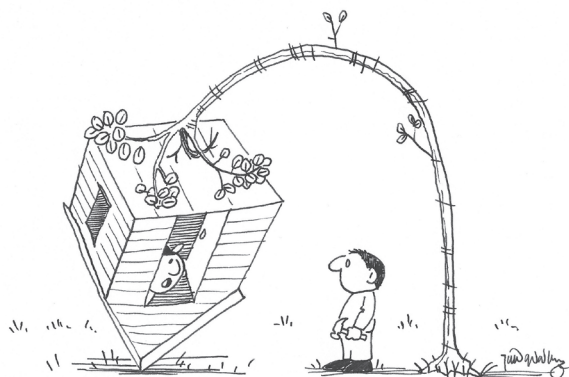
Take a few minutes to write out and memorize these verses.

By now you may be asking, *What are the advantages of honoring my parents?* There are plenty! God promises that if you honor your parents, he will blow you away by blessing your life for a long, long time. The blessing and favor of the Lord are on your side when you honor your parents. You can be sure you are on the right track to fulfilling all your potential if you submit to the authority that God gave your parents.

How do you do that? Honor your parents by listening to them. Proverbs 1:8–9 says, “Listen, my son, to your father’s instruction and do not forsake your mother’s teaching. They are a garland to grace your head and a chain to adorn your neck.”

Do you really want to be smart? Then listen to Mom and Dad. I know it’s a novel concept, but just try it. It’s amazing how many mistakes it will keep you from making. Don’t just do it because you’re supposed to; do it to really find out why their

instincts and knowledge are telling you to go in this direction when yours are telling you to go in the other direction.



"We should've picked a bigger tree."

11/01/03

With a humble attitude, respectfully ask them questions so you can get their perspective and understand their reasoning. Get their views on why they have particular rules for you or why they don't want you to do something. Communicate to your parents that when you are trying to find out the reasons for their rules, you're simply trying to understand their perspective and learn wisdom. It will help them think through their rules (and maybe loosen up on some rules that you have outgrown, though this shouldn't be your motive).

Remember to have a teachable heart and true humility in your tone and attitude as you question them, and you will communicate honor. As you learn from your parents by really listening to them, the things you think you should be doing to have more freedom just might change because you've become smarter.

Action Steps

When you are still living under your parent's roof, eating their food, and taking advantage of their care and protection, God expects you to obey and listen to them. They are your authorities, and they are responsible to God for you.

Write down all the ways God blesses you through your parents.

God will very often speak to you and lead you through Mom and Dad. Maybe they say you can't go to a certain party. God may be protecting you from a lot of heartache or even danger. Trust him with your parents' decisions for you. If you have not been listening to them, ask the Lord and them for forgiveness. Turn over a new leaf and begin listening to not only the words they speak to you but also the heart behind their words. You'll probably start noticing just how much they really do care about you.

Daily Bible reading: John 5

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

How Do You Speak to Your Parents?

Do not let any unwholesome talk come out of your mouths, but only what is helpful for building others up according to their needs, that it may benefit those who listen.

EPHESIANS 4:29

Take a few minutes to write out and memorize this verse.

Another way to honor your parents is in the way you speak to them. So many young people bring shame on themselves by the way they talk to or about their parents. The helpful talk that Ephesians 4:29 encourages is hardly the case between teens and parents. If you're murmuring under your breath after they tell you to do something or you have volcanic anger when they exasperate you, it's about time to think before speaking.

Once when I was sixteen, my dad and I got into an argument about my car. I wanted to take it, and he said no. He had my keys in his pocket. I said, "Give me those keys, or I will tackle you and do whatever I have to do to get them." I was a little bigger than my dad at the time, so he gave me the keys. And even though I have since apologized, I still regretted those words and that confrontation for a lot of years. Instead of

respecting the authority God had put in my life—my dad—I humiliated him.



“My dad said he’d buy me a car when I turned sixteen.”

12/27/03

Did you know that parents have feelings too? Many parents have been deeply hurt by the things their kids have said to them. Even if, in your opinion, your parents aren’t doing the best job in the world, they brought you into this world, and they are more than likely doing their best to raise you right. (We should also mention here that some parents weren’t raised right themselves and don’t have a clue how to raise their children. But they are the exception, not the rule.)

An overwhelming majority of teens say they occasionally or consistently lie to their parents. Is this honoring them? Honor your parents by always speaking the truth. While the short-term consequences may not be fun (especially if you’ve messed up), the long-term fruit of your parents being able to trust you and what you say to them will give you more freedom than one hundred lies could ever do. Freedom comes through trust, and trust through honesty. Honesty is easier when you have the attitude of honor at the forefront of your mind.

Action Steps

How have you been speaking to your parents?

The verse you memorized today from Ephesians 4:29 says not to let any unwholesome talk come out of your mouth. Have your words to your parents been wholesome? Have they built your parents up or torn them down? Have your words benefitted your mom and dad? Think of some ways you can make amends to your parents if you have spoken unwholesome words to them.

If you're not sure if your words have been a blessing to your parents, just ask them; they'll tell you. And if you know that your words have hurt or dishonored your parents or that you've been lying to them, confess it to them today. Ask them to forgive you and choose today to allow only wholesome and uplifting words toward your parents to come out of your mouth. This takes prayer, attitude adjustment, and practice, but God will help you transform in this area.

Daily Bible reading: John 6

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

Honor Equals Obedience

Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right.

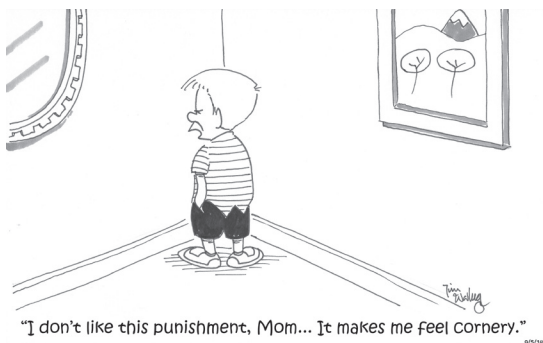
EPHESIANS 6:1

Take a few minutes to memorize this verse.

We know obedience sounds more like torture than a vacation. But this is God's way of doing things because he knows it's the best way.

Colossians 3:22 says, "Slaves, obey your earthly masters in everything; and do it, not only when their eye is on you and to curry their favor, but with sincerity of heart and reverence for the Lord." We know you're not a slave, but this is a great principle to learn when it comes to obeying your parents. Do you want to give your parents a shock? Then bend over backward to obey them. Obey not just their commands but their desires as well. Obey not just when they're watching but even when they're not around. Don't try to just slide past them with minimal obedience or try to get away with all that you can. Parents know way more than you think they do. They've been living with you for thirteen or more years, so they can read you like a book.

Find out what they really want and then do it. Go for the spirit of the law and not just the letter of the law. You will absolutely blow them away if you do what they want. Obey your parents even when you don't agree with them and especially when you don't want to. That's your chance to prove to them that you are submitting to their God-given authority, and this pleases the Lord.



The more willingly you submit and obey from your heart, the more you will earn your parent's trust. God will ultimately bless you with more freedom because you have become trustworthy.

Action Steps

When you gave your heart and life to the Lord, you were essentially giving him the "reins" of your life so he could lead you and take you where he wanted you to go. If he says in Scripture, "Children, obey and honor your parents," then when you obey them, you are obeying God. Today remember the commitment you made to the Lord to follow him and his ways and make a fresh commitment to obey him by obeying your parents. Write out and pray a prayer of commitment.

Daily Bible reading: John 7

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

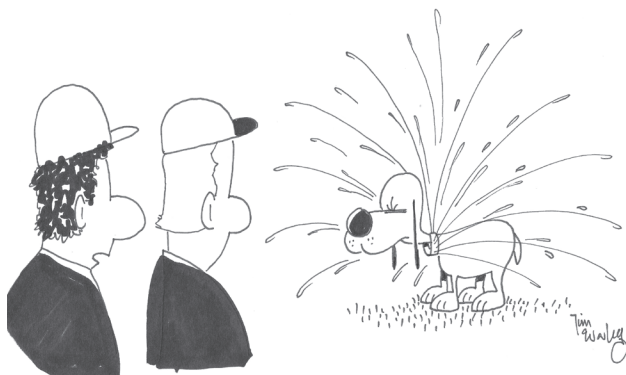
Honoring When It's Hard

Children, obey your parents in everything,
for this pleases the Lord.

COLOSSIANS 3:20

You may be in a situation in which it is extremely difficult to honor your mom and dad. Honoring can be different from obeying. As an example, let's consider a time when you have to take out the garbage.

When you take out the garbage because Mom told you to, it does not mean you honored her. If you did it with a bad attitude, there was no honor. Some young people think that if their parents are really mean to them, they do not have to honor them. The truth is that honoring your parents has nothing to do with the way they treat you.



"The underground sprinkling and invisible fence crossed circuits."

5/28/18

You honor your parents because of their position, not because of what they do, good or bad. We honor the president

or leader of our nation because of their position. We might not like their policies, their philosophy, or the way they do their hair. But the president is the leader of the country, and we honor them because of that.

The same principle is true regarding your parents. You may not like their rules, their philosophies, or the clothes they wear, but they are your parents. God gave them that position. Of all the people in the world, he chose those two to bring you into the world. You wouldn't be here if it weren't for them. No one can take that position away from them. No matter what bad or good things they do, God made them your parents. Consequently, he wants you to honor them.

So what is the difference between honoring and obeying? If your parents asked you to do something illegal or immoral, it would not bring them honor for you to follow through on what they asked. If people found out, they would think, *What terrible parents you must have to raise you like this.* God gave you a conscience for a reason. He wants you to follow what you know is right. If I would have "obeyed" my parents' wish about my college choice, I never would have moved away and gone to a quality Christian college to prepare myself for my life's calling. Of course, now people look at me and say, "What great parents you had!" The truth is that neither one of them was a Christian at the time, and both would have preferred that I had stayed near home and gone to a secular school. If I had obeyed their preference, I would not have brought them honor like I do now.

"Does this mean that whenever I want, I can selectively obey my parents?" Not at all. "Does it mean that if my parents are not Christians, I don't have to obey them?" No way! Most of the disagreements that teens have with their parents have nothing to do with whether something is scriptural or not. They have to do with whether the teen would prefer to do a chore or not.



The general rule to follow is to obey your parents no matter what. If you think you have a biblical reason not to obey (such as if what they are asking is blatantly against the Bible, like, for example, getting them drugs or lying for them), then you need to talk to your pastor or church leader before you make any drastic moves. They may be able to help you talk to your parents. Find out why your parents want you to do what they are asking. See how you can obey the spirit of their rules if not the letter. The point is that you want to have other people backing you up so that you are not all alone if they are, indeed, asking you to do something that is unscriptural.

Action Steps

There have been many a young person who had parents who were unbelievers, and God used those kids in a powerful way to reach their parents by the way they treated their parents with honor. A humble heart goes a long way with most parents, Christian or not. Think of some ways you can honor your parents and list them here.

If you have shown your parents honor but still are truly facing a difficult situation at home, ask the Lord to help you and talk to your church leader or pastor about it. Pray for healing for your family and for God to use your faith to touch the hearts of your parents.

Daily Bible reading: John 8

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 7

Honor Equals Showing Responsibility

“You have been faithful with a few things;
I will put you in charge of many things.”

MATTHEW 25:21

Many teens want the opportunity to make their own decisions but have not really shown they are responsible enough to do so. Jesus told the parable of the talents in Matthew 25:14–30. In verse 21, the master commended his servants, saying that because they had been faithful with a few things, he would put them in charge of many things. In other words, if you want to have more responsibility, you must show that you are awesome at handling the little you have now.

How do you spend your free time? How about your money? If you have your driver's license, how fast do you drive? Have you had any traffic tickets or accidents? These are all obnoxious neon signs that communicate to your mom and dad exactly how responsible you really are or aren't. If you don't prove faithful in the small things, you will probably not get more freedom anytime soon.

Do you want to give your dad a head-scratching fit? Don't always try to take a free ride. Try to pay for your own stuff once in a while instead of asking him for money all the time.

Do you want to make your mom pass out? When you are in the wrong, admit it. Confess your mistakes and ask her to forgive you. When you do this, you are taking responsibility for your actions. And remember what responsibility leads to? That's right: freedom.

I have a friend from high school who told me that he had no rules for his teenage daughter. I couldn't believe it! He said that she had been so responsible, coming home earlier than their curfew, always getting her homework done, and doing all her chores. She went overboard to obey and honor him and his wife with her attitude, so they trusted her completely. They never had to lay down rules for her because she already had her own convictions that affected her decision-making as she followed the Lord.

It's good to desire more freedom through responsibility, but don't let your desire for it turn into rebellion. If you start thinking, *I'm old enough; I'm going to do it anyway*, you immediately get out of God's blessing. When that happens, get ready for your life to get really messed up. As you prove your responsibility and honor your parents, God will open doors in your life that you will not believe! Nearly every good thing that happens to you will be because you've honored God or honored others. Being someone who has learned the secret of honoring will help you go far in life in anything you endeavor.

Action Steps

We've been talking all week about honoring and obeying your parents. Stop right now and take some time to ask God to show you any specific situations where you have dishonored or disrespected your parents. Write them down.

Ask the Lord to forgive you for each situation and cleanse your heart of any rebellion or wrong attitudes toward your

parents. Make a fresh commitment to God to honor your parents with all your heart. Write out your commitment here.

You may even want to go and talk to your parents about it if you haven't already. Ask them to forgive you. It does not matter if they have made a mistake; do not expect them to ask you to forgive them. You do it first. You are responsible to God for your own life, not theirs. You will be amazed at what will happen in your relationship with your parents when you honor them. As the Bible says, "Honor your father and your mother, so that you may live long in the land the LORD your God is giving you" (Exodus 20:12).

Daily Bible reading: John 9

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

This week's lessons talked a lot about gaining your parent's trust through honoring them. Share some experiences you had with your parents this week—any attempts you made to honor and obey your parents even when it was hard or any situations where you failed to honor them. What are the benefits and blessings of honoring your parents? Take some time right now and pray for one another's relationships with their parents.

Week 12

Forgiveness and Family

Day 1

God Cares

“I hate divorce,” says the LORD God of Israel. “I hate it when one of you does such a cruel thing to his wife. Make sure that you do not break your promise to be faithful to your wife.”

MALACHI 2:16 GNT

Divorce happens so often that it's easy to conclude that it's a normal part of life. When I was a kid, it was very abnormal, even embarrassing, if your parents were divorced. Now it's no big deal, the norm. Some kids have only a mom, others only a dad. Some have a stepparent, and others live with people who are not their parents at all, such as other relatives or foster parents.

This week we will be addressing several types of complex family situations that you may be facing, specifically looking at the impact of divorce. Your parents might not be divorced, but you still may have tension in your home. Whatever the case may be, God sees you and wants to heal your heart and help you through these difficult family dynamics.

When a divorce does happen, I've seen a lot of young people act like it doesn't bother them. “It's a fact of life, so why should it upset me? And even if it did bother me, what could I do about it? So what? My parents got a divorce. Who cares if I feel hurt and cheated during the whole thing?” A lot of kids harden their hearts so that they won't feel the pain, but as you will discover this week, the pain is still there whether we try to ignore it or not. And God is an expert at dealing with pain.

The Bible is clear when it says that God hates divorce. It is because divorce was never a part of his original plan for marriages, and he knows how much it hurts children when a

father and mother split. God never intended for marriages to end like this. Jesus said, “What God has joined together, let no one separate” (Matthew 19:6). So if your family has gone through a divorce and your heart and head are confused about it, don’t feel like you are the only one who has a problem with it or that you are all alone.

If you don’t live with your two biological parents, how should you live day by day given your parents’ situation? If your mom and dad are still single or if one of them is seeing someone, what should you do? What if one of your parents gets remarried? How should you deal with your stepparent? These are complex questions, and we must look to the Bible to find God’s way of handling them.

If your father or mother is absent, your heavenly Father sees and will be a father or mother to you. Psalm 68:5 says, “A father to the fatherless, a defender of widows, is God in his holy dwelling.”

Trust the Lord that he is with you and will take care of you in every way that you need.

Action Steps

If you come from a divorced family or if there’s tension in your family, bring it to the Lord and pray for peace and unity. If you don’t come from a divorced home, pray for a friend who does. This week will give you tools to encourage your friends who are facing difficult family situations.

Pray for each member of your family by name and for them to come to know the Lord. Write your prayer here.

Daily Bible reading: John 10

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 2

The Single Parent Family

“In you the fatherless find compassion.”

HOSEA 14:3

When a family separates because of a divorce, the members of that family experience many of the same emotions that they would if someone in their family died. The sense of loss someone feels when their spouse leaves is similar to the way they would feel if they had just been widowed. The emptiness they feel after part of their life has been torn away and their heart ripped out is only worsened by the fact that it did not happen through an accident or physical disease; it was their partner's intentional decision. This also brings a sense of rejection.

The loss that young people feel when their parents divorce can be similar to what orphans feel at the loss of their parents. They are often bereaved or, in other words, deprived of the love and constant relationship with the person who has left the home. They can feel a lack of security. The permanence of a divorce, at least initially, is like the permanence of death. Divorce has made many teens feel like orphans in their own homes.

How does God respond to a family when one parent leaves? Hosea 14:3 says that “the fatherless find compassion.” He promises to be “the helper of the fatherless” (Psalm 10:14). He says he will be “a father to the fatherless, a defender of widows” (Psalm 68:5). If you have endured a divorce in your family, you have a very special place in the heart of God. He looks at you in the same way he looks at an orphan because you have gone through many of the same things. He promises to help you and to stick with you through all the empty days and lonely nights.

If your parents are divorced, don't take sides. You may have a tendency to favor the one you are living with more because you hear his or her side of the story all the time. Or maybe you favor the parent who gives you more freedom or things. Just realize that it takes two to have problems. Rarely does the blame fall entirely on one person. Neither of your parents is perfect, so don't idolize one over the other.

Whether your parents are divorced or not, if one of them tries to put the other down, you should politely ask that parent to stop. You shouldn't have to hear anything negative about either of your parents from anyone. And no matter what the ongoing problems may be, you should not allow yourself to be put in the middle. As difficult as it may be for them, it is wrong for your parents to ask or force you to choose sides or to put you in the middle of their fights.

You also do not have to play messenger or referee between your parents. A counselor needs to get in the middle, not you. This may take a lot of self-control because you will sometimes want to be a helper, especially if one parent is really struggling. After all, you have the blood of both parents in you. And while you should be proud of that, you shouldn't allow that fact to persuade you to take on roles that may cause you to grow to resent one parent or the other.

Action Steps

Whatever your family situation is, take a moment to meditate on the verses from this lesson (Hosea 14:3; Psalm 10:14; Psalm 68:5). Write them out here.

God is a perfect Father. He's a good Father. He cares. He will never leave you. Ask him to show you his tremendous, unfailing love.

Daily Bible reading: John 11

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 3

Stepfamily Harmony

Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but be willing to associate with people of low position. Do not be conceited. Do not repay anyone evil for evil. Be careful to do what is right in the eyes of everyone. If it is possible, as far as it depends on you, live at peace with everyone.

ROMANS 12:16–18

About 40 percent of families in the US are blended, with at least one partner having a child from a previous relationship before marriage.⁴ If you are one of the many children who live with a stepparent in your family, you are not alone; those families are all over the world. And you also know that not everything is going to be okay simply because there is a male and a female figure in the home. Some adults think that getting a new spouse will help to soothe the pain of divorce. Their motive may be right, but the new marriage does not usually always accomplish the results they wanted.

When I was young, I experienced many of the same relational tortures that many young people do today because my parents divorced when I was seven years old. Once, when I went to visit my dad, he held me up in the window of his home while my mother was driving off so she could see me kiss my stepmom! There are many times biological parents are still mad at each other when one or both remarry. They are so hurt that they may continue to think of ways to get even with the other person for the pain they caused. They may tell you things about the other parent to try to get you mad at him or her. They may even try to lure you away from the other parent by buying your

love and attention. This becomes a game to them, and you are the pawn.

It's a well-used ploy for one parent to talk badly about the other's new spouse just to keep you from liking him or her. The tragedy is that all this stuff just messes with your head even more. If you are in this situation, the Lord can help you learn to see through all these games. Discern what's going on. Then don't go along with their immaturity even though God still expects you to honor them.

Guilt and a Divided Heart

Say you finally accept the fact that the parent you live with is remarried. (Let's say it's your mom in this case, just to cut down on the confusion.) You decide you are going to try to get to know your new stepdad, and you find out that he is not too bad a person after all. In fact, you even like him. While visiting your real father, you accidentally end up saying more than you should about your new relationship with your stepdad. Suddenly, you notice some jealousy on your dad's face and in his tone of voice. Though you backpedal quickly by playing down how much you like your stepdad, you realize you've stepped over some invisible line. Inside you start feeling guilty for even liking your stepdad at all. This new relationship is what your mom has been begging for, even praying for. However, now that you really like the guy, you feel as if you are betraying your dad. It seems like whatever you do, you can't win.

Do you know that you have nothing to feel guilty about? If your biological parent is trying to make you feel bad about liking your new stepparent, it's their problem, not yours. Just because you like and perhaps want to honor your new stepparent does not mean you do not love your biological parent. All this potential mess is a good reminder that both your parents need to know that you love them no matter what kind of relationship you have with your stepparent. It is also a

reminder that your parents are human and need a lot of grace, so go easy on them.

It is easy to feel divided between your two families. You go to one house and do not feel completely at home, and you go to the other house and still do not feel like you are at home. So where is your real home anyway? It's a lonely feeling.

Stepparent Losing Out

Let's go back to your mom for a moment and imagine another scenario. After she remarries, imagine you are determined not to get along with your new stepfather. You make him jump through every hoop you can think of, but you've already decided that no matter what he does, he will lose. He is working hard to pay for your food, clothes, and housing. He is learning how to love not only your mom but also you and your brothers and sisters as well. He's trying to be all that you need in a father, but you don't care. You're more interested in punishing your mom for divorcing your dad than you are in allowing family harmony to return.

In the midst of a disagreement with your stepfather, you shout, "You're not my real dad anyway!" A statement like that cuts to the heart of someone doing all they can to be accepted. It's time to grow up. Life offers no promises except the ones Jesus made, like this one: "In this world you will have trouble. But take heart! I have overcome the world" (John 16:33). You have to start cutting your stepparent some slack, learn to make the best of a situation that no amount of the silent treatment will change, and above all, realize that your stepparent is a person too.

Living for God through difficult situations means asking the question, *How would Jesus treat them?* If your mom and dad are genuinely trying to do their best to pick up and go on with life, then you need to do the same by trying to see your stepparent through the eyes of God.

As a teen, I moved in with my dad and stepmother. I was fifteen, and she was twenty-six. I believed our ages were way too close for us to have a healthy relationship. We increasingly despised each other as the days turned into weeks and months. Finally, after I gave my life to Jesus, God began to draw our hearts together. I started to see her as an individual instead of a twenty-six-year-old who wanted to boss me around. Later she gave her heart to the Lord, and when I was nineteen, she asked me to baptize her. We became the best of friends, sharing what God was doing in our lives and praying together regularly. It was an incredible change!

One of the most incredible aspects of the church is that through it, God has given us a new family. One day, Jesus was talking to a crowd. Someone came to him and said, “‘Your mother and brothers are standing outside, wanting to speak to you.’ He replied to him, ‘Who is my mother, and who are my brothers?...Whoever does the will of my Father in heaven is my brother and sister and mother’” (Matthew 12:47–50).

You cannot go through life thinking you’ll never be whole because your family is not together anymore. Jesus had an entirely different definition of family anyway. He said it is those who really love his Father and do his will who are his family. It takes more than the same blood to make up a close family. It takes a unity of heart. I know of Christian stepfamilies who are much closer than many natural families who are still together but do not have the Lord. It is more important to be in God’s family together than in a traditional family where your hearts are all torn apart and you’re going separate ways.

Action Steps

Take some time right now to thank God for the family he has given you, warts and all. If you have been struggling to get along with a parent or stepparent, pray especially for them right now, asking the Lord to give you his heart for that parent. Write out your prayer.

If you have not been treating your parent or stepparent with respect and honor, go to them and ask forgiveness for the way you've been acting. Ask the Lord to forgive you and give you a heart to honor that parent and to be an example of how Jesus loves them. Who knows? The Lord could use you in a powerful way in their life.

Daily Bible reading: John 12–13

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 4

Forgiveness Starts with You

“If you forgive other people when they sin against you, your heavenly Father will also forgive you.”

MATTHEW 6:14

As you may know, many complex issues are causing a lot of hurt in families today. Too many arguments and too many harsh words have been exchanged that have put a wall between young people and their parents or stepparents. It would be foolish to pretend that these situations never happened. And bad feelings will not just go away...unless the hearts involved submit to the Lord.

To live for God, you must learn to forgive and forget—just as the Lord has done with your own sins and offenses toward him. In a situation that is likely out of your control, there is only one thing you can control: your own response to it all. You can't control anyone else, but you can control yourself. You hold the power to get your heart right first and then hope others involved will take your lead and do the same. But if they choose not to, at least your heart will be free. Life is way too short to let the wall of bitterness separate people who live under the same roof.

I've experienced firsthand the sad fact that family situations are a major source of real hurt. When the people we love most wind up hurting us through selfish or sinful choices, it stings the heart. Some of you reading these pages may have been stabbed in the back, talked about, cut down, beaten, or even sexually abused. But you are not without hope. You can be whole again, and you can restore lost relationships.

My firsthand experience tells me that God's awesome power can take away any pain, no matter how deep it may be.

The key to your recovery lies in the powerful choice called *forgiveness*. Instead of going through your teenage years hurting and resentful, it's important for you to make the decisions to deal with your pain before you go any further. No relationship, no amount of fun, no career choice, no drug, no pleasurable activity can take away the pain of your present or your past—only forgiveness can.

Action Steps

We know that some of you have gone through some pretty rough situations. The only way you can be free of the memories, the pain, and the hurt is to choose to forgive. Ask the Lord right now to soften your heart and help you begin the process of letting go and allowing God to bring healing and forgiveness to your heart. He is with you now and has never left you. “He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion” (Philippians 1:6). He is the Good Shepherd over your heart.

Daily Bible reading: John 14–15

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 5

My Personal Battle

“When you stand praying, if you hold anything against anyone, forgive them, so that your Father in heaven may forgive you your sins.”

MARK 11:25

My mom and I had a really tough time getting along as I grew up. I felt like she was constantly out to get me. It seemed like she always punished me worse than she punished my brothers and sisters. She would say things that made me feel so low I felt like flushing myself down the toilet. I grew up hating her. Though I somehow knew all this hate wasn't right, I didn't have any idea how to get rid of it.

After I gave my life to the Lord, he began to deal with me about my mom. I had to change the way I felt toward her because I had finally learned some lessons about love and compassion from my new faith. I don't remember how he sent the message, but God got through to my wounded heart and told me I had to forgive my mom. What you are about to read is exactly the process God took me through to forgive her.

I remember asking the Lord just a few months after I became a follower of Jesus, *Where were you when she was beating me? Where were you when I was getting bruised over and over again?*

Very gently he spoke to my heart, *I saw all those things, and I was right there, but I'm not in charge of all the bad things that happen in the world. You need to forgive your mom. And you need to ask her to forgive you, too, for any way you have disrespected or dishonored her.*

That shocked me! I asked the Lord for help, and I chose to forgive her. However, there were still times after that when my

memory would flash back to the hardest times, and I would find myself getting mad at her again. Ultimately, I found verses about forgiveness in the Bible and memorized them. Whenever I felt angry again as a memory flashed through my mind, I would pull out the verses and read them. Slowly, the Lord totally healed my heart. In fact, one day I was praying for my mom, and I said, *Lord, please reach my mom. She needs to know you, and I love her.* I shocked myself. I couldn't believe I had just said I loved her. I had never told her that unless she forced me to (and yes, many times she would force me to say I loved her). Now I could tell a miracle of forgiveness and love had happened inside me. God had put into my heart a genuine love for my mom.

I have told this story to literally millions of young people, and as a result, many have forgiven the person who hurt them. What the devil meant for harm God used for good. Also, my mom ultimately became an on-fire follower of Jesus! She went to heaven years ago, and I got to share this story at her funeral and sing a song I had written for her that speaks of how the Lord healed our relationship. It worked for me, and if you have any relationship that needs restoring, this process can work for you.

When a powerless person is abused by someone more powerful, the pain is often so deep that it's hard to believe it will ever go away. Holding on to unforgiveness and grasping it tightly won't affect the person who hurt you as much as it will affect you. It's like a cancer in your heart that will slowly infect your whole body. The key element in dealing with hurt is wondering what to do with all your hurtful memories. While the future could get better, the past is hard to let go of.

Did you know that God has the power to heal your memories? When you truly forgive, the cancer of the past not only goes into remission, but it will seem like it has been surgically cut from your emotions. You won't necessarily forget every bad thing that happened to you, but God takes away the sting and pain of those memories. It will no longer hurt to think of them.

Be ready to go to war if you really want to get rid of your pain. The way you fight this war is with God's Word. If you've dealt with abuse for months or years, the deep hurt doesn't disappear overnight with a quick little prayer. The devil has been busy cramming hurt, guilt, and condemnation down your throat for years. Now it's time to cram some truth concerning forgiveness into your heart. Study verses like the following:

- "If you forgive other people when they sin against you, your heavenly Father will also forgive you" (Matthew 6:14).
- "When you stand praying, if you hold anything against anyone, forgive them, so that your Father in heaven may forgive you your sins" (Mark 11:25).
- "Forgive, and you will be forgiven" (Luke 6:37).
- "I can do all this through him who gives me strength" (Philippians 4:13).

Action Steps

Write down these verses about forgiveness on index cards and take them with you everywhere. You can also make them the wallpaper on your phone. Meditate on them until you are saying them in your sleep. This is the first step toward your wholeness.

Daily Bible reading: John 16–17

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Day 6

Decide to Forgive

“In your anger do not sin”: Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.

EPHESIANS 4:26–27

Forgiveness is not a feeling. You will never wake up one day and think, *Boy, I feel like forgiving today!* Our natural human tendency is to hold a grudge and never to forgive.

A good definition of *forgiveness* is “giving up your right to hurt someone back when they have hurt you first.” You probably deserve to be very angry at the one who hurt you. No one would argue with that. The whole idea is to give up your right to strike back.

You cannot wait for God to personally tell you to forgive. He has already told you that you need to forgive (Matthew 6:14–15). Your mandate to forgive does not depend on the other person’s repentant heart either. You must forgive even if the person who hurt you never admits they did anything wrong. Your own freedom in your soul depends on it.

Usually, when someone gets hurt, they get mad. It is hard to distinguish between these two emotions because both are felt at the same time. The Bible says in Ephesians 4:26–27, “In your anger do not sin: Do not let the sun go down while you are still angry, and do not give the devil a foothold.” Sure, things are going to make you mad, but you have to know how to handle your anger when it comes. Many people have grown old and bitter at the world because they were hurt at one time in their life, and they let anger and bitterness overtake them.

God says not to even let one day go by while you are still mad. If you do, you give the devil a foothold in your life. You

can follow the Lord, go to church, and read your Bible every day. But if you get mad and stay mad, you invite the devil to put a stronghold—a fortress of pain—on part of your life. It is like you are asking him to camp out right in your living room. The Bible tells us how to deal with anger. Ephesians 4:31–32 says, “Get rid of all bitterness, rage and anger, brawling and slander, along with every form of malice. Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other, just as in Christ God forgave you.” **You get rid of anger by forgiving.** It is the only way. No matter what you have been through, God has given you the power to forgive.

And it doesn’t even matter if you will never see that person again. A friend I know had a stepfather who used to beat up my friend’s mom. After they divorced, my friend never saw that stepfather again. When my friend gave his life to Christ, he still had leftover hate and bitterness toward that man. Though he never got to look the man in the eye and tell him he was forgiven, my friend forgave his stepfather from his heart. He forgave him without seeing him, and it set his own heart free.

Even if the person who hurt you isn’t living anymore, you still need to forgive them. It’s for your heart’s health, not for them. And forgiveness clears the way to the Father and draws you close to him. True forgiveness that sets your heart free is between you and God. Once you make the decision to forgive, the heaviness will lift from your life. A miracle happens in your heart!

Remember Stephen, the first disciple killed for his faith? As he was being stoned, he said, “Lord, do not hold this sin against them” (Acts 7:60). Wow! Right in the middle of the stoning, Stephen decided to forgive the very people who were killing him. With Jesus’ power, you can decide to let go of your anger right among the people persecuting you.

Action Steps

If you have been thinking about a particular person the whole time you've been reading today's lesson, that's the Holy Spirit bringing someone or several people to your attention. Take time right now to pray over that person.

In the space provided, write down their offenses—everything you can think of that the person did that hurt you.

Now bring each offense to the Lord and decide to let go of the offense and forgive that person for what they did or said to you. You're choosing to forgive that person; now ask God to forgive them. Take a red marker and cross off each offense as a representation of the blood of Jesus covering them and the forgiveness that Jesus shed for that person.

Lord Jesus, I'm asking for your power to forgive. Help me, Lord. I choose forgiveness instead of anger and bitterness. Soften my heart and fill me with the Holy Spirit and your forgiveness, compassion, and love. Heal my heart and make me new again.

Daily Bible reading: John 18–19

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

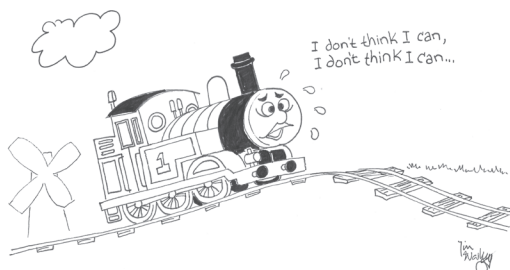
Day 7

Fight the Battle in Your Mind

Whoever claims to love God yet hates a brother or sister is a liar. For whoever does not love their brother and sister, whom they have seen, cannot love God, whom they have not seen. And he has given us this command: Anyone who loves God must also love their brother and sister.

1 JOHN 4:20-21

Even after you have made the decision and prayed a genuine prayer to unlock forgiveness, the battle isn't quite over. You will not necessarily feel an overwhelming love right away for the person you forgave. Forgiveness is not a feeling; it's a decision. You may think, *I don't feel any differently about the person or about my pain, so I guess I didn't really forgive him.* Wrong! If you made the decision, then you have forgiven.



Doubting Thomas

4/25/79

Remember when you said yes to receiving the gift of forgiveness that Jesus offered? Though the fact of your choice was certain, there have likely been times when you didn't feel forgiven. Those doubting thoughts came from the Father of Lies, the devil. In the same way, the devil will try to trick you into

feeling condemned and confused about your decision to forgive those who hurt you. It is important to remember the date and time when you decided to forgive those people so you can remind the devil—and remind yourself—what you chose to do.

Even after you've made this important choice, you will have a natural tendency to take up the offense again and get mad. All this does is make you lose the ground you and the Lord have fought to take. Every time unforgiveness creeps back in, pull out your index cards with verses about forgiveness and start saying them aloud. You see, the battle is in your mind. If you turn to God's Word every single time you are tempted to get angry again, there is no question you will win. Though you ought to find others to encourage you, you must be prepared to fight the battle with the sword of God's Word. Use it the moment hurtful thoughts enter your brain with their vain attempts to filter bitterness down to your will.

As you continue to wage this war and succeed at kicking out words of death with words of life, you will take more and more ground and feel less and less pain. And believe it or not, you'll find a growing love in your heart for the person who hurt you. You will discover that the clouds are gone, and you really are set free.

One last note: If you have been the victim of physical or sexual abuse, you should confide in your pastor or a qualified Christian counselor. It is imperative that you have someone to help you work through these forgiveness issues, especially before you get married. You will avoid many years of grief and marital struggles if you take the time to do this now.

It may take weeks or months before you feel any different about the person who hurt you. Don't be discouraged. God's Word has the power to heal your broken heart. It never fails! You just have to be committed to fighting your thoughts with his Word, no matter how long it takes, because you know that having a free heart for the rest of your life is worth it.

Remember 2 Corinthians 5:7: “We walk by faith, not by sight” (NKJV) or by feelings. As you persist in your decision to forgive and as you program God’s Word into your memory bank, you will find the most incredible miracle happening in your heart. You will sense a freedom like you have never known before. The dark cloud of the unforgiveness cancer that surrounded you will leave. God will perform heart surgery that no world-class surgeon could ever perform. He alone has the awesome power to heal a broken heart. Healing begins with forgiveness.

Action Steps

Continue the forgiveness process you started. Reaffirm your commitment by writing out the decisions you’ve made to forgive those who have hurt you. Include the date and time.

Pull out your index cards with verses about forgiveness and renew your mind in God’s Word by meditating on them. No matter how you feel, know that the Lord has started a good work in you that he will complete.

Describe what the Lord has done in your heart this week concerning your family and forgiveness.

Daily Bible reading: John 20–21

What did you learn today in your reading about how to live?

Connect Group Discussion

Take some time to share more about your family this week and pray for each one in the group, using Scripture to comfort and encourage one another toward forgiveness.

Conclusion

Congratulations! You have finished the first trimester of the Pathway to Freedom series. Don't forget all the ways God has spoken in your heart over the last twelve weeks and keep pursuing him every day of your life. Your journey with God doesn't stop here.

To help you build a solid foundation for your life, now you can get your copy of *Pathway to Freedom (Trimester Two): Building Your Whole Life on a Solid Foundation* and gather with your connect group. Together you will learn to emulate biblical world changers, mature your faith with Scripture, thank God for his gift of salvation, conquer doubts with belief, and surrender your whole life to God.

Remember that our goal is to become lifelong followers of Jesus and make disciples of others. As you progress through the next trimesters, you will find yourself becoming more like Jesus because you are following him more closely, and you will be more equipped to bring others along with you on the journey.

Let the adventure begin!

What Is Baptism?

The word *baptismo* (Greek) literally means “to be immersed in water.” Since the beginning of Christianity, this has been a common practice and a clear marker for people who decide to follow Christ. Baptism is a place where all are equal—rich or poor, popular or not. If you are a follower of Christ, being immersed in water in front of a group of people who can cheer you on is a public declaration that you are seeking to follow Jesus’ teaching and walk with him.

Often baptism is referred to as the water grave, symbolizing that the old you is being buried under the water and staying there and that a new person who has been given true life is rising up out of the water. This is a very public rite of passage, like someone getting a tattoo or wearing certain clothes when they join a gang. Baptism shows the world that you have unashamedly decided in your heart to follow Jesus and that he has set you free.

Baptism indicates to the whole world whose side you are on. Luke 3:3 says, “John went from place to place on both sides of the Jordan River, preaching that people should be baptized to show that they had repented of their sins and turned to God to be forgiven” (TLB). Here you can see that John was baptizing people to show they had decided to change the way they were living. It was a public declaration that from that point forward, they intended to follow the teachings of John.

The very early church fathers recorded how when people were baptized, they would go into the water and first look to the west (the direction the sun sets, where darkness lives). They would shout something like, “I renounce the devil and all of his ways!” and often spit three times in that direction to indicate that they wanted nothing to do with the devil.⁵ Then they would turn to the east (the direction the sun rises and light emerges) and proclaim their commitment to God: “I surrender myself to you, O triune God, Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, in

belief, obedience, and the earnest resolution to remain faithful to you until my end.”

Through baptism, you are letting others know—family and friends and new friends—that you have finally found where you belong.

Why Get Baptized?

Since the beginning of the church, Christians have been baptized to follow Jesus’ example.

Jesus left Galilee to come to the Jordan to be baptized by John. But when he waded into the water, John resisted him, saying, “Why are you doing this? I’m the one who needs to be baptized by you, and yet you come to be baptized by me?”

Jesus replied, “It is only right to do all that God requires.” Then John baptized Jesus. And as Jesus rose up out of the water, the heavenly realm opened up over him and he saw the Holy Spirit descend out of the heavens and rest upon him in the form of a dove. Then suddenly the voice of the Father shouted from the sky, saying, “This is my Son—the Beloved! My greatest delight is in him.” (Matthew 3:13–17 TPT)

When Jesus went to John the Baptist to be baptized, he was demonstrating that his teaching and John’s teaching about living and having a relationship with God were the same truth. He was identifying with John’s message, saying we are from the same Father.

Peter also taught that Christians should be baptized.

They asked Peter and the other apostles, “Friends, what should we do?”

Peter said to them, “Turn to God and be baptized, every one of you, in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins, and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit.” (Acts 2:37–38 CEV)

The act of baptism does not make you a follower of Christ; rather, it tells the world you are a follower of Christ. When you became a follower of Jesus, you changed your mind. You repented of the way you were living and decided to follow Christ instead of the world. You decided to follow Christ instead of culture, to follow Christ instead of what is cool. Since you have already made that decision, it is only natural to follow him in baptism like billions of others who have followed Christ over the course of two thousand years. It is publicly displaying, “I’m with him!”

God wants us to trust him and obey him for many things for the rest of our lives. Baptism is a simple act of obedience that gets your habit of trusting and obeying started really easily and with so many people celebrating with you. Baptism is a conscious choice of obedience while displaying to the world, “I was dead; that old self is staying under the water, and new life has been poured into my heart with the love and forgiveness of Christ!” You will find that for the rest of your life, simple acts of obedience to Christ’s words will bring amazing freedom and a fresh encounter with him every time you do it.

How Do You Know If You’re Ready to Be Baptized?

Ask yourself a few questions:

- *Have I given my life to Jesus and decided to follow him for the rest of my life?*
- *Do I eagerly want to become more like him?*
- *Am I ready to identify that I belong to Jesus and to let the whole world know in a public way that I am a follower of Christ?*

Talk to your connect group leader and your pastor now about when you might be able to be baptized. What a fantastic celebration it will be!

Endnotes

- 1 *Merriam-Webster Dictionary*, s.v. “perseverance,” accessed November 19, 2024, <https://www.merriam-webster.com>.
- 2 Daniel Pearce, “Examining High School Sweethearts and Their Likelihood of Divorce,” *Men’s Divorce*, accessed August 15, 2024, <https://mensdivorce.com>.
- 3 “Born Again Christians Just as Likely to Divorce as Are Non-Christians,” *Barna*, September 8, 2004, <https://www.barna.com>.
- 4 Kristin McCarthy, “Blended Family Statistics: A Deeper Look into the Structure,” *Love to Know*, last updated August 5, 2021, <https://www.lovetoknow.com>.
- 5 Philip Schaff, *The New Schaff-Herzog Encyclopedia of Religious Knowledge*, ed. Samuel Macauley Jackson, vol. 9: *Petri-Reuchlin* (Baker Books, 1953; Christian Classics Ethereal Library, n.d.), PDF, 1134–36, <https://www.ccel.org>.

Authors' Note

As you continue your adventure with Christ, we encourage you to pray this over yourself each day as you begin a fresh pursuit of his reality every morning.

Disciple's prayer:

I am a follower of Jesus Christ, the Savior of the world, and today I will be seeking his kingdom. May it intervene in every activity I have. I am renewing the way I think in every dimension of life so that I can be transformed to live more like Christ today. I am connecting with other disciples to help propel me in my quest, and today I will engage the Father, the creator of the universe, because I know he cares about every hair on my head.

After you complete this book, please email us at ronluce100@gmail.com and describe what the Lord has done in your life and with your connect group.

About the Authors



Ron and Katie Luce have spent their lives helping younger generations genuinely connect with Jesus and thrive in their faith. They have hosted millions of young people at live conferences across North America and now help church leaders all over the planet dramatically grow their churches by reaching and discipling the next generation. See www.generationnext.me for more information.